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BY

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Hon'ble Deputy Chief Minister, Bihar

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DATE: 25 JULY, 2026



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PHOTO COURTESY: SHRI SAMRAT CHAUDHARY

Russian missile strike kills 10 after Zelenskyy hosts US defence firm

Associated Press
Kyiv, July 24

A RUSSIAN attack Friday a site near Kyiv that was hosting a defence industry event killed at least 10 people and wounded nearly 100, Ukrainian government and industry officials said. The ballistic missile strike came a day after Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy met in Kyiv with senior representatives of Raytheon, the U.S. company that makes the Patriot air defense systems that Ukraine desperately needs to counter the devastating ballistic missiles Russia uses to advance its invasion. Raytheon didn't immediately respond to an email inquiring whether any of its workers were at the event. "Missiles for Patriot systems are the number one priority," Zelenskyy said on social media, where he reported the attack. The strike hit the grounds of a privately operated military training site that was hosting an



The site of Russian missile strikes in Kyiv on Friday, Reuters

China imposes export controls on 14 EU entities over Russia sanctions

Associated Press
Beijing, July 24

CHINA ANNOUNCED Friday it was adding 14 European entities to an export control list in retaliation for the European Union penalizing 14 Chinese enterprises as part of its latest round of sanctions against Russia. Chinese companies will not be allowed to export dual-use items, which can be used for both civilian and military purposes, to the 14 European organizations, China's Commerce Ministry said in a statement. Additionally, foreign companies are barred from providing to the 14 entities dual-use items made in China. The European companies affected include Czech vehicle manufacturer Tatra Trucks, Italian electric motor maker Lafert SpA, German manufacturer Sindhuauser Materials GmbH and French drone manufacturer Cavok UAS. A Chinese Commerce Ministry spokesperson said the measures were taken in retaliation for the EU on Thursday adding 14 mainland Chinese and Hong Kong enterprises to its latest list of sanctions against Russia over its war in Ukraine. The measures are intended "to safeguard national security and interests, and to fulfill international obligations such as non-proliferation, in response to the EU's egregious actions," the spokesperson said.

UNESCO adds West Bank site, Lebanese castles to Heritage List

Associated Press
Seoul, July 24

UNITED NATIONS committee voted Friday to inscribe a major archaeological site in the West Bank and a set of castles in southern Lebanon as World Heritage sites, despite objections from Israel, which had urged the committee to reject the bids. The decision at a UN Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization meeting in South Korea came days after Israel's Foreign Ministry urged committee to reject efforts to designate the small West Bank town of Amel as recognized for their layered architectural heritage, combining Crusader, Ayyubid, Mamluk and local influences, reflecting the evolution of fortified architecture over nine centuries, as per UNESCO description.

mittee decided to place Sebastia and five castles in Lebanon's Mount Amel area on both the World Heritage List and the List of World Heritage in Danger after reviewing the nominations on an emergency basis, citing ongoing conflicts in West Asia. Sebastia, a hilltop town about 10 kilometers (6 miles) northwest of Nablus in the Israeli-occupied West Bank, is identified by scholars as ancient Samaria, capital of the biblical Kingdom of Israel. The five castles in Mount Amel are recognized for their layered architectural heritage, combining Crusader, Ayyubid, Mamluk and local influences, reflecting the evolution of fortified architecture over nine centuries, as per UNESCO description.

U.S. MISSILES HIT QESHM ISLAND AND SITES IN GILAN ON IRAN'S CASPIAN COAST

Drones target US bases in Iraq as tensions escalates

Tehran says it also attacked US bases in Kuwait, Bahrain & Jordan

Associated Press
Irbil, July 24

DRONES CARRYING explosives targeted a city in northern Iraq where US forces are stationed, and sirens rang out in Bahrain on Friday, hours after the American military said it finished its 13th night of strikes against Iran. The conflict has flared again over the past week, as the US pounded Iran while Tehran attacked ships in the Strait of Hormuz and targeted US assets and allies in the region. The Strait, which is a crucial passage for the world's energy supplies, is at the centre of the latest fighting since Iranian attacks on a US ship in the Persian Gulf, sending fuel prices soaring worldwide and causing widespread economic turmoil. The Iranian-allied Houthis added further pressure this week by targeting two Saudi tankers in the Red Sea, making good on a threat to cut off an alternative route for the region's oil. Despite the war's unpopularity and its widespread damage to Iran and the global economy - the latest round of fighting has no clear off-ramp. The Iranian Health Ministry



Iran Parliament Speaker Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf with Iraqi Prime Minister Ali al-Zaidi in Tehran, on Thursday, Reuters

says 3,434 people have been killed since the war began. The US and Israel attacked Iran on Feb. 28 and have offered shifting goals for the war, including toppling Tehran's government and eliminating its nuclear programme. But the conflict has devolved into a fight for control of the Strait with Iran apparently hoping to win concessions by inflicting damage on the global economy. US-led forces shot down five explosive-laden drones Friday over Irbil, according to security officials in northern Iraq. No injuries or damage were reported. Flights continued as normal at the airport, the state-run Iraqi News Agency reported, citing the facility's director. US military officials in Iraq did not respond to a request for comment. A small contingent of US

Trump warns China, Russia not to join war

Washington: US President Donald Trump said Friday he does not believe China or Russia are "participating" in the ongoing Iran conflict, but warned that if they did get involved "it would be very bad for them." "President Xi, at our recent meeting in Beijing, China, told me that he would not, under any circumstances, give or sell Weapons to the Islamic Republic of Iran - And that statement included Chinese Companies," he wrote on Truth Social. Trump said Putin had also told him that he would not sell weapons to Iran and that he believed Russia and China were not participating in the Iran conflict. "If they did, it would be very bad for them - Certainly not in their best interests," Trump posted. REUTERS

ern Iran, the semi-official news outlets Fars and ISNA reported. Blasts from US bombardment overnight were also reported over Iran's Qeshm Island, a base for naval assets including drone boats that Iran can use to attack vessels in Strait of Hormuz, as well as in Isfahan province, home to a major Iranian air base and Iran's nuclear sites.

• BRIEFLY

UNITED KINGDOM

Singer Chris Brown pleads guilty over bottle attack at London bar



Chris Brown arrives at Southwark Crown Court in London on Friday, AP

GRAMMY-WINNING singer Chris Brown pleaded guilty Friday to brawling at a London nightclub in 2023, a fight in which he hit a music producer over the head with a bottle. Brown, 37, made the change of plea during a hearing at London's Southwark Crown Court. He had earlier denied more serious charges over what prosecutors called a "vicious attack." In return for the guilty plea, prosecutors dropped charges of assault, attempting to cause grievous bodily harm and having an offensive weapon, a bottle. AP

VIETNAM

Govt plans to ban kids from posting on social media

VIETNAM IS planning to force social media platforms to ban users under 16 from posting content, commenting or reacting to posts, according to a draft decree reviewed by Reuters. The rules would require accounts be verified for children under 16 to be registered using the information of a parent or legal guardian responsible for supervision. REUTERS

IRELAND

Police intercept car bomb near Northern Ireland

AN "EXTREMELY significant" car bomb was intercepted earlier this week near the Northern Ireland border during a probe of disident republicans, Irish police said Friday. A woman arrested in her 20s was arrested Wednesday near County Monaghan and remained in custody Friday. A man in his 40s was later detained and continues to be held. AP

• NEIGHBOURHOOD WATCH

PAKISTAN

15 troops killed in attack on police outpost in KPK

AT LEAST 15 personnel, including 12 soldiers, were killed in an attack on a joint police checkpoint in Pakistan's Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province, the military's media wing said on Friday. The ISPR said attack in Tank district was carried out by the Fitna-al-Khawarij early on Friday. PTI

SRI LANKA

El Niño may arrive early, warnings issued

SRI LANKA is likely to face severe dry weather till September, followed by heavy rainfall till December as El Niño could hit the island nation earlier than expected, warned Environment Minister Dhammika Patabandana on Thursday. This will likely cause economic hardships, and job losses. PTI

Merz reshuffles top posts to counter far-right surge

Associated Press
Berlin, July 24

GERMAN CHANCELLOR Friedrich Merz reshuffled top posts on Friday as he tried to boost the fortunes of his deeply unpopular government ahead of elections in which a far-right party could get its first state governor. Merz took office less than 15 months ago with pledges to reform and turn around Germany's economy, Europe's biggest, after years of stagnation. But that economic turnaround

has been slow to start. And the middle-of-the-road coalition of Merz's center-right Union bloc and the center-left Social Democrats, two traditional rivals, has yet to persuade voters that it can produce results. That has resulted in Merz's popularity sinking to rock-bottom levels, while the far-right Alternative for Germany, or AfD, has gained support on the back of discontent. Merz took the opportunity to make a series of changes after a senior ally quit as the leader of



Chancellor Friedrich Merz

his bloc's parliamentary group over personal conduct that undermined his credibility.

Merz plans to put his chief of staff, Thorsten Frei, in that job. The German leader said Health Minister Nina Warlen will take Frei's place at the chancellery, a post that is key to the smooth functioning of the government. She will be the first woman to take that job. Another close ally, Carsten Linnemann, the general secretary of Merz's Christian Democratic Union party, will become health minister. Merz said there will be further Cabinet changes, but didn't offer details. He said

decisions will take "a few days yet, and perhaps more time." "The personnel changes follow a clear line," he said. "We want a government that works with great vigor and pleasure and also represents the personal diversity of our society and politics. We are a reform government and want to continue showing that." In the eastern region of Saxony-Anhalt AfD is hopeful of winning a majority that would give it control of a state government for the first time.



Knightly Knockout

Two fighters clash with swords and shields during the International Medieval Combat Federation's World Championship at Spotttrup Castle in Denmark on Thursday. Competitors from 30 countries are taking part in the tournament, which recreates medieval combat with 14th-century weapons under modern safety rules. AP

Tens of thousands evacuated as wildfires sweep France, Spain

Reuters
Madrid, Paris, July 24

TENS OF thousands of people fled wildfires in southwest France by car and boat on Friday and Spain declared a national emergency as huge blazes merged outside Madrid and searing heat left tinder-dry conditions across the region. French authorities ordered total evacuation of the Cap Ferret peninsula, a tourism hotspot on its Atlantic Coast. Two fires merged outside Madrid, and a third was on the verge of joining them, government officials said. Both countries, which have suffered a succession of heatwaves and fires in recent months and years that scientists say have been exacerbated by climate change, sought help from the EU



Smoke and flames rise as a wildfire advances near La Adrada, Ávila province, Spain, on Friday, AP

as the blazes strained emergency services. Spain's national emergency - the first it had ever declared over a wildfire - opened up federal funding to tackle the crisis. "This is the worst wildfire in our region's history," Madrid's regional leader Isabel Diaz Ayuso said. "It's the perfect storm of very high temperatures and ceaseless winds that aren't letting up." In southwest France, authorities sent boats to help the evacuation and a total of about 63,000 people were told to get out as two separate fires threatened homes.

Bangladesh President Shahabuddin, a close ally of Hasina, resigns

Press Trust of India
Dhaka, July 24

BANGLADESH PRESIDENT Mohammed Shahabuddin, a former ally of deposed prime minister Sheikh Hasina, resigned on Friday, two years ahead of the end of his tenure. "I am suffering from various health complications," the 76-year-old leader was quoted as saying by The Daily Star newspaper. He was responding to a question about the reason for his resignation. Bangabhaban - the president's house - spokesman told PTI Shahabuddin's representatives have left his office for the parliament carrying his resignation letter. The resignation letter would be submitted to parliamentary Speaker Hafizuddin Ahmed, who would serve as Acting President in accordance with the Bangladesh Constitution until a new President is elected. "I can't make any official comment on the resignation until the Speaker receives the



Mohammed Shahabuddin, FILE

letter," the spokesman said. His resignation comes amid speculations that Prime Minister Tarique Rahman's government was uncomfortable with the largely titular head of the state, according to media reports. A 1971 Liberation War veteran and former lower judiciary judge, Shahabuddin had taken the oath in April 2023 for a five-year term. He was elected to the highest office by the previous parliament and is the only person still holding his constitutional position, long after the violent 2024 student-led street protest that toppled Hasina's Awami League government.

• LIGHTERS ARE SHARED BY DOZENS OF FAMILIES, PASSED FROM TENT TO TENT UNTIL THEY BREAK FROM CONSTANT USE

In Gaza's tent camps, a cigarette lighter becomes a lifeline

Haseeb Alwazir & Nidal Al-Mughhrabi
Cairo, Gaza, July 24

IN THE sprawling tent camps of southern Gaza, a disposable cigarette lighter has become an unlikely luxury item, as essential to daily survival as food, water and fuel. For displaced mother-of-four Nisreen Abu Saada, lighting a cooking fire can be a daily struggle in a territory where gas remains scarce and families rely on burning cardboard, plastic and scraps of wood to prepare meals. "There's no gas, and we're lighting fires 24 hours a day, which means a lighter is very essential," she told Reuters. Before her war, three lighters

cost one shekel (\$0.33). Now, a single lighter costs 100 shekels (\$32.55), something Abu Saada, 38, cannot afford. She was sitting beside a makeshift cooking area outside her tent in Khan Younis. Nearly three years in the Gaza war, shortages of basic goods have transformed every daily objects into prized possessions. Lighters are shared among dozens of families, passed from tent to tent before breaking under constant use. "When I want to light a fire, I wait for someone else to light one, or I go to where someone has lit a fire, take a piece of cardboard, light it, and bring it back," Abu Saada said. The scarcity has created a niche trade for Hassan Abu



Palestinian repairman Hassan Abu Latifa tests a repaired lighter at his kiosk in Khan Younis, southern Gaza Strip, on Thursday, Reuters

Latifa, a displaced father of three who repairs broken plastic lighters at a small kiosk. "Repairing lighters is not really a profession, but because of the suffering, people's need for them, and our need to work, we were compelled to take it up as one," said the 35-year-old, who worked as an agricultural

engineer before the war. Surrounded by boxes of damaged lighters and salvaged spare parts, Abu Latifa said soaring prices have forced families to repair lighters rather than replace them. The war has devastated Gaza's economy. UN agencies say unemployment in Gaza exceeds 80%, while poverty has approached 100% after the conflict wiped out most economic activity and destroyed infrastructure across the enclave. A US-brokered ceasefire in October halted major fighting but failed to end attacks by Israel, which says it has targeted Hamas and other Gaza militants posing an imminent threat. Hamas blames Israeli attacks

and border restrictions for the lack of progress to reach a broad agreement to end the conflict. Aid levels remain disputed. The Hamas-run Gaza government media offices say supplies entering have fallen far short of needs, while COGAT, the Israeli military body responsible for humanitarian affairs says food deliveries have exceeded World Food Programme requirements. For Iftikhar al-Kafarna, a displaced mother-of-six who bakes bread in a traditional oven to earn money, the small tool has become critical to her livelihood. "If there is a lighter, there is life. If not, the work stops, and I can sit for three or four hours without work," she said. REUTERS



The Indian EXPRESS

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NEW DELHI, LATE CITY, 24 PAGES

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Happening today

● **A CENTRAL GOVERNMENT** team will visit flood-hit Assam to review the rapidly deteriorating situation. The deluge has so far killed 47 people and affected over 7.21 lakh people across 11 districts in the state.

● **THE WEST BENGAL** government will table all pending Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) reports in the state Assembly and recommend registration of FIRs wherever the audit findings establish corruption.

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SC bars court hearing clips on social media without approval



Direction by three-judge bench led by CJI Surya Kant

Ananthkrishnan G
New Delhi, July 24

IN AN interim order Friday, the Supreme Court barred the recording and circulation of courtroom proceedings without prior permission of the court concerned. It concerns over alleged misuse on social media but clarified that the curb will not affect news reporting. A three-judge bench, led by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, said, "As an interim measure, we direct that there shall be no posting, reposting, extraction, modification, dissemination, monetisation, recording or review of the live-streamed proceedings of this court on social media or any other digital platform without the prior permission of the concerned registrar and the secretary general of this court and registrar general of high courts."

Directing the secretary general of the Supreme Court and registrar general of high courts to display this order on their court websites, the bench said, "This order shall have no bearing on news reporting."

The bench, also comprising Justice Joydipya Bagchi and Justice V Mohana, was hearing a PIL by journalist Harshita Grover highlighting "increasing misuse of audiovisual recordings of judicial proceedings through selective clipping, editing, decontextualised

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POLITICS PAGE 5

CJI COCKROACH REMARKS ONLY FOR FAKE LAW DEGREE HOLDERS

BILL LIKELY IN PARLIAMENT MONDAY; PM THANKS PEOPLE FOR 'POSITIVE SUGGESTIONS'

Jail up to 10 years, Rs 10-cr fine for exam leak: Nod for tough new law

Statutory backing for fast-track courts, 5 months for probe, trial

Damini Nath, Harikrishnan Sharma & Jatin Anand
New Delhi, July 24

A DAY after Prime Minister Narendra Modi announced fast-track courts and a tough new law to punish those involved in exam paper leaks, the Union Cabinet Friday approved a draft Bill with provisions for a jail term up to 10 years, penalty up to Rs 10 crore, statutory backing for fast-track courts and a five-month time frame for investigation and trial of cases, official sources said.

Hours later, in an Instagram post, Modi thanked everyone for the responses and positive suggestions received on his Thursday midnight video in which he announced the government's decision.

"Thank you, friends. I got the opportunity to talk to you at midnight. The way you have responded to my video, positive suggestions given by you, thanks to everybody. Your love will continue to flow, our relations will continue with more bonding. Thank you, thank you friends," he said in the new video message.

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Union Ministers J P Nadda and Jitendra Singh with CJP's Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka, Friday. ANI

Pradhan resignation non-negotiable, says CJP; more talks today: Centre

Sophiya Mathew & Liz Mathew
New Delhi, July 24

REPRESENTATIVES OF the Cockroach Janta Party, spearheading the protest at Jantar Mantar over examination paper leaks, told the Centre Friday that their key demands for the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, compensation for the families of students who ended

THE BIG PICTURE

Meet the protesters: Young, angry and very Gen Z PAGE 9

their lives following the NEET paper leak, and no legal action

against the protesters were not negotiable.

Union Minister J P Nadda, who along with his colleague Jitendra Singh met CJP spokespersons Ashutosh Ranka and Saurav Das for nearly two hours at the Constitution Club of India, not far from the protest site, told reporters that the CJP demands and suggestions had been noted and there would be another meeting Saturday afternoon.

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Using discarded wrappers, cops trace outlets sending food to Jantar Mantar

Aanchal Magazine & Soumyarendra Barik
New Delhi, July 24

USING DISCARDED wrappers and packaging from the Jantar Mantar protest site, Delhi Police is allegedly tracking down restaurants and cafes and asking them to stop supplying free food or making bulk deliveries to the venue.

The owners of several cafes and restaurants told *The Indian Express* that Delhi Police officers visited them and went through the records of the orders placed and the deliveries made over the last few days. Some eateries were asked to furnish proof of the paid orders, including bulk deliveries, as well as the food sent by the outlets for free. Some restaurants and cafes claimed they were also summoned to police stations.

The owner of a restaurant, which has supplied 800 pieces of food items daily on an average to Jantar Mantar over the last three days, said Delhi Police officers reached their South Delhi store Thursday, enquiring about those running it and asking why its food was available at

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Business as Usual

By EP UNNAY



Why those new bills when nobody is paying for anything?

officials to send a "strong message". These are "only the initial steps" in reforming the functioning of the agency, and "several more stringent and reform-oriented measures" are likely to follow, the sources said.

In a separate statement signalling wider reforms within the NTA, the Education Ministry said it has issued advertisements for the appointment of senior professionals at the level

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BEYOND SONAM: PROTEST SHOWS NO SIGNS OF ABATING

2024 ANTI-PAPER LEAK ACT: HOW THE HOUSE PASSED IT

NTA sacks 47 officials, Govt starts recruitment for reform overhaul

Four General Managers and 16 young professionals to be engaged: Ministry

Vikas Pathak
New Delhi, July 24

IN A sweeping internal crack-down following the NEET-UG paper leak and amid protests led by the Cockroach Janta Party, the National Testing Agency (NTA), which is the

nodal autonomous body that conducts entrance tests to higher educational institutions, has "terminated the services" of 47 officials, sources told *The Indian Express*.

Sources said the agency would also initiate "legal and criminal action" against the of-

EXPRESS special

Lawyer who fought Wangchuk's NSA case, three days of talks: The nudge that convinced activist to end fast



Sonom Wangchuk with wife Gitanjali J Angmo and MPs Vivek Tankha, Sagarkia Ghose and John Brittas at Medanta Hospital, Gurgaon. ANI

Deepthiman Tiwary
New Delhi, July 24

THREE DAYS of negotiations, the government softening its stand, and intervention by Sonam Wangchuk's lawyer and leaders from Ladakh driven by concerns about his health. That's what it took to nudge the activist, the face of the ongoing Jantar Mantar protests, to reconsider his position and break his fast late on Thursday night.

Sources said the government began making attempts to reach out to Wangchuk by the evening of July 20 when the protests ran into lathi charges and tear gas fired by the police during the march to Parliament. It is learnt that Vivek Tankha who was among the lawyers who fought Wangchuk's National Security Act (NSA) case in the Supreme Court — and is known to be close to the activist — played a

significant role in persuading him to end the fast. A source said Tankha's intervention was driven purely by his concern for Wangchuk's failing health due to the prolonged hunger strike. "He had lost more than 11 kg and those around him were concerned," the source said. Sources said that after speaking to Tankha, who is a Congress MP, Wangchuk issued an open letter to Nadda in

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SECTION 301 FORCED LABOUR PROBE

India attracts 10% US tariff, lower rate after policy shift

12.5 per cent for Vietnam, China: Trump administration redraws tariff architecture

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, July 24

THE US Friday imposed 10% tariffs on India, lower than the 12.5% rate proposed in March when the United States Trade Representative (USTR) identified 60 countries under Section 301 of the US Trade Act, citing import of goods produced with forced labour.

This comes weeks after the Directorate General of Foreign Trade (DGFT) announced prohibition of import of goods produced using forced labour, along with parallel negotiations for a trade deal with the US.

In the new tariff regime enforced Friday, the European Union and Taiwan received the most favourable rates — the Section 301 tariff is applied on goods from these two economies only if the product's existing most favoured nation (MFN) tariff is less than 10%. If

E. EXPLAINED

Bar on import of forced-labour goods

Ahead of the US tariffs, India barred the import of goods made using forced labour. On July 13, the Directorate General of Foreign Trade had inserted a new paragraph in the Foreign Trade Policy regarding 'forced labour', stating that import of goods produced or manufactured, 'wholly or in part', through the use of forced labour is 'prohibited'.

the product from the EU or Taiwan already has an MFN tariff of 10% or higher, the Section 301 tariff is zero.

India has been placed in the

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HC: OpenAI's use of copyrighted material to train ChatGPT 'fair'

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, July 24

THE DELHI High Court has held that OpenAI's training of its large language models (LLMs) on original retrieved copyrighted works constituted fair dealing, and did not amount to infringement of copyright.

The interim ruling Friday by Justice Amit Bansal extends a measure of legal cover to developers of artificial intelligence (AI) chatbots such as OpenAI to continue training on Indian-origin content without licensing agreements, and also interprets broadly what constitutes "fair use" of copyrighted works.

The suit, the first of its kind in Indian jurisdiction, was moved by news agency ANI Media Pvt Ltd in 2024 against OpenAI Inc and OpenAI OpCo LLC, seeking an injunction against the use of

its copyrighted content in the training of LLMs.

California-based OpenAI is the developer of the ChatGPT series of generative AI models. OpenAI OpCo LLC is the commercial arm of the organisation.

"...in my prima facie view, OpenAI's acts of storage of the literary works of ANI for the training of its LLMs would fall under Section 52(1)(a) of the Copyright Act (fair dealing) and hence, would not amount to infringement," Justice Bansal ruled.

He took into consideration that OpenAI's use of the copyrighted works for training its LLMs is "completely an internal process" and does not involve providing the copyrighted material to any third party.

"I am also of the prima facie view that the outputs generated

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● ELECTORAL ROLL REVISION IN SOME OF STATE'S MOST INACCESSIBLE VILLAGES

Rivers rising, BLOs in Punjab's border areas take boats to meet SIR deadline

Kanchan Vasdev
Chandigarh, July 24

FOR MOST Booth Level Officers (BLOs), revising electoral rolls means walking from one house to another with forms in hand. For some in Punjab's remote border belt, it has meant rowing across rivers, waiting out floodwaters and, on occasion, relying on Army boats to return home.

As the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls gathers pace, BLOs posted in some of Punjab's most inaccessible villages have been navigating swollen rivers and flood-prone terrain to ensure

that even the state's last voters, living on the edge of the India-Pakistan border, are not left out. In Gurdaspur district, Vikram Singh's workday begins on a road boat on the Ravi. To reach Bharyal village, he boards a small country boat at Makaura PATTAN, near the confluence of the Ravi and Ujh rivers. Villagers ferry him across to a settlement, relying on Army boats to return home.

"With rains lashing Jammu and Kashmir and the river getting into spate, it becomes difficult. I had to go daily. I wanted to finish my work before the monsoon. I have been able to

identify 60 per cent of the voters. It was not an easy task," Singh told *The Indian Express*, adding that SIR is still underway.

Bharyal, which has 369 voters, is inundated almost every year. Many of its residents temporarily move to 15 neighbouring villages during the flood season.

"I had to map each one of them. Like today, it is raining and I cannot go," Singh said.

Bharyal and neighbouring Toorvillage, covered under Polling Station Nos. 1 and 2 of the Dinanagar (SC) Assembly constituency, are among Punjab's most isolated habitations. Pakistan lies on one side, the Ravi



BLOs Pushpa Grover and Darshan Singh cross the Sutlej on a boat to reach Kaluwalla village in Punjab's Ferozepur district. EXPRESS

on the other, while the international border is barely 5 kilometres away.

Of Punjab's 12,500 villages, 50 are considered remote because they are located along the

international border and have poor road connectivity.

For part of the year, a temporary pontoon bridge connects the villages with the mainland. During monsoon, the bridge is dismantled as the river swells, leaving boats as the only means of transport.

"These villages are cut off during monsoons but that doesn't happen every year," one official said.

Gurdaspur alone has 15 such villages. "The Ajnala, Dharamkot and Bhoja Assembly segments also have such remote villages," Tript Rajinder Singh Bajwa, Congress MLA from Fatehgarh Churian in Gurdaspur, told *The Indian Express*.

For BLOs, this means crossing the swelling river multiple times during the exercise — from house-to-house enumeration and mapping, and following rounds that involve revisiting locked houses and identifying ineligible voters, to sitting at local polling booths to process forms.

Singh recalled one such day when a routine visit nearly turned into a rescue operation.

"The water level was manageable when I went to Bharyal. But by the time I had to return, flash floods in Rajouri had affected the river here too. Then the Army boat helped us come back," he said.

"When the river is in spate,

village boats stop operating because it becomes risky. The Army takes over with boats, life jackets and all necessary arrangements."

He said residents had urged authorities to keep the pontoon bridge in place this year, but rising water levels made that impossible.

Boat to Kaluwalla

Nearly 150 km away, a similar story is unfolding in Ferozepur district.

Kaluwalla village, under Polling Station No. 7 of the Ferozepur Urban Assembly constituency, is often called Punjab's island village. Encircled by the

• CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Bhagwat: Knowledge on Hindu gods should be part of school textbooks

Divya A
New Delhi, July 24

RSS CHIEF Mohan Bhagwat on Friday battled for inclusion of knowledge on Hindu gods in school textbooks.

Addressing a programme organised by the RSS on the topic of 'Contemporary Motherhood', he said that the new generation seeks logic in everything, and believes in discussion, not dictation. "Sometimes, children ask these questions, especially abroad, why this god with a monkey face and why does this god have an elephant face? They come home and ask these questions but the father doesn't know, the mother doesn't know. This should be part of textbooks, even as children can't be left to textbooks alone," he said.

At the beginning of his address, he said, "Being asked to speak on the subject of motherhood, in itself, a contradiction... In a way, it is women's right, and it is not appropriate for men to speak about it." Even as he said that today everyone thinks more as an individual than as part of society, which leads to disintegration, he advocated that women of today must be given opportunities and empowered.

The audience — largely women and several male Sangh functionaries and BJP leaders — also included Union Women and Child Development Minister Annapurna Devi and Rajasthan Deputy CM Dhanraj Kumar sitting in the front row along with BJP MPs Kangana Ranaut, Swati Malival and Bansuri Swaraj; besides Mallika Nadra and Lakshmi Puri, spouses of Union ministers J P Nadra and Har-



RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat at an event in Delhi, Friday. ANI SHARMA

deep Puri, respectively. BJP veteran Murlu Manohar Joshi, who had a day earlier, expressed concern over the students' protests and handling of the youth, was also present at the event.

Bhagwat said, "Being in accordance with the times is also a subject of motherhood that does not require discussion. It happens on its own. Human beings change all their ways according to time." However, he said that "since the focus of the family unit is the mother, she ought to be 'sanskari' and 'vichaarshil' (visionary)." "It is the mother's role to shape the perspective of her children, and not only their career," he said.

He said parents should spend more time with their families and maintain open communication with children. He stressed that children learn more through observation than instruction, making it important for parents to lead by example. He said parents should continue to expand their knowledge so they can address their children's questions and curiosity. The three-hour event, organised by Vishwa Mangalya Sabha, also had the RSS chief interacting with women leaders in a brief question and hour session. The next session will be held in Hyderabad later this month.

MEA pushes back on Wang's remark attributed to Jaishankar

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, July 24

TWO DAYS after China claimed that External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar had told Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi that India's positions on issues concerning Taiwan and Xizang (Tibet) have not changed, and that India respects China's sovereignty, Delhi pushed back on Friday, clarifying that what Jaishankar actually said was "when it comes to sovereignty issues, it is actually India that should be and is raising them."

Jaishankar and Wang met in Manila, the Philippines, on July 22 on the sidelines of the ASEAN and East Asia foreign ministers meeting, where the Indian minister had underlined that "peace and tranquillity in the border areas" is the prerequisite for normal ties — the prerequisite for normal ties — Delhi's position on the border standoff for the last six years.

The Chinese Foreign Ministry returned in state-run news agency Xinhua had said, "Jaishankar said that India's positions on issues concerning Taiwan and Xizang have not changed, and India respects China's sovereignty."

Responding to questions

about the readout, the MEA's official spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said, "Yes, External Affairs Minister said that when it comes to sovereignty issues, it is actually India that should be and is raising them. India does not violate China's sovereignty in any manner and has been consistent. But China is in illegal occupation of Indian territory in Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh since 1963, where India's right is officially acknowledged even by China. Also, there are Chinese projects on territories in Jammu and Kashmir that belong to India, and we object to that."

On July 22, Jaishankar had said, "Peace and tranquillity in the border areas is obviously the prerequisite for normal ties. Since October 2024, both sides have engaged to ensure that the important objective. This will continue to need our constant attention. Relevant mechanisms in this domain must be given full support and strong encouragement." This was a reference to the India-China agreement on disengagement, after a four-year border standoff in eastern Ladakh, which was agreed in October 2024 and completed in November 2024.

New law

The Cabinet, sources said, approved a proposal to amend The Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024. Under Section 10 of the Act, the punishment for individuals resorting to unfair means is imprisonment for three to five years and a fine up to Rs 10 lakh. Section 11 provides for imprisonment of five to 10 years and a fine of at least Rs 1 crore for those involved in organised crime.

CJP-Govt

The meeting took place hours after activist Sonam Wangchuk, who had backed the CJP demands, ended his 26-day hunger strike Thursday night at Medanta Hospital in Gurgaon in the presence of Nadra and Singh. Ranks said, "The government has asked for time until tomorrow afternoon on our demand for Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation. We hope the government will remove him soon."

He said there was "in-principle approval" from the government on the demands relating to compensation and the withdrawal of FIRs and legal cases against students.

The CJP also sought a public apology from the Centre, the head of the Rapid Action Force and the Delhi Police Commissioner to their five-point charter

soner to students assaulted during the protests.

Nadra said, "Today, we had come here to discuss the issues of the agitating people, and the conversation lasted for almost two hours. From the government's side, Dr. Jitendra Singh, I and I participated in the conversation. We listened to their points. The discussions took place in a cordial atmosphere, and from many perspectives. All matters were thoroughly discussed in every way."

"Their main demands were three, and from the perspective of reforms, there were five suggestions for the examination. We have told them that we will meet with you again tomorrow afternoon, and then whatever further discussion or conversation takes place, we will inform you about it," he said.

The CJP representatives also sought a response from the Centre to their five-point charter

that we received through online platforms like Swiggy and Zomato, and then told us that our orders should raise red flags for us and we shouldn't service them. Since then, almost every one in our family has advised us not to send food to the protests, and I guess that's the police's whole point, to create that kind of an intimidating environment," the owners said.

Apart from volunteers bringing and distributing free food at Jantar Mantar since the protest started on June 20, supporters have spread across India and overseas have been sending meals, snacks and bottled water through delivery apps. Many local eateries also sent free food to the protest site, besides posting social media announcements offering "a place to pause,

paper leak cases will be fast-tracked and will be taken to conclusion within five months, the sources said.

The fast-track courts to be set up for such cases would be given statutory backing through the Bill, the sources said.

The existing law that came into effect on June 21, 2024 aimed to curb leaks, malpractices in the fast-track courts would be set up in the High Courts of Bombay, Calcutta, Delhi and Madhya Pradesh where cases pertaining to the NEET paper leak are ongoing.

Any such move, a source said, could set a new precedent. "The government cannot be seen as succumbing to pressure from protesting forces or groups. Tomorrow, another group may come up and demand the resignation of others," the sources said.

Another source said the government is independent technology audits of examination systems. No punitive measures against protesting students. The government, the source said, is also ready to look into ways to compensate families of NEET aspirants who died by suicide following the paper leak.

The government will look at the rules and procedure for providing compensation in these circumstances. DMs have been asked to look at the details of each family. The government has to see it does not create any wrong precedent... It should withstand judicial scrutiny too," the source said.

hibitory orders under Section 163 BNS, 2023, citizens are advised to avoid unnecessary travel to the notified area and use alternate routes wherever possible.

App-based mobility, ride-hailing, food delivery, logistics and e-commerce platforms are advised to regulate operations in the restricted area for the duration of the prohibitory order to support public safety and maintain law & order."

In another post on X, Delhi Police said: "Rumours are circulating on social media claiming that Delhi Police has imposed a ban on food delivery app services across the New Delhi area. This claim is completely false, baseless, and misleading. Delhi Police has not imposed any ban on food delivery services in the New Delhi area."

However, in a "traffic advisory" posted on X, Delhi Traffic Police said: "In view of the pro-

Selection and the National Testing Agency which, among others, conducts the NEET exam.

Sources said the amendment Bill is likely to be brought in Parliament Monday, as announced by the Prime Minister Thursday.

Earlier Thursday, Law and Justice Minister Arjun Ram Dasgupta said the fast-track courts would be set up in the High Courts of Bombay, Calcutta, Delhi and Madhya Pradesh where cases pertaining to the NEET paper leak are ongoing.

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deal with paper leaks.

Sources said that while Wangchuk was hesitant to end the hunger strike, his wife told him that he had to keep his word to the government. "His wife finally persuaded him to end the fast," said a minister.

Sources close to Wangchuk said his decision was entirely informed by his concern for the well-being of protesters who he felt could face serious legal trouble in future. Sources said Wangchuk was likely to stay in the hospital for the next few days to complete his recovery. He is likely to meet youth leaders at Jantar Mantar before going back to Ladakh.

In parallel, civil society leaders from Ladakh arrived in Delhi from Leh on July 21. Their attempts to meet Wangchuk were unsuccessful on July 21 and 22. On July 23, however, the leaders were allowed to meet Wangchuk in the morning, according to the government's Intelligence Bureau official.

The Ladakh leaders too urged Wangchuk to end his fast. "By the time we met him, an understanding had already been reached between the government and him about ending his fast. We need him in Ladakh to support our own negotiations with the government on issues concerning our region," a leader in the Ladakh delegation told *The Indian Express*.

— WITH INPUTS BY LIZ MATHEW

SC clips

circulation, and commercial exploitation on social media and digital platforms".

The plea said, "Isolated courtroom exchanges, oral observations, and preliminary remarks are frequently extracted from lengthy hearings, and circulated without the factual or legal context in which they were made. Such clips are often accompanied by misleading captions, sensational commentary, and clickbait headlines designed to maximise public engagement and commercial gain."

It said unchecked circulation of such content had exposed judges, advocates and litigants to unwarranted criticism, trolling, vilification, and reputational harm. "More importantly, it risks undermining public confidence in the administration of justice by creating distorted and incomplete narratives regarding judicial proceedings," it said.

The bench asked the various high courts to submit reports on the adoption of its livestreaming guidelines. It also asked the Centre to appraise which minis-

tries could implement the relief sought.

Appearing for Grover, Senior Advocate Vikas Singh expressed apprehension on clips of hearings being edited and circulated on social media.

"I personally don't see any problem with livestream," he said, referring to the recent instance of a hearing before a bench wherein the petitioner threw files and used abusive words, going viral on social media. "Adding words and showing clips is also happening," he said.

Justice Bagchi said that once such live streams are uploaded on digital platforms, it becomes difficult to manage their circulation. "Regulating data is one of the biggest challenges in digital space... so we should ensure limited access and therefore restrict livestream itself. Parties must expressly make a prayer that they want to see. It can't be a 24/7 entertainment channel by default... That belittles the justice system," he said.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta pointed to the dangers of AI and said some tools can alter the words spoken by someone while preserving the lip movements.

10% tariff

second tier where the US has imposed a standard 10% tariff rate on 17 economies — others in the category are Argentina, Bangladesh, Cambodia, Canada, Ecuador, El Salvador, Guatemala, Honduras, Indonesia, Jordan, Malaysia, Mexico, Pakistan, Sri Lanka, Trinidad and Tobago, and the United Kingdom.

"Based on the findings in the investigation of India, including India's adoption of a forced labour import prohibition subsequent to the publication of the June 5, 2026 FRN, and considering the public comments and testimony, the advice of the Section 301 Committee, as well as the advice of advisory committees, and in accordance with the specific direction of the President, the Trade Representative has determined to impose 10% tariffs on products of the U.S.," the USTR said.

The standard 10% tariffs on India are similar to those on ASEAN countries such as Malaysia and Indonesia but better than Vietnam which now falls under the least favourable countries with 25% tariffs alongside China, Russia, Brazil, Australia, the Philippines, Turkey and Saudi Arabia.

Under the new tariff design, Japan, South Korea and Switzerland are placed better than countries such as Vietnam and China, as they are subject to a 12.5% rate net of MFN.

Similar to the EU's Tariff Rate Quota mechanism, their duty is determined by MFN plus Section 301.

BLOs

Stutje on three sides and the India-Pakistan border fence on the fourth, it sits barely a kilometre from the international border. The village has little permanent infrastructure and is accessible largely by boat. Temporary Army pontoon bridges are erected only during emergencies. Repeated floods and the location on the border have forced many residents to move away, leaving behind a population of about 200.

For Darshan Singh and Pushpa Grover, teachers at Government School, Tendiwala, carrying out the SIR has meant making repeated boat journeys across the Sutlej.

There are 150 voters. I have completed 82 percent of my work," Darshan Singh said. "Some residents who have gone out of the village will re-

capped at 12.5%. If their MFN rate is already 12.5% or higher, the Section 301 duty is zero, according to the USTR.

The USTR has also established textile tariff-rate quotas (TRQs) for Bangladesh, Cambodia, Indonesia and Malaysia under which these economies could import US cotton and textile goods for final manufacturing. No such TRQ has been announced for India.

Bangladesh, being one of India's top competitors and a large importer of Indian cotton and fibre, could now begin sourcing input items from the US.

The USTR said that the TRQs will allow a specific volume of textiles and apparel from Bangladesh, Cambodia, Indonesia and Malaysia to enter the US free of Section 301 tariffs. However, these TRQs will have an initial duration of three years and imports to the US would then begin attracting a 10% Section 301 tariff.

The list of goods exempted from the Section 301 additional tariffs includes aircraft (other than military), engines, ground flight simulators and their parts or components. In the agriculture and food category, certain animal products (used for animal or pet food), seeds for planting, vegetable products (like coconut oil and jute burlap), unflavoured instant coffee, and in-quota sugar products would remain exempted.

In the materials and minerals category, pig iron, certain ferrous/aluminium scrap waste, and in-quota sugar products would remain exempted.

In the materials and minerals category, pig iron, certain ferrous/aluminium scrap waste, and in-quota sugar products would remain exempted.

turn after planting paddy. Earlier, I used to go every day. The villagers are adept at rowing boats and we have been using them."

Pushpa Grover said, "I have also been taking the boat to reach the village. The pontoon bridge is no longer there... I live in this area, so it is not a hardship for me. I have completed 90 percent of my work. The rest will be done soon."

Punjab Chief Electoral Officer Anindita Mitra said the exercise had highlighted the dedication of BLOs working under difficult conditions. "The BLOs have shown tremendous professionalism in carrying out the SIR in Punjab. They took whatever river was available. They are the praiseworthy partners in the SIR and have done commendable work," she said.

plance with related laws and norms, including Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023, Information Technology Act, 2000, and directions of the Indian Computer Emergency Response Team (CERT-In), as well as running around-the-clock Security Operations Centre.

The post requires 12 years of information-security experience, including at least five at a senior leadership level.

The GM (Vigilance, Investigation and Forensics) will head the agency's internal probe and digital forensics functions, including leading probes into suspected malpractice, building an in-house digital forensics capability, and coordinating with Central and state investigative agencies. The position requires 15 years of experience, including

five years at a senior level in information, including Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023, Information Technology Act, 2000, and directions of the Indian Computer Emergency Response Team (CERT-In), as well as running around-the-clock Security Operations Centre.

The GM (Assessment Research and Development and Psychometrics) will head the agency's academic and measurement-science function and will be responsible for item banks or digital repositories of questions, normalisation methodology, equating and calibration procedures, and pilots on computer-adaptive testing and AI-assisted assessment.

As for the 16 young professionals, the Ministry said: "The engagement is open to candidates who have appeared in the Civil Services Examination and are on the Pratibha Setu portal with 12 positions in academic research, two in legal research and two in finance and accounts."

OpenAI

by ChatGPT using the RAG (retrieval-augmented generation) technique does not amount to infringement under the Copyright Act since the outputs generated by OpenAI were not substantially similar to ANI (inputs)," he said.

Justice Bansal said ANI had "failed to satisfy" the court "that any memorisation or regurgitation of ANI's copyrighted works happened through the responses generated by ChatGPT". The "balance of convenience" was in favour of OpenAI, the judge said — "irreparable injury would be caused not only to OpenAI but also to the public at large" if any interim injunction was granted in favour of ANI.

Two district courts in the US took a broadly similar line in two closely watched copyright cases that were decided within days of each other in June 2025. A group of writers had filed a class action complaint against Anthropic, the company behind the Claude family of LLMs; in the second case, a group of authors had sued Meta Platforms, whose research division Meta AI has developed the chatbot Llama.

The judges held that AI works did not substitute for the original works; rather, they generated something new from them. The ruling in the Meta case underlined that the plaintiffs had not shown that the training measurably harmed the market for their books. Both US verdicts have been relied upon by the Delhi High Court in its ruling.

Several media and publishing organisations and associations such as the Federation of Indian Publishers, Digital News Publishers Association, and the Indian Music Industry had joined as parties to ANI's suit and raised similar objections to OpenAI's training model.

On Friday's ruling, IP lawyer Amit Kumar Panigrahi, partner at Kochhar & Co., said the verdict, apart from being a boost to developers, is likely to prompt copyright owners to revisit their contractual frameworks, including licensing models and AI-specific restrictions in content access and usage terms.

Three days of talks

which he put forward his conditions for ending the fast. He requested an "unequivocal assurance from the government that none of the young protesters will face any punitive or retaliatory legal action for participating in this movement". This was a climax from the collective demand of the protesters that Pradhan must resign.

"The government did not approach me for this. They were talking to Gitanjali (Angmo), Wangchuk's wife. Yes, I helped Gitanjali and Sonam in the whole process as they were consulting me throughout. I was also trying to convince him to break his fast. Sonam ending his fast is separate from the ongoing movement. The movement of the youth continues. But his health was deteriorating. It was important to save his life. He is an inspiration to the youth in the country. He was to end his fast on July 20 itself. But the government treated him badly. So, he continued his fast," Tanika told *The Indian Express*.

On July 21, Union Ministers J P Nadra and Jitendra Singh met Wangchuk at Medanta Hospital in Gurgaon. The two are learnt to have assured him that issues raised by him would be taken up for discussion in a "merit list".

The appointments, the Education Ministry said, will mark "the first concrete step in the institutional rebuild of NTA" being implemented in line with the recommendations of the high-level committee of experts chaired by former ISRO chief K Radhakrishnan.

The *Indian Express* has first reported on July 7 that the Government is set to overhaul the NTA, covering its organisation, infrastructure, technology and processes.

According to the Education Ministry, four contractual positions of General Manager — each for an initial term of three years — have been notified: Test Centre Network and Operations; Information Security; Vigilance, Investigation and Forensics; and

NTA

of General Manager in the agency to oversee key functions such as its network of centres, operations, information security and vigilance.

The Ministry also said it would engage 16 young professionals in various units of the NTA through the Pratibha Setu portal of the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC).

The portal is a Government initiative that allows "verified employers — including ministries, PSUs, autonomous bodies, and private organizations — to access details of non-recommended willing candidates who cleared all stages of UPSC exams but didn't make it to the final

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SEVERAL SCHOOLS SWITCH TO ONLINE & HYBRID MODE

'Students stuck in buses for hours': Parents fret as stir hits schools near Jantar Mantar

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, July 24

"WHY DISTURB parents mentally everyday?" "How will we manage to take students from school?" "Children remained stuck in buses for hours?" These have been among the concerns of the parents whose children have been studying in schools in Central Delhi where daily commute has been affected amid the protest at Jantar Mantar against NEET paper leak.

Amid uncertainty, several schools have shifted to online or hybrid mode as Metro services and mobile connectivity remain affected and barricades choke arterial roads. Among the schools that are close to the protest site are Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, Raghubir Singh Junior Modern School, Modern School at Barakhamba Road, and St Columba's School.

Delhi Education Minister Ashish Sood told *The Indian Express* on Friday that the government is not interfering in how school administrations handle the ongoing stir even as he recently convened a meeting with all Deputy Directors of Education to review broader school safety and general concerns.

On Monday, during the 'Sant Chalo' march, which saw the use of batons and tear gas to curb the agitation, schoolchildren were stranded in school buses for four to five hours, claimed some parents.

A parent of a student from Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan said he had to wait until around 5 pm to know whether his child had reached their home in Bengali Market.

A father of a five-year-old child, who studies at Raghubir Singh Junior Modern School, recounted the ordeal faced by his wife. "Bachha hai, school intezaam karoge. Rehne do unko school me. (The child is in school, the school will make the ar-



Protesters at Parliament Street in Delhi on Friday. GAIJENDRA YADAV

rangements. Let them remain in school," she was told by a security personnel, according to him.

The school on Friday said that it has shifted to online classes.

After a school bus carrying students from Sardar Patel Vidyalya in Lodi Estate was reportedly stuck on the road for three hours, the school switched to online mode on Tuesday before adopting a hybrid mode on Wednesday and resuming physical classes from Thursday.

The school also issued advisories to parents, asking them to remain in touch with bus attendants, as traffic restrictions continued.

The school transitioned to online mode for its junior wing on Friday. Meanwhile, exams for senior sections were postponed, as per an official circular by the school and teachers instructed to hold hybrid classes for Classes 6-12.

At Modern School on Barakhamba Road, a Class 10 student said that the aftermath of tear gas use at the protest site was felt at the school campus this week. Even as the school held physical classes on Thursday, the attendance remained low, the student claimed.

Queries sent to the school related to academic disruptions by *The Indian Express* did not elicit a response.

At St Columba's School, regular classes have continued, but the school, in a notice, underlined that it delayed its inter-school festival — Columban Melange — "in view of the prevailing situation".

Vishal Sharma, whose child is in Class 9 at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, said the school has been operating in a hybrid mode.

"The school is just five to seven minutes from Jantar Mantar. It made us (parents) deeply anxious about sending our boys to classes. Despite the chaotic environment and the unexpected scale of the protest, the management handled everything very efficiently by dispersing classes in a staggered manner through six separate gates. Students were only released after parents called the class teachers to confirm arrival. While some parents organised carpools, the situation was still tense on Wednesday," Sharma said. He added that the school bus services especially to the inner Connaught Place and other parts of Lutyens' Delhi had to be rerouted.

The situation has also raised questions about how schools are dealing with conversations around the ongoing protests, said Aparajita Singh, head of Delhi Parents Association. "The schools need to be sensitive to the circumstances students are navigating and ensure that their safety and emotional well-being are not overlooked amid the ongoing disruption," she said.

A principal of a school in West Delhi's Dwarka said political discussions were not permitted on campus. A senior teacher, who did not wish to be named, however, said that the uncertainty surrounding the disruption was difficult to ignore, particularly for senior students concerned about their future.

A Delhi-based collective of mothers has also raised concerns over the reported use of expired tear gas ammunition during the police action.

In a representation to the Central Pollution Control Board on Wednesday, Warrior Moms said there were credible reports that expired tear-gas shells may have been used against protesting students and citizens and sought an independent scientific and environmental investigation.

17 Metro stations shut for third day, roads closed, markets see heavy dip in footfall

Gayathri Mani
and Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, July 24

THE IMPACT of the CJP protest is spreading beyond Connaught Place, with traders across Sarojini Nagar, Chandni Chowk, Khan Market, Janpath and Palika Bazaar reporting a sharp drop in footfall, as closed Metro stations and traffic restrictions keep shoppers away.

For the third consecutive day on Friday, the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation kept 17 stations in Central Delhi closed from 7.30 am. These included Rajiv Chowk, Janpath, Central Secretariat, TITO, Delhi Gate and Khan Market. New Delhi Metro station was later added to the list before entry gates at Mandi House and Central Secretariat were reopened in the evening. Fifteen stations, however, remained shut until further orders.

A day after most shops, restaurants and offices in Connaught Place shut in the evening, traders at Sarojini Nagar said they may also pull down shutters early from Saturday if the protest continues at Jantar Mantar.

Ashok Randhawa, president of the Sarojini Nagar Mini Market Traders Association, said they will take a final call on the



Sarojini Nagar Market also saw a dip in footfall on Friday. EXPRESS

matter on Saturday. "We will take a call tomorrow if the CJP protest continues. As of now, we have told the shopkeepers that if they want, they can shut their shops early," he added.

Many shopkeepers closed their shops by 7 pm at Sarojini Nagar market, he further said. According to Randhawa, in the last few days, business at the market has seen a dip of nearly 70%. "The situation will worsen if the protest continues because a large number of customers take the Metro to come to the market. With Metro stations closed and traffic jams across the area, customers are simply not coming," he added.

Connaught Place is not faring any better.

Manpreet Singh, who runs Zen Restaurant, said the park-

ing area outside his restaurant, which usually sees around 500 cars, has seen barely 30-40 vehicles over the last few days.

"Business is down 95%. People are scared of getting stuck in traffic because roads are being closed without prior information," he said, adding that congestion around Jantar Mantar had worsened because of barricades, security deployment and vehicles parked along the roads.

Atul Bhargava, president of the New Delhi Traders Association, estimated that businesses in Connaught Place were operating at only about 25% of capacity. "Usually, Friday, Saturday and Sunday are the best days for us, but today has been the worst, with people not coming to Connaught Place at all," he said.

"Our staff has to walk long distances to reach the stores," he added.

Traders said nearby markets, including Gole Market, Yusuf Zai Market, Janpath and shops near Indian Oil Bhawan, had also witnessed a sharp decline in customers. Even the posh lanes of Khan Market are witnessing significantly less footfall. "People are scared... when roads will be blocked," said Sanjay Mehra, president of the Khan Market Traders Association. He estimated that stores were making only about 25% of their usual sales.

In Chandni Chowk, traders claimed daily footfall had fallen from around 1.5 lakh to about 50,000. Sanjay Bhargava, president of the Chandni Chowk Traders Association, said, "We urge the government either to earmark a separate venue for the protest or restrict the number of protesters. Traders have placed orders for new stock and have payments to make, but transportation disruptions and traffic congestion have severely affected business."

"The wedding season is approaching and business will be severely affected if the protest continues. We will soon write to the Prime Minister, the Lieutenant Governor and the CM raising the issue," he added.

20-yr-old dies as car veers off slippery road, falls into drain

New Delhi: A 20-year-old student died and a woman, who was travelling with him, was injured after the car he was driving allegedly lost control, plunged into a drain and overturned in South West Delhi on Friday morning, said police.

The driver, identified as Yashvendra, had sustained serious injuries in the crash. He was rushed for medical treatment but succumbed to the injuries.

Preliminary enquiry revealed that while taking a sharp turn near the Nangal Dewar red light, Yashvendra allegedly lost control of the vehicle because of

the slippery road surface. Police said the two had spent the previous night at a friend's house and were on their way to drop the woman home when the accident took place. Investigators found that the vehicle belonged to the woman while it was being driven by Yashvendra.

Yashvendra and the woman were students of the same institution in US, where they became friends. They were in India for a break. He was the son of an Indian Army officer.

The woman is a resident of Vasant Kunj. Her father works with a private firm. ENS

JNU, Jamia caution students against protest participation

New Delhi: A day after Delhi University (DU) cautioned students against participating in the CJP protests, two more central universities — Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU) and Jamia Millia Islamia — on Friday issued advisories asking students to stay away from demonstrations around Jantar Mantar.

The advisories come amid growing concern among university administrations over the spillover of the nationwide protests. Videos circulating on Friday show students marching through DU's North Cam-

pus carrying flags and placards. JNU issued a public advisory asking members of its "epistemic community" to "act responsibly and prioritize their personal safety". It also cautioned students to "exercise responsibility on social media", warning that violations could invite legal consequences.

Jamia Millia Islamia, in a message to students, appealed to them to remain focused on their studies and avoid activities that could jeopardise their future. It addressed many first-year students who recently joined the university. ENS

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Gross Advances

₹3,92,833
Crore

19.75% YoY

RAM Advances

₹3,068
Crore

36.23% YoY

Net Profit

Gross NPA

1.81%

-111 bps YoY

Net NPA

0.51%

-24 bps YoY

Unaudited / Reviewed Financial Results (Standalone & Consolidated) for the Quarter ended 30th June 2026

₹ in Lakh

Sr. No.	Particulars	Standalone			Consolidated		
		Quarter ended 30.06.2026 (Reviewed)	Quarter ended 30.06.2025 (Reviewed)	Year ended 31.03.2026 (Audited)	Quarter ended 30.06.2026 (Reviewed)	Quarter ended 30.06.2025 (Reviewed)	Year ended 31.03.2026 (Audited)
1	Total Income from Operations (Net)	22,52,847	20,51,829	85,03,554	22,71,228	20,67,762	85,64,956
2	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	4,08,748	2,91,330	13,94,566	4,33,099	3,02,341	14,28,854
3	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period before tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	4,08,748	2,91,330	13,94,566	4,33,099	2,50,461	13,76,974
4	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period after tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	3,06,790	2,25,212	10,52,715	3,30,258	1,82,956	10,30,630
5	Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit/(Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	Refer Note 3			Refer Note 3		
6	Paid up Equity Share Capital	4,55,341	4,55,341	4,55,341	4,55,341	4,55,341	4,55,341
7	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve) as shown in the Audited Balance Sheet of the previous year			75,47,654			77,38,068
8	Earnings Per Share (of ₹ 10/- each) (for continuing and discontinued operations) -						
	1. Basic (in ₹):	6.74	4.95	23.12	7.25	4.02	22.64
	2. Diluted (in ₹):	6.74	4.95	23.12	7.25	4.02	22.64
9	Net Worth	76,94,034	66,86,230	75,27,811	78,90,859	68,36,318	77,05,575
10	Paidup Debt Capital/ Outstanding Debt *	28.60%	19.46%	27.82%			
11	Debt Equity Ratio *	0.71	0.57	0.78			

* Debt represents borrowings with residual maturity of more than one year. Outstanding Debt represents total borrowings of the Bank.

Notes:

- The above is an extract of the detailed format of Quarterly / Yearly Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 and Regulation 52 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Quarterly/Yearly Financial Results are available on the Stock Exchange(s) websites (BSE: <https://www.bseindia.com> and NSE: <https://www.nseindia.com>) and the website of the Bank (<https://www.bankofindia.bank.in>). The same can be accessed by scanning the QR Code provided here.
- For the other line items referred in regulation 52(4) of the Listing Regulations, pertinent disclosures have been made to the Stock Exchange(s) (National Stock Exchange and Bombay Stock Exchange) and can be accessed on the URL (NSE: <http://www.nseindia.com> and BSE: <http://www.bseindia.com>).
- Information relating to Total Comprehensive Income and Other Comprehensive Income is not furnished as Ind AS is not yet made applicable to banks.

Sd/- (Pramod Dwivedi) Executive Director | Sd/- (Rajni Mishra) Executive Director | Sd/- (Subrat Kumar) Executive Director | Sd/- (P. R. Rajagopal) Executive Director | Sd/- (Rajneesh Karnatak) Managing Director & CEO | Sd/- (M.R. Kumar) Chairman

Place : Mumbai | Date : 24.07.2026



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Bank of India
Relationship beyond banking



Protesters and security personnel at Jantar Mantar on Friday. TASHI TOBOGYAL & ABHINAV SAHA

Speeches made since Sonam's removal to be examined: Police

Sakshi Chand & Pragynesh New Delhi, July 24

THE DELHI Police will assess all the speeches made at the protest called by the CJP at Jantar Mantar since activist Sonam Wangchuk was removed from the site on July 18 to examine if any inflammatory comments were made to trigger the demonstrations, sources told *The Indian Express*. A police officer also said that the speeches would include the ones given by celebrities and political leaders.

A total of 15 FIRs have been registered so far following the 'Sansad Chalo' march on July 20, said officers, adding that first one registered at Parliament Street police station — after the first reports of stone pelting came from the 'Selfie Point' area in Connaught Place — will have sections of criminal conspiracy added to it.

"Around 2,500 people have been found to be involved in violence and 100-200 protestors are suspected to have been involved in inciting the crowd and getting involved in stone pelting and creating ruckus," an officer said. A source said that the police have over 5 terabyte of related data, and will conduct a detailed investigation in the coming days.

Police had earlier said that they are examining encrypted chats on the Bitchat app, which works over Bluetooth mesh networks; locality and college-based WhatsApp groups; social media posts; CCTV camera footage; mobile phone data and facial recognition records.

Investigators said that they are examining whether charges of culpable homicide apply after a 22-year-old woman was injured in the stampede-like situation that followed.

The other challenge: 15,000 kg of garbage daily at protest site

Mishal Mussaddique & Tabshir Shams New Delhi, July 24

AT JANTAR MANTAR, the crowds are growing every day. So is the garbage. Plastic bottles, paper plates and food packets line the protest site, accompanied by a constant stench.

"There is no standard waste management protocol when more than 5,000 people gather every day," said an official from New Delhi Municipal Corporation (NDMC), in charge of managing waste in the area.

"Earlier, we collected around 500-600 kg of waste from Tolstoy Marg, Sansad Marg and Jantar Mantar Road. Now we lift nearly 15,000 kg of waste every day."

To manage the waste, the NDMC has deployed extra workers in three shifts. About 50 workers clean the area in the morning, 15 in the afternoon and 20 in the evening.

"We also use goblies — battery-operated, eco-friendly litter-pickers — and vacuum devices designed to rapidly collect solid waste. Fogging machines and disinfectant sprays are also used in regular intervals. Further, auto-tippers and garbage trucks come to the protest site in coordination with the police," the official said.

Still, garbage piled up over the last few days, especially next to the abandoned building opposite Kerala House.

"The NDMC had not collected garbage from the protest area for many days. Today we called them," said Gyan (35), one of the protesters.

As per NDMC officials, they could not enter the area because police permission had not been granted. "We didn't have clear-



Four portable toilets — three for women and one for all — were installed on Tolstoy Road, Friday.

ance from the district commissioner of police to clear waste for the last couple of days. As soon as we got permission, the entire area was wet cleaned," said the official.

Many protesters, meanwhile, have taken it upon themselves to keep Jantar Mantar clean. Near the protest site, on Tolstoy Road, opposite The Imperial Hotel, Amaldeep Singh (26) — who had travelled from Malout in Punjab for the protest — was seen collecting waste off the footpath amid the sea of people. "This is seva (service)."

"I want to show that we youth are not here to have fun, we can also take some responsibility... Many are littering without any hesitation. What is the kind of message that we are trying to send out there?"

NDMC officials said such volunteers have made their work easier. "We can't deny it. The children have been really helpful and have coordinated with us throughout to make our work easier," said the official.

However, not everyone collecting waste is a volunteer. Thirteen-year-old Janisar and his uncle Nasim, who collect scrap for a living, have been visiting the protest site for the last few days to gather discarded plastic bottles. The two sell them to a scrap dealer on Minny Road.

"We have been coming here for the last three-four days. We keep walking around collecting bottles. We eat the free food distributed here and sleep at the protest site," said Nasim, adding that they earn around Rs 800-900 a day.

Outside the The Imperial Hotel, meanwhile, stood four portable toilets — three for women and one for all. The Sachkhand Foundation, whose members are volunteering at the protest site, got them installed



'To maintain law & order', liquor shops in Delhi to shut by 8 pm until Sunday

Gayathri Mani New Delhi, July 24

FOLLOWING INSTRUCTIONS from the Delhi Police Special Branch, the Excise department directed that liquor shops in the city will be shut by 8 pm on three days — Friday to Sunday. Currently, liquor shops in the city close at 10 pm.

"The revised timings have been implemented from today. A formal order is on the way in the regard. The decision has been taken following directions from the Delhi Police," a senior Excise department official said.

"While students are protesting peacefully, some anti-social elements are trying to disrupt the protest by drinking and creating ruckus. As this can lead to untoward incidents, police requested us to revise the timings of liquor shops... it has been done," the official added.

Officials said that the Special Branch, on Friday, officially wrote to Principal Secretary (Home and Finance) Santosh D Vaidya requesting that the order be immediately implemented. "It is submitted that credible intelligence inputs indicate the likelihood of certain anti-social and disruptive elements attempting to exploit the prevailing situation to create disturbances affecting public order at various locations in the National Capital Territory of Delhi," read the letter undersigned by Ankit Chauhan, DCP, Special Branch.

It added that the available inputs further "indicate that such elements may resort to consumption of liquor during the evening hours and thereafter indulge in hooliganism, unruly and disorderly conduct, breach

of peace, acts of violence, damage to public property, obstruction of public ways and other unlawful activities, thereby posing a potential threat to public safety, security and maintenance of law and order."

According to the police, continued operation of liquor vendors up to 10 pm may facilitate easy access to liquor during the critical evening period and "increase the possibility of intoxication-induced incidents capable of escalating into serious law and order situations, requiring substantial police intervention and deployment."

"As a preventive measure aimed at maintaining public order, ensuring public safety and denying opportunities to anti-social elements to exploit the prevailing situation, it is requested that directions may kindly be issued for closure of all liquor vendors/shops in the National Capital Territory of Delhi by 2000 hrs... for the next three days..." the letter read.

The police have also told the government that if the current situation prevails, it may extend the further extend the time restrictions beyond three days. "The requirement for continuation of the above arrangement, if warranted by the prevailing situation, shall be communicated," the letter issued with the approval of Commissioner of Police, said.

Currently, the city has 700 government liquor shops run by four corporations.

An official from one of the corporations said, "The directions have been verbally issued... all the vendors and corporations will implement it immediately. An official order will be issued to all shops soon."

Delhi Police forms STF to probe paper leaks, public exam offences

Sakshi Chand New Delhi, July 24

TO STRENGTHEN probe into alleged irregularities in the conduct of public examinations, the Delhi Police on Friday constituted a Special Task Force (STF) within its Crime Branch to investigate paper leaks and other offences under the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024, officers said.

According to a statement issued by Delhi Police on Friday, the STF has been constituted with the approval of the Commissioner of Police and will conduct probe into offences related to public examinations conducted by agencies including the UPSC, Staff Selection Commission (SSC), Railway Recruitment Boards (RRBs), Institute of Banking Personnel Selection (IBPS), National Testing Agency (NTA) and recruitment examinations conducted by Union Government, besides any other authority notified by the Centre.

As per officers, the STF will also coordinate with prosecuting agencies to ensure speedy prosecution of such cases.

The unit will be headed by the DCP, Crime Branch, while the Special Commissioner of Police, Crime Branch will exercise overall supervision and administrative control over its functioning, an officer said.

Training of RAF personnel postponed; 10 more CRPF companies for Capital

Express News Service New Delhi, July 24

THE CENTRE has directed the airlifting of 10 more CRPF companies from Chhattisgarh to deploy in Delhi to bolster security measures in view of the student protest underway, officials said on Friday. The CRPF headquarters has also postponed one of the training sessions of the Rapid Action Force (RAF) due to the ongoing protests at Jantar Mantar, they added.

According to an official communication, the RAF per-

sonnel were set to undergo training from July 27 to August 8 in Meerut. The Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) officials said that orders have been issued to sanction only emergency leaves to its Delhi Metro unit as maximum manpower is required at the stations owing to the security situation.

According to officials, a security review meeting held in Delhi on Thursday required all Central Armed Police Forces (CAPF) units scheduled to be stationed in the Capital ahead of Independence Day to report

early. They said that about 150 CAPF companies will be deployed in Delhi over the next few days. A CAPF company has about 100 personnel. About 100 such companies are already in Delhi assisting the local police with law and order duties, officials said.

Earlier this week, the Centre airlifted 20 CRPF companies from West Bengal to deploy in Delhi. Followed close in its wake was the induction of three RAF units and several other CAPF units, such as the SSB, BSF, and ITBP.

HC refuses to order NIA probe into foreign funding claims

Sohini Ghosh New Delhi, July 24

THE DELHI High Court on Friday declined to entertain a plea seeking a probe by the NIA into the allegations of foreign funding and assault of police personnel tied to CJP-led march to Parliament on July 20 to protest the NEET paper leak and other related issues.

Even as the government suggested that the court can issue a notice, a bench of Chief Justice D K Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia noted that Supreme Court judgements have already dealt with the

procedure to be followed when officers are injured, and public and private property suffers damage during such cases of "unlawful assembly".

Addressing Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, who was representing the government and the petitioner, the HC said, "Are you saying you're not following/laid down mandate... to need court directions? There is every authority available to you to deal with such situations. Do that. You're under a mandate (to act according to laid down law)."

Satish Kumar Aggarwal, ex-vice president of Akhil Bharat Hindu Mahasabha, who had

moved the petition, withdrew after the HC indicated that it is not inclined to entertain the petition. Aggarwal, in his petition, wanted the court to direct the NIA or any other specialised probe agency to probe the alleged attempts at blocking Parliament and alleged stone pelting at police personnel on July 20 during the 'Sansad Chalo' march of the CJP.

Aggarwal sought the HC intervention to direct the authorities to "identify persons responsible for acts of violence, vandalism, obstruction of emergency services, damage to public and private property,"

While Aggarwal's counsel stressed that the "fundamental rights" of citizens are being denied owing to the disruption in livelihoods, including due to the shutdown of some Metro stations, the High Court said that there is an alternate remedy available to air these grievances.

The court opined that Aggarwal can approach the government with a representation, and the government can take a decision on it accordingly.

The court made the remarks even as SG Mehta urged the court that Aggarwal's petition can be heard along with two

other petitions that deal with police excesses on protesters, and the government's response can be called for.

The court also disposed of a petition by NGO Save India Foundation which was imploring the court's intervention on alleged attack on security officers. The court permitted the outfit to make its representation to the government.

The HC also dealt with a third petition by former JNUSU president Aishwarya, objecting to the continuous and indiscriminate surveillance at the protest site, which it will hear on July 27.

● ACTIVIST ENDED HIS 26-DAY FAST EARLY FRIDAY

Beyond Sonam Wangchuk: At Jantar Mantar, the protest shows no sign of abating

Akriti Kanodia New Delhi, July 24

AS LONG queues waited to enter Jantar Mantar, volunteers distributed food and water, slogans gave way to songs and protesters prepared for another long night, activist Sonam Wangchuk ended his 26-day hunger strike following talks with the Centre early Friday.

Many at the protest site did not immediately know that Wangchuk had ended his fast. With mobile Internet data sus-

pendent within a 1.5-km radius of Jantar Mantar, many learnt of it only when they stepped outside the area.

"We went to Jama Masjid to eat," said Avik, a student. "We got network there and saw what had happened. Then we came back."

Wangchuk had been on an indefinite hunger strike since June 28 at Jantar Mantar, where the CJP has been demanding Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation over the NEET paper leak.

Around 12.45 am on Friday, he broke his fast in the presence of Union Health Minister J P Nadda and Union Minister Jitendra Singh.

For many who returned to the protest site after hearing the news, Wangchuk's decision did not change the reason why they were there.

"I think the timeline should shift away from a centralised personality to the issues, because it is the issues that matter," said a working professional at the protest.

"People can come and go,



CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke at Jantar Mantar on Friday. ABHINAV SAHA

but this is about people's lives. It is about the 21 lives who are

not here with us anymore." Referring to images of

Wangchuk being offered a drink by Nadda, she added, "People who understand politics know what that means."

Krishna Yadav, one of the volunteers coordinating supplies, said donations from across the country had kept the protest going. "Some people sent medicines, some sent food," he said.

Asked whether Wangchuk ending his fast would change anything, he said the protest would continue regardless: "We are here 24 hours."

Supplies, however, have thinned.

At one point, an exhausted volunteer tried to stop a group of boys from entering the packed venue. "There's no point going inside now," he said.

One of the boys replied, "It's okay, we will be here tomorrow evening."

Not all agreed on what would happen next. Some said the focus had shifted from Pradhan's resignation to a broader demand for accountability; others said the original demands stood

unchanged. "We have given you a chance to raise your voice in a democracy," said Vikant, a protester and medical volunteer.

"I've asked, revert with the answer. Say sorry, at least. Come out and say, 'I made a mistake.' Then fix it," he headed. Avik admitted that the protest may now slow down with Wangchuk ending his hunger strike. He, however, maintained: "But the protest has become bigger than one person. Everyone is a face. Everyone is a leader."

Bill criminalising insult to Vande Mataram introduced in House

Nikhil Ghanekar, Asad Rehman & Anoma Dutt
New Delhi, July 24

AMID CONTINUED demand for the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, the first week of the Monsoon Session ended in a washout on Friday, with the exception of the introduction of The Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026, in the Rajya Sabha.

The Bill seeks to amend the Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act, 1971, to make insults to National Song Vande Mataram a criminal offence, punishable with imprisonment up to five years.

Proceedings in both Houses on Friday began with paying tribute to members of the Armed Forces killed during the Kargil War, ahead of the Kargil Vijay Diwas on July 26 (Sunday).

Soon after, the Opposition MPs resumed their protest



Congress MPs Mallikarjun Kharge and Priyanka Gandhi, along with TMC MP Sagarika Ghose and others raise slogans seeking the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan during the Monsoon session of Parliament in New Delhi, Friday.

against the NEET paper leak, resulting in both Houses getting adjourned until 12 noon.

When the Lok Sabha met again, Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju said, "If we don't have a discussion and make excuses, then it is not a good message. I request (Leader of Opposition) Rahul

Gandhi that he should make the Congress MPs understand. Other party MPs have put their views that there should be a discussion. Why can't we have a good discussion?"

LoP Rahul Gandhi sought to speak after Rijiju's remarks, but BJP's Jagdambika Pal, who was presiding over the House, said

he would allow him time to speak after papers are laid on the table. The Opposition members started raising "istifa do" slogans, and Pal adjourned the proceedings till Monday.

Speaking to reporters in the Parliament complex, Gandhi said, "Rijijuji gave a statement that they want our MPs to hold a discussion. The normal protocol is that if someone names a person, he or she is allowed to respond. When I wanted to reply, the mic was taken away from me. I was not given an opportunity," he said. Gandhi reiterated the Opposition's stance that they will not have a discussion or conversation on NEET until Pradhan is sacked.

In the Rajya Sabha, proceedings were adjourned till 2 pm. When the business resumed, Minister of State for Home Affairs Nityanand Rai proposed to introduce 'The Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026'.

The Bill seeks to make intentionally preventing the singing of the National Song or causing disturbance to any assembly engaged in such singing an offence with a maximum punishment of five years, or fine, or both. It also seeks to accord the same statutory protection to the National Song as the National Anthem.

As the Opposition benches protested the Bill's introduction, Deputy Chairman of Rajya Sabha Harivansh allowed CPI(M) MP John Brittas and CPI MP Sandosh Kumar P to speak on the Bill. "The Constituent Assembly, after nearly three years of exhaustive deliberation, consciously refrained from placing the National Song and the National Anthem on the same constitutional footing. Had the framers of both intended to enjoy identical legal consequences, they would have expressed and so provided," Brittas said.

The CJI said that when he travels, many youth come forward to meet him. "I am drawing my force from the youth of the country."

He said the Supreme Court's doors are always open to every citizen and "whatever in terms of constitutional principles or law of the land allows, will redress the grievance."

"If the country's youth have any grievance which they want to be redressed through the judicial forum, then the Su-

CJI reiterates: Cockroach remarks only for fake law degree holders, not all youth

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, July 24

CHIEF JUSTICE of India Surya Kant on Friday reiterated that his remarks about cockroaches at a hearing in the Supreme Court in May this year was only in the context of those who had gained entry into the legal profession using fake degrees and not all youth for whom he had great respect.

The CJI told *The Indian Express* that the issue of fake law degree holders had been flagged by none other than the Bar Council of India in the past and it was only in this background that he made those comments. "It was about the lawyers who have entered profession through backdoor based on mostly fake degrees. Issue was about fake law degrees and how to clean up. It was in that context that I commented," he said.

The CJI said that when he travels, many youth come forward to meet him. "I am drawing my force from the youth of the country."

He said the Supreme Court's doors are always open to every citizen and "whatever in terms of constitutional principles or law of the land allows, will redress the grievance."

"If the country's youth have any grievance which they want to be redressed through the judicial forum, then the Su-



CJI Surya Kant

"If the country's youth have any grievance which they want to be redressed through the judicial forum, then the Supreme Court's doors are always open for them"

SURYA KANT,
CHIEF JUSTICE OF INDIA

preme Court's doors are always open for them," he said.

The CJI's remarks on May 15 during a hearing likening unemployed youth in law to cockroaches had led to an uproar culminating in the creation of the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP), with many inter-

preting it as comments targeting the entire youth community and not just the legal profession.

A day later, the CJI stated that he had been "misquoted" by sections of the media and that his criticism was directed solely at those who had entered professions through fake or bogus degrees.

"I am pained to read how a section of the media has misquoted my oral observations made during the hearing of a frivolous case yesterday. What I had specifically criticised were those who have entered professions like the Bar (legal profession) with the aid of fake and bogus degrees. Similar persons have sneaked into the media, social media, and other noble professions as well, and hence they are like parasites," the CJI had said in a statement.

"It is totally baseless to suggest that I criticised the youth of our nation. Not only am I proud of our present and future human resource, but every youth of India inspires me. It is not an exaggeration to say that Indian youth have great regard and respect for me, and I too see them as the pillars of a developed India," he had said.

Bittu resigns from Union Cabinet, will focus on poll-bound Punjab

Press Trust of India
Chandigarh, July 24

WITH PRESIDENT Droupadi Murmu accepting his resignation from the Union Council of Ministers, BJP leader Raveesh Singh Bittu on Friday said he will now shift his entire focus on poll-bound Punjab as his party is eyeing to form the government in the border state.

Bittu is likely to contest the 2027 Punjab assembly elections from Ludhiana. He had been holding the charge as Union Minister of State for Railways and Food Processing Industries.

A prominent Sikh face of the BJP, Bittu said he had tendered his resignation on June 21, when his Rajya Sabha term ended. In June, Bittu had expressed his desire to work for



Raveesh Singh Bittu's tenure in Rajya Sabha ended on June 21

Punjab in the Vidhan Sabha after spending nearly 17 years in Parliament. He had then said that the BJP made him the minister even though he had lost the 2024 parliamentary elections.

On the 2027 Assembly polls, Bittu expressed confidence that the BJP would form the govern-

ment in Punjab. "People of Punjab are fed up (with other parties). People are very much aware of development and progress taking place in other (BJP-ruled) states and they want progress in Punjab as well," Bittu said.

The grandson of former Punjab chief minister Beant Singh, Bittu was assassinated in 1995. Bittu joined the BJP ahead of the 2024 Lok Sabha polls.

He remained Lok Sabha MP for three terms on Congress ticket. He was elected an MP for the first time from Anandpur Sahib in 2009. Later, he was elected from Ludhiana twice in 2014 and 2019.

After joining the BJP, he unsuccessfully contested from Ludhiana seat in 2024. He was defeated by Congress' Amrinder Singh Raja Warring.

Mrityunjay Tiwari jumps ship from RJD to BJP

Yuvraj Singh
Patna, July 24

FORMER RJD spokesperson Mrityunjay Tiwari on Friday joined the BJP in the presence of the party's state unit president, Sanjay Sarangi. The move comes a week after Tiwari served with the Opposition party in Bihar, bringing a formal end to his nearly 20-year association with the RJD.

Tiwari was inducted into the party during an event at the state BJP headquarters in Patna.

Addressing BJP workers after joining the party, Tiwari cited alignment with national goals as his main reason for switching sides. "I was inspired by the party's vision of Viksit Bharat... the BJP is working in the nation's interest. More people are joining the BJP be-

cause they identify with its ideology and vision."

On quitting the RJD, he said: "I no longer found myself aligned with the party's leadership despite having worked there for nearly two decades."

Tiwari's crossover follows his resignation from the RJD on July 16, when he publicly cited growing friction with party leadership and alleged that there was "no space for dedicated and loyal workers" in the RJD's organisational structure. As the RJD's spokesperson for over a decade, Tiwari was often seen leading from the front in defending the party and pushing its viewpoints before the media. His exit deprives the Opposition party of a familiar, articulate defender.

Writer is an intern with *The Indian Express*

भारतीय कॉन्कर लिमिटेड
CONTAINER CORPORATION OF INDIA LTD.
(A MAHARATHA UNDERTAKING OF GOVT OF INDIA)
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CIN: 1010098-ADG-EM (Project Personal) / ICFRE - Vol. III
Tel. Nos: 4112350-96, 4112350-96/97/98, website: <http://www.concorindia.co.in>

NOTICE OF RECORD DATE FOR INTERIM DIVIDEND FOR FY 2026-27

Notice is hereby given that 4th August, 2026 (Tuesday) has been fixed as the Record Date for the purpose of determining the entitlement of members to Interim Dividend @32% (₹1.60 per share on equity share of ₹5/- each), declared by the Board in its meeting held on 24.07.2026 for the financial year 2026-27. Further, Interim dividend will be paid:

(i) to those Members whose names will appear in the Register of Members of the Company, after giving effect to all valid Share Transfers in physical form lodged with the Company and its Registrar on or before 4th August, 2026; or

(ii) in respect of Shares held in electronic form, to those 'deemed members' whose names appear on the Statements of beneficial ownership furnished by National Securities Depository Limited (NSDL) and Central Depository Services (India) Limited (CDSL), at the end of business hours on 4th August, 2026.

In order to avail the facility of payment of dividend through Electronic Clearing Service (ECS), members of the Company, holding their shares in Demat mode are requested to submit the duly filled in ECS mandate form to their Depository Participant and those holding physical shares to Company's Share Transfer Agent and Registrar: **M/s Beetal Financial & Computer Services (P) Ltd., BEETAL HOUSE, 3rd Floor, 99, Madangir, Behind Local Shopping Centre, Near Dada Harsukdas Mandir, New Delhi-110062.** ECS instructions once furnished by the member will supersede all his/her previous bank mandates/details. ECS mandate form is available on Company's website: www.concorindia.co.in.

Shareholders holding shares in dematerialized mode are requested to update their records such as tax residential status, and permanent account number (PAN), mobile numbers and other details with the relevant depositories through their depository participants. Shareholders holding shares in physical mode are requested to furnish details to the Company's Registrar and Share Transfer Agent, M/s Beetal Financial & Computer Services (P) Ltd at concor@beetalfinancial.com.

Shareholders are also requested to register/update their E-mail ID with company at investorrelations@concorindia.com. Their Depository participants/ Company's Registrar & Share Transfer Agent at concor@beetalfinancial.com which will be used for sending official documents through e-mail in future.

Shareholders are requested to claim their unpaid/unclaimed dividend, if any by writing to company at its Registered office or email or to its R&TA. Dividend, if remained unpaid or unclaimed for a period of seven years shall be transferred by the company to the Investor Education and Protection Fund. Further, all shares in respect of which dividend has not been paid or claimed for seven consecutive years or more shall be transferred by the company in the name of Investor Education and Protection Fund.

For Container Corporation of India Ltd. **ad/-**
Place: New Delhi (Harish Chandra)

Date: 24.07.2026 PED (Finance) & Company Secretary

EXPRESS Careers

Advertisement No. 83/2026
Government of India
Public Enterprises Selection Board invites applications for the post of Director (Human Resources)

in
Bharat Sanchar Nigam Limited (BSNL)

Last date of submission of application by applicants is by 15:00 hours on 11th August, 2026

Last date of forwarding of applications by the Nodal Officers to PESS is by 17:00 hours on 20th August, 2026.

For details login to website <http://pees.gov.in>

Government of India Ministry of Chemicals & Fertilizers Department of Chemicals and Petrochemicals ENGAGEMENT OF TECHNICAL CONSULTANTS

The Department of Chemicals & Petrochemicals invites applications for engagement of three Technical Consultants i.e. two Mid-level and one Entry-level - on a contractual basis.

2. Detailed vacancy circular dated 01/07/2026 and 27/05/2026 are available on the website <https://chemicals.gov.in/recruitments>. Interested candidates may submit their applications in the prescribed format within 21 days from the date of publication of this advertisement in the Employment News to the following address:

Deputy Secretary (Admin),
Department of Chemicals & Petrochemicals,
Room No. 23051, 3rd Floor,
Kartavya Bhawan - 02, Dr. Rajendra Prasad Road,
New Delhi-110001
CBC-02101/11/0005/2627

Indian Council of Forestry Research and Education (ICFRE) (An Autonomous Body of Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change, Govt. of India) P.O. New Forest, Dehradun - 248 008

Advr. No. 1-45/2008-ADG (EM) Project Personal/ICFRE - Vol. III Dated: 23.07.2026

Walk-in-Interview

Walk in interview for temporary positions, purely on contractual basis under the following consultancy projects of EM Division will be held on 12.08.2026 in the committee room of EM Division, ICFRE H.O. Building from 11:00 AM onwards:

S.N.	Name of Projects	Name & No. of posts	Duration
1	Assessment of Environmental Damage resulting from Unauthorized Use/Diversion of Forest Land for Setting up Integrated Steel Plant in Bokaro District, Jharkhand/ M/s. ESL Steel Ltd.	Project Associate - 01	06 Months
2	Post Impoundment Environmental Study of Vayal Hydroelectric Project (120 MW) on Yamuna River in Uttarakhand	Project Associate - 01	01 Year

Willing candidates may see the details of Ad including requirement of qualification, work experience, terms of conditions of engagement at ICFRE website www.icfre.org - Recruitment (Home page).

Assistant Director General (EM)
ICFRE, Dehradun

PUBLIC NOTICE

M/S TATHASTU REALTY PRIVATE LIMITED
(CIN U70109HR2022PTC123262)

Registered Office: 10th Floor, Tower-B, Vastika Towers, Golf Course Road, Sector-54, Gurgaon, Haryana, India - 122011
E-mail: - con@tathasturealty.com, Phone No. 0124-4544650

Whereas M/s Tathastu Realty Private Limited is in the process of developing an Affordable Group Housing Colony namely "TATHASTU 3rd" situated in Village Mohanmadpur, Gujjar, Sector-35, Tehsil Sohna, District Gurgaon under an area measuring 9.9825 Acres under License No. 131 dated 2023 granted by Director, Town and Country Planning, Haryana and having RERA Registration No. 108 of 2023 dated 04.12.2023.

And Whereas M/s Tathastu Realty Private Limited (hereinafter referred "Company") has applied for change in bank account from ICICI Bank Limited to Indus Bank Limited and accordingly Company has obtained Delegation Letter for change of bank accounts from Haryana Real Estate Regulatory Authority, Gurgaon. Accordingly vide this public notice, the general public is hereby notified/ informed that the following changes in bank accounts.

Particulars	Previous Bank Accounts	New Bank Accounts
Bank Name	ICICI Bank Ltd	Indus Bank Limited
IFSC Code	ICICI0007390	INDB00000005
Master Collection Account No. (100%)	739005000523	256005000161
RERA Account No. (70%)	739005000524	256005000162
Promoter Free Cash Flow Account No. (30%)	739005000520	256005000163

Date: 24.07.2026 Sd/-
Place: Gurugram M/s Tathastu Realty Private Limited

EXPRESS explained.Live

LOSE FAT NOT HEALTH

The science behind weight loss

Dr Anoop Misra
Executive Chairman of Diabetes C-DOC Hospital for Diabetics and Allied Sciences

In conversation with
Rinku Ghosh
Senior Associate Editor
The Indian Express

Scan to Register

Why is losing weight becoming harder despite eating less?

Which diet actually works - intermittent fasting, keto, low-carb, Mediterranean, or calorie counting?

Can you lose weight without giving up your favourite foods?

Why do people regain weight after dieting, and how can the 'yo-yo effect' be prevented?

Do weight-loss medications and injections really work, and who should take them?

How do hormones, sleep, stress, thyroid problems, PMOS and menopause affect weight loss?

29 July 2026

06:00 PM

Join us on **ZOOM**

The Indian EXPRESS
— JOURNALISM OF COURAGE —



Language No Bar

THE CONGRESS' social media team, led by senior party leader Supriya Shrinete, had a tough task at hand on Friday — to translate Congress Parliamentary Party Chairperson Sonia Gandhi's newspaper article on the "education system's collapse" into different regional languages. The social media team didn't rely on Artificial Intelligence for the translations and asked its teams in different states to do the needful. Some senior leaders in the Delhi team also lost their cool when some of the state teams did not give a prompt response. The article by Sonia Gandhi was translated into 11 regional languages, including Telugu, Gujarati and Punjabi, and shared on social media handles in the states.

Rare Coffee Table Book

FORMER COMPTROLLER and Auditor General (CAG) of India Vinod Rai got nostalgic at a gathering on Thursday after being presented with a coffee table book chronicling his life and public service. Authored by BS Chauhan — a 1972-batch Kerala-cadre IAS officer who retired in 2013, Chauhan also presented a copy of the book to the current CAG, K Sanjay Murthy — the book is said to be the first coffee table book dedicated to a former CAG. It offers a glimpse into the life and career of Rai, a 1972-batch Kerala-cadre IAS officer who retired in 2013. Chauhan also presented a copy of the book to the current CAG.

No Network

SEVERAL REPORTERS who came to the National Media Centre in the Capital on Friday afternoon to attend the much-anticipated Cabinet briefing — in the wake of PM Narendra Modi's midnight message indicating crucial steps to prevent paper leaks — were disappointed to learn that mobile Internet services were down at the venue. Officials then managed a Wi-Fi connection to salvage the situation.

Delhi court denies bail to doctor accused in NEET paper leak case

Nirbhay Thakur
New Delhi, July 24

A DELHI court on Friday denied bail to paediatrician Manoj Shirure, one of the accused in the 2026 NEET-UG paper leak case, noting that the leak had caused "disrupt to the nation".

"It is widely known that the paper leak of NEET-UG was severely impacting millions of NEET aspirants in India and abroad. In the case allegations against the accused persons... as presented till date are taken on their face value, the same would prima facie show that in order to satisfy their greed and to gain illegal wealth, they not only sabotaged the entire process of [the]... exam which was supposed to be conducted fairly and flawlessly but by their aforesaid illegal acts, they have also brought disrepute to the nation", Special Judge Ajay Gupta of Rouse Avenue Court said in his order dated July 24.

The allegation against Shirure was that Siddhivinayak Hospital, which he ran in Latur, Maharashtra, was used to "facilitate access to a chemistry question paper in April 2026", ahead of the exam scheduled on May 3.

Will monitor NEET overhaul steps, take those extra miles: SC

Problems being monitored and supervised at highest level: SG

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, July 24

AMID THE ongoing protest in Delhi against paper leaks, the Supreme Court said Friday it would closely monitor the Centre's overhaul of the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (NEET), cautioning that a shift to computer-based testing alone would not eliminate the risk of paper leaks.

The Centre, meanwhile, was assuring the top court it was going "10 extra miles" to safeguard the NEET process.

A bench presided by Justice P S Narasimha, and also comprising Justice Alok Aradhe, was hearing pleas seeking recognition of the NTA following the alleged NEET-UG 2026 question paper leaks.

"We will monitor it, we will see. We will take those extra miles... We cannot let this go on... We will see that this is completely institutionalised and how it works, not just the commoners. We will follow it up throughout the year and see that complete and total institutionalisation takes place," Justice

TOP COURT TO HEAR ON JULY 27 PLEAS AGAINST POLICE EXCESSES ON STUDENTS

The Supreme Court will hear on July 27 two petitions alleging police excesses against students protesting at Jantar Mantar and other places in the country since Monday against the alleged NEET question paper leak. CJI Surya Kant, presiding over a three-judge bench, told Senior Advocates Gopal Sankaranarayanan and Shyam Dewan, "Let it be belated, we will entertain." Sankaranarayanan told the bench, also comprising Justices Jayaprakash Narayan and V Mohana, that there are two petitions dealing with the violence that took place across the country. "There is urgency because this is happening on a daily basis," he said. "The police are using excessive force against children." "It is just going on unabated. Some controls are necessary. The court stands between us and the police," Sankaranarayanan said he was waiting for the court's Registry to grant diary numbers before he could mention the same for an urgent hearing. "We didn't want to mention (the matter) until we got the diary numbers. We have diary numbers and properly constituted petitions. The states are parties," he submitted. ENS

Justice Narasimha said.

At the outset, Solicitor General Tushar Mehta sought more time to file an affidavit in the matter, explaining what is being done to secure the process, and said he will present a "holistic view".

Children's problems will have to be addressed without any reservations. I can assure you from my personal knowledge, it is being monitored, supervised, and everything is being done at the highest executive level," Mehta said.

This comes a day after PM Narendra Modi announced formation of fast-track courts to ensure swift justice in paper leak cases.

Referring to the recommen-

dations of the high-powered committee constituted in 2024 under the former ISRO chairman K Radhakrishnan Committee to overhaul NTA to make the NEET foolproof, the top court then highlighted some points which it said the Centre's proposed affidavit should reflect.

"Last time, we mentioned the Radhakrishnan Committee's recommendations. It specifically refers to the governing body. Your affidavit should indicate exactly what has been done with respect to the board. And this would comprise transparency of the test, nominations and stakeholder equations," Justice Narasimha said.

"So far as the domain-specific requirement... You have

indicated that ITIS, UGC, and Kendriya Vidyalaya Sangathan have been considered, but then it doesn't indicate what progress has been made with respect to the domain experts," Justice Narasimha added.

Justice Narasimha said, "We are focusing on institutionalisation. Ad hocism has troubled us for years." He said the government should also address the aspects of printing and transportation of papers. "I am aware a similar issue arose two years back and we had explained, right from printing to when students get the paper, what the system is in place."

Justice Narasimha referred to the government's decision to delay the IAF to transport question papers this time, saying, "that is only an ad hoc situation, not a permanent one."

Mehta said, "I can assure that with children, there cannot be any adversarial approach. The Radhakrishnan Committee (recommendations) is fully accepted. But we are going beyond that."

Justice Narasimha asked how data would be kept safe when NEET switches to digital mode. "That's very important because when you shift to this, leaks could occur, making data unsafe. And the entire thing breaks down," he said. Mehta said there has been no such instance as of now, but they will have to be careful.

Video of cop 'grabbing' woman misinterpreted: Mumbai Police

Express News Service
Mumbai, July 24

A DAY after a Mumbai Police constable was transferred over a viral video in which he allegedly threatened protesters with a false narcotics case, another video involving a police officer has sparked controversy, with Opposition leaders demanding action.

The latest video, widely circulated on social media, purportedly shows a plainclothes officer grabbing a woman protester as police personnel disperse a crowd.

Mumbai Police rejected allegations of misconduct, saying the video was being misinterpreted. DCP (Operations) Akbar Pathan said senior officers reviewed the footage.

"The video in reference is being irresponsibly misinterpreted. The officer was trying to hold on to a male protester and a woman stepped in while he was looking away," Pathan said.

Congress MP Varsha Gaikwad, who was on the video, tagging CM Devendra Fadnis, and asked why a male officer was physically handling a woman protester. NCP (SP) MLA Rohit Pawar also demanded strict action. BJP spokesperson Navnath Ban accused Pawar of trying to malign Mumbai Police for political gain. Ban said the video showed officers rushing to catch a man in a blue shirt and argued there was no evidence the officer had deliberately misbehaved with the woman.

Suspended constable hands over his badge to Dipke, 'resigns'

Aishwarya Raj
Dehradun, July 24

SAYING HE was extending solidarity with the protesters, a police constable from Uttarakhand "resigned" from his post while on the stage at Jantar Mantar Friday, Uttarakhand Police, however, said later the constable had already been placed under suspension earlier.

The constable, Sher Singh, alleged that the question paper for a patwari post was available at grocery stores. He was registering reports of exam leaks in Uttarakhand since 2021.

"This is Bhagat Singh's coun-

Not a single page related to protests filed on July 22: CJI

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, July 24

CHIEF JUSTICE of India Surya Kant on Friday dismissed as "reckless reporting" that he had denied listing of a plea on July 22 against crackdown on protesters during "Chalo Sansad" march on July 20, and said that "not a single page has been filed" and "only a representation was received".

During the mentioning hours, CJI Kant, presiding over a three-judge bench, said, "In the last two days, a completely false statement was made that a matter has been filed. And the media is absolutely free from all responsibility, falsely reporting that the Chief Justice refused to list the matter." The remarks came when Senior Advocate Shob Alam sought listing of an unrelated matter.

"Until 10 am, I tried to find out, no case had been filed... Not a single page has been filed in the Supreme Court. It was one representation... How can I treat the representation as a writ petition? And people start recklessly reporting this," the CJI said.



LoP Rahul Gandhi with Sahil Lochab in New Delhi on Friday. ANI

Pellet-hit student by his side, Rahul slams Pradhan, says PM must apologise

Asad Rehman
New Delhi, July 24

CONTINUING TO up the ante against the Centre and Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, LoP Sahil Lochab on Friday addressed reporters along with a student protester who had suffered pellet gun injuries in police action amid the protest in the national capital against paper leaks on July 20.

Gandhi said Pradhan must be removed, action must be taken against the personnel who shot at protesters with pellet guns and lathicharged them, and PM Narendra Modi should apologise to students.

"My brother was struck by a pellet gun when he was peacefully protesting with a Tricolour," said Gandhi, pointing to 19-year-old Sahil Lochab while addressing reporters outside CPP chief Sonia Gandhi's 10, Janpath residence.

Gandhi lifted Sahil's T-shirt to show his injuries to the media and said the teenager also risked losing vision in an eye damaged by pellets. "This has happened to thousands of youth. They have been shot at with pellet guns and have been beaten up

in lathicharge," Gandhi said. Sahil, who was allegedly hit by the pellet gun in his right eye, said he demands justice.

The LoP said Sahil had written an exam for recruitment in the police force but the question paper was leaked. "His (Sahil's) parents, from their hard-earned money, had got him this opportunity (to appear for the exam). The government must stop lying. It has attacked our future," he said.

"They (protesters) are saying three things — the Education Minister, because of whom the students are protesting and paper leaks happened, must be removed; action must be taken against those who have fired at our future and beat them with lathis; and Narendra Modi... should apologise to students," Gandhi said. "Stop assailing and threatening our students."

Later, in a post on X, Gandhi wrote: "Sahil is a student at Delhi University. He drives a car part-time to support his family. Like thousands of others, he too is a victim of paper leaks — the SSC Delhi Constable exam in 2025. Now he's worried that the SSC has chosen the same vendor again, and that the paper might leak again."

Govt orders GitHub to block Bitchat app that works without Internet

Soumyarendra Barik
New Delhi, July 24

AMID REPEATED mobile Internet shutdowns around Delhi's Jantar Mantar, the site of the ongoing students' protests, the government has directed GitHub to disable access to repositories hosting Bitchat, an offline messaging application developed by Twitter co-founder Jack Dorsey.

"The government of India does not like technologies like Bitchat and wants it taken down," said Jack Dorsey, platform's co-founder. Dorsey also shared a copy of the blocking order by Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C), under the MHA, issued to GitHub on July 23. According to the order copy shared by Dorsey, I4C said the app could be used to evade lawful surveillance and coordinate unlawful assemblies during restrictions on Internet services.

The order invoked Section 79(3)(b) of the IT Act, 2008, along with Rule 3(1)(d) of the IT

Rules, 2021, and asked GitHub to disable access to three repositories linked to Bitchat within three hours. The URLs include the app's main source-code repository, its Android repository and a page used to distribute its Android installation file.

Bitchat is an open-source, decentralised messaging app that can allow users located near each other to communicate without mobile data, Wi-Fi, phone numbers or centralised servers. Its offline mode uses Bluetooth Low Energy to connect nearby phones, with each device capable of relaying messages to others and thereby extending the network's reach.

The order, shared by Dorsey, said the app's design "creates a substantial risk of misuse by anti-national elements, terrorist organisations, organised criminal groups, and cybercriminals seeking to evade lawful detection" despite "legally imposed restrictions".

Queries sent to Home Ministry remained unanswered until publication.

With bipartisan support, how House passed 2024 anti-paper leak Act

Vikas Pathak
New Delhi, July 24

Barely two-and-a-half months before the 2024 Lok Sabha elections, the then Narendra Modi government brought the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Bill, 2024, in Parliament, which sought to prevent "unfair means" in order to "bring greater transparency, fairness and credibility to the public examinations system".

These exams include common entrance tests and government recruitment exams conducted by "public examination authorities" such as the UPSC and NTA, among others. The Bill was passed by both Houses in February 2024 during the Budget Session.

Amid its current standoff with students and protesters led by the CJP, the Modi govern-

ment is planning to amend the 2024 Bill to make it more stringent.

Piloting the Bill in Lok Sabha on February 6, 2024, Union Minister Jitendra Singh underlined that while the Bill seeks to punish officials or organisations that indulge in various exam malpractices, including leaks of question papers and tampering of answersheets, students or candidates will not come under its purview.

While the Act stipulates a prison term of three to five years and a fine up to Rs 10 lakh for any person resorting to unfair means in exams, it provides for a jail term up to 10 years and a fine over Rs 1 crore, in cases of "organised" paper leaks.

The Bill had bipartisan support in both Houses. Introducing the Bill in LS,

Singh flagged media reports about 18-year-old Niharika Solanki, a JEE aspirant from Kota, who had died by suicide two days before exam on 31 January 2024. The minister quoted from the girl's suicide note: "Mummy, papa, please forgive me. I cannot do it. I am the worst daughter."

In all provisions made for the youth in the last 10 years, it has been seen that there is transparency and that the youth get opportunities in keeping with their talent (prati-bha), ability (gyavata) and hard work (parishram)," Singh had said.

He noted that most of the exams were now computer-based to ensure transparency.

Singh pointed out that there have been complaints in recent years that question papers have been leaked, citing instances of impersonation and papers being sold outside the exam centres. He gave an example from his post where the TMC-ruled West Bengal in 2022, the then Congress-ruled Rajasthan during 2019-2022, and J&K between 2017 and 2022.

Supporting the Bill, Congress MP K Suresh had urged the government to use the latest technology to ensure that there were no exam irregularities. Then Congress leader in LS, Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury, had said that the Bill "lacks preventive measures to reduce such acts".

DMK MP D M Kathir Anand also said that the Bill "only talks about imprisonment, punish-

ment and fine", adding that it has "not said anything about how these malpractices can be controlled".

In his reply, the ministers said that "punishment itself is a deterrent meant for prevention".

While supporting the Bill, NCP (SP) leader Supriya Sule said that the Bill "would make a mockery of the TMC-ruled West Bengal in 2022, the then Congress-ruled Rajasthan during 2019-2022, and J&K between 2017 and 2022."

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He mentioned, and therefore, we have identified and tried to define 'unfair means' in the conduct of exams to the best of our ability." "If the magnitude of the crime goes beyond an extent, it will fall in the domain of the BNS or the erstwhile IPC."

In Rajya Sabha, the Bill was taken up on February 9, 2024. Jitendra Singh again cited the Kota girl's suicide note, saying that "We have huge stakes in the youth who comprise over 70% of India's population and, therefore, none of us would like vital youth energy and youth power to be sacrificed to the altar of a handful of selfish interests."

The order invoked Section 79(3)(b) of the IT Act, 2008, along with Rule 3(1)(d) of the IT

Commercial vessel attacked in Black Sea, Indian killed

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, July 24

AN INDIAN seafarer was killed in an attack on a ship while it was reportedly transiting Russian territorial waters in the Black Sea on July 18, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said on Friday. This came to light days after four Indians were among 10 killed in an attack on a commercial vessel off the coast of Ukraine on July 19.

"It has come to our attention that on July 18, the commercial vessel MV OMORFI was attacked while transiting the Black Sea, reportedly in Russian territorial waters. At the time of the incident, there were 10 crew members on board, including three Indian nationals," the MEA said.

"As per available information, one Indian national tragically lost his life in the attack. We extend our deepest condolences to the bereaved family of the deceased. The other two Indian nationals on board are reported to be alive," MEA said.

It said the Indian mission in Russia has reached out to the relevant authorities and is making efforts to extend all possible assistance to the affected family.

"India unequivocally condemns such attacks targeting commercial shipping and plac-

ing the lives of innocent civilian crew members at risk. It is a matter of serious concern that the freedom of navigation and international commerce is facing increasing threats," the MEA said.

"India calls upon all concerned parties to uphold international obligations to ensure the safety and security of maritime navigation and uninterrupted flow of global commerce."

On Tuesday, New Delhi had summoned the Russian charge d'affaires following the killing of the four Indians in the strike on the MV Golden Leo vessel on July 19.

In response to Moscow indicating that the ship in Black Sea was targeted for carrying military supplies for Ukraine, India on Friday said that the vessel was carrying "grain" as cargo.

During a weekly briefing, the Ministry of External Affairs' official spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal, while responding to Kremlin spokesperson Dmitry Peskov's comments, said: "As per information made available to us from the Directorate General of Maritime Administration, India, MV Golden Leo, the Guinea-Bissau-flagged commercial vessel involved in the tragic incident in the Odessa port, had loaded grain as cargo prior to departure on 19 July 2026."

Boulders roll down on taxii Lahaul-Spiti, infant among 13 killed

Saurabh Parashar
Shimla, July 24

ALL 13 occupants of a taxi, including a six-month-old child, were killed as massive boulders suddenly fell from a hill and crushed the moving vehicle in Himachal Pradesh's Lahaul and Spiti on Friday, police said. The overloaded taxi, a Tata Sumo, also caught fire in the incident that took place near Kuddu Nala on the Udaipur-Killad road, they said.

While Deputy Commissioner, Lahaul and Spiti, Kiran Badana confirmed that 13 people have died in the accident, local MLA Anuradha Rana said 10 victims deceased belonged to Pangi in Chamba district, while three, including a woman and her infant, were from Lahaul and Spiti.

According to the preliminary information, the passengers had remained stranded overnight at Tindi as the Udaipur-Killad road was closed for traffic the previous day. They set off for Pangi in the morning after the road reopened.

Apart from the infant, the victims include seven men and four women. They were identified as Bir Singh, Buti Singh,



Wreckage of the vehicle in Lahaul-Spiti on Friday. PTI

Bir Singh, Kamla Kumari, Anil Kumar, Rekha, Saurabh Singh, Anjana, Soman Angmo, Aaru (the infant), Sanjay Kumar and Hans Raj, DC Badana said.

MLA Rana said, "The weather was clear, but there were reports of shooting stones in the area. All the bodies were recovered from the mangled vehicle and taken to the Civil Hospital at Udaipur for post-mortem examination."

Rana said there was no telecommunication signal at the accident spot and she used a satellite phone to reach out to SP (Lahaul-Spiti) Shivani Mehra for carrying out rescue and relief operations.

Personnel from the Border Roads Organisation (BRO) reached the spot as did police teams from Lahaul and Tindi, and officials from Udaipur administration and other emergency agencies.

Expressing grief, Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu directed that all possible assistance be provided to the next of kin of the deceased.

In a separate incident, a woman died and seven people were injured in a landslide in Mandi.

The Shimla Met office, meanwhile, issued an orange warning of heavy to very heavy rain state from July 27 to 29.

Ken-Betwa stir claims its first win, activist suspends fast

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, July 24

EIGHTEEN DAYS after beginning an indefinite hunger strike against alleged irregularities in the rehabilitation of families affected by the Ken-Betwa Link Project in Madhya Pradesh, Jai Kisan Sangathan leader Amal Bhatnagar on Friday suspended his fast, saying the agitation had achieved its "first success" after the state agreed to conduct fresh village-level surveys to identify families left out of compensation and rehabilitation.

Bhatnagar, who has been leading the Ken-Betwa Chita Andolan, said he was ending only the indefinite fast and not the movement itself.

"After achieving the first success of this 18-day indefinite fast, I am suspending my hunger strike today. But this struggle has not ended. From today, I am taking a pledge of 'Nay Satyagrah'. Until the last eligible person receives justice under the project, I will not rest."

I will go from village to village, lead this movement, cooperate with every positive step taken by the administration and monitor every promise. If required, the next phase of the agitation will also begin," he said.

The rehabilitation process concerns villages falling within the Daudh Dam submergence zone. Bhatnagar had alleged that hundreds of eligible families were excluded from rehabilitation lists, that compensation assessments were flawed, and that Gram Sabha proceedings contained irregularities.

According to Bhatnagar, district authorities have agreed to form joint teams comprising officials and representatives of the Jai Kisan Sangathan to conduct fresh village-by-village surveys in Chhatrapur district and include every eligible family that had been left out.

• BRIEFLY



Devotees during the Bahuda Yatra in Puri on Friday. ANI

ODISHA

Devotee dies of 'suffocation' in Puri amid massive procession rush

A DEVOTEE died of suffocation amid a big rush of people who attended the Bahuda Yatra, or the return chariot procession, of Lord Jagannath in Puri on Friday, officials said. According to health department officials, the 57-year-old man from Cuttack collapsed in the crowd while pulling the chariot. He was immediately rushed to the nearby health centre and then to the Puri district headquarters hospital, where doctors declared him dead. Officials said that as per a preliminary report, the deceased had high blood pressure. More than 100 people suffered health issues amid the big rush and humid conditions during the Bahuda Yatra on Friday. "Most of the patients were discharged from hospital after preliminary treatment," an official said. ENS

Boy falls off auto, dies after being run over by lorry

A SEVEN-YEAR-OLD boy died after falling from an auto-rickshaw while returning from school and being run over by a lorry in Kerala's Kozhikode district on Friday, police said. The deceased was identified as Amal, a Class 2 student. According to police, the incident occurred around 4 pm when Amal was returning home in an auto-rickshaw. When the vehicle reached Pulpuramba, its door accidentally opened and the child fell onto the road, police said. A lorry travelling behind the auto-rickshaw ran over the boy, killing him on the spot, they said. PTI

2 workers killed in factory blast in Saharanpur

TWO MIGRANT workers were killed while two others were missing after an explosion took place at a fireworks factory in Saharanpur district in UP on Friday. Twenty three labourers from Madhya Pradesh were employed at the factory in Gangah area, police said. The deceased were identified as Deepraj Devde, 23, and Sandeep, 25. Their bodies have been sent for post-mortem examination. The factory premises have been sealed. With no trace of the two missing workers, police suspect they may have fled the scene out of fear following the blast. ENS

Shah dials kin of policeman killed in Anantnag terror attack

Naveed Iqbal
Srinagar, July 24

UNION HOME Minister Amit Shah Friday dialled the family of the policeman who was killed in Anantnag on July 22. Head Constable Ashiq Hussain Qureshi, a resident of Budgam, was posted with the Indian Reserve Police and attached with the Special Operations Group, was on Amarnath Yatra duty.

The J&K Police said that a militant fired at Qureshi from point blank range near Lalchowk in Anantnag.

BJP's Sunil Sharma, Leader of the Opposition in the J&K Assembly, visited the family on Friday to offer condolences. During the visit, the LOP facilitated the call between Qureshi's son Absar and the HM during which Shah offered his condolences to the family. Qureshi is survived by his wife and three children.

J&K Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha also visited Beerwah to meet the family members of Qureshi. Sinha paid tribute to the policeman and conveyed his condolences to the bereaved family. He said the entire nation is proud of the brave heart "whose courage, sacrifice, and devotion to duty will remain etched in our collective memory."

He assured the family that the administration stands firmly with them and will ensure their well-being and dignity. The LG also assured full support to the family until Qureshi's son finishes his studies and becomes eligible for a compassionate government appointment.

Now Bengal: Led by BJP leader, prayers held outside 650-year-old mosque

Ravik Bhattacharya
Kolkata, July 24

A MANDIR-MASJID row is brewing now in West Bengal as a Hindu right-wing group, led by a BJP leader, conducts prayers near a 650-year-old mosque which it claims was once a temple, in Malda district. On the coming Monday, the 'Adinath Puratan Shiv Mandir' organisation plans to install a big Shiva Lingam outside the mosque.

Built in 1373 AD by Sikandar Shah, the Adina Masjid in Pundia, Malda, is considered by the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) to have been the biggest mosque in medieval times in the entire subcontinent. However, Hindu groups and the BJP have been claiming that it came up in the place of an 'Adinath Temple', dedicated to Lord Shiva.

Kajal Goswami, the chief patron of the Adinath Puratan Shiv Mandir and a convener of the BJP's 'Good Governance Wing' for North Bengal, says: "There are Hindu and Buddhist statues in the so-called mosque. The Adinath Temple was destroyed to build a mosque on it."

The organisation claims many Hindu and Buddhist motifs are present in the mosque, apart from a Shiva Lingam, and says it will approach the Calcutta High Court soon seeking an ASI report on the issue.

"Our aim is to restore the temple and place the Shiva Lingam inside it," Goswami says. A 36-ft-high Shiva Lingam, weigh-



The Adina Masjid in Malda was built in 1373 AD. SOURCE: ASI

ing 1.5 tonnes, is being brought from Tarakeswar, 289 km away, for installation near the mosque.

"But we will follow the law," Goswami stresses. "We do not want a law and order problem. We have already held a meeting with representatives of the ASI and police, and they told us to do puja outside the mosque area."

Calling the mosque "a historic monument", a senior ASI official confirmed to *The Indian Express* that their representatives had held a meeting with the organisers of the prayers. "Nothing will be allowed inside the monument. Police deployment has been increased. We are also increasing our staff strength." No prayers are currently held inside the mosque.

Recently, the Malda district police issued an advisory saying it had heard about social media posts claiming that "certain individuals intend to visit Adina Monument and perform religious rituals, including puja and other ceremonies."

The general public is hereby informed that Adina Monument is a Centrally Protected Monument of National Importance under the Archaeological Survey of India and is governed by the provisions of the Ancient Monuments and Archaeological Sites and Remains Act, 1958 (AMASR Act). No religious rituals or any other unauthorized activities are permitted within the protected monument premises," the statement added, warning strict legal action in case of any violation.

It was on December 5, 2025, that — months to go for West Bengal Assembly elections — BJP Rajya Sabha MP and current Bengal president Samik Bhattacharya scaled the same up, to Parliament.

In his statement in the House, he said, "The Adina Mosque... was constructed in 1373 AD by Sultan Sikandar

Shah of Bengal Sultanate. This mosque was built using material from pre-existing Hindu and Buddhist structures. Local traditions and historical accounts suggest that the site was originally home to Adinath Temple dedicated to Lord Shiva and Lord Vishnu. The presence of Hindu iconography within the mosque and architecture supports this assertion."

Adding that "the Adinath Temple needs to be protected at any cost", Bhattacharya said: "It is one of those thousands of temples which, following the invasion of West Bengal, were destroyed by the invading hordes... I hope that the Government of India, the Archaeological Survey of India, will look into the matter seriously."

Speaking to *The Indian Express*, BJP Rajya Sabha MP and former West Bengal chief Rahul Sinha compared the dispute to the Ayodhya Babri Masjid row. "A lot of emotions and religious sentiments prevail in connection with the Adinath Temple. Like Ram Mandir and other temples, it was also destroyed and a mosque built on it... The religious sentiment surrounding the temple should not be ignored, and truth must prevail."

CPI(M) state secretary and Politburo member MD Salim said it was a familiar playbook of the BJP. "The BJP or RSS, whenever they get a foothold, they start this. In the first stage, they bring in religious activities. Then they create conflict and division. The Adina Mosque is the latest example."

• ONE OF THE CONVICTS, A JUVENILE AT THE TIME OF THE 1999 ATTACK, HAS EMBRACED CHRISTIANITY, SAYS 'IT BROUGHT ME INNER PEACE'

Village where Staines was killed lives with regret, fears Dara Singh's return

Sujit Bisoi
Manoharpur (Keonjhar), July 24

MANOHARPUR LIVES with regret — regret of the fire that killed Australian Christian missionary Graham Staines and his two minor sons 27 years ago in this Santal village of Odisha. The possibility now that the main accused, Ravindra Pal alias Dara Singh, a former Bajrang Dal member who is serving a life term, may get premature release has brought the memories back.

Along with apprehension of what it might mean for the village that, on the face of it, is a long way from that night of January 22-23, 1999 — dotted by pucca houses and roads; marked by a police station that came up after the Staines kill-

ings, and has not seen any communal violence since; and home now to many more tribals who have embraced Christianity, among them a juvenile who was convicted in the murders.

Laxmi Hansdah, in her 60s, sads repeat: "That night will stay with me until I die. Why are you asking about it now?"

Dara, lodged in Keonjhar District Jail, moved the Supreme Court in 2024 seeking remission, appealing that he had spent 24 years in prison and that he repented acting as he did, "in a fit of youthful rage". The SC has directed the Odisha government to take a call on the matter within a month.

Dara, who was 37 when arrested, belongs to UP and it is not clear where he will choose to settle down if released.

Another accused in the case who was also serving life, Mahendra Hembram, came out on parole last year.

A villager, who does not want to be named, says he was a child in 1999 but remembers what happened enough to sads repeat: "We are living in harmony... Whether Dara is released or not is up to the government and court, but it should not trigger problems in the village."

Ojen Hansdah, who was convicted for the Staines killing and spent six years in jail before being acquitted in 2005, is also repentant, though he claims he was framed. Partially paralysed, Hansdah says: "I don't know what exactly happened. It shouldn't have happened..."

Hansdah's nephew was the only juvenile convict in the case

• In Odisha's Keonjhar



and spent nine years in a juvenile home before being freed in 2008. Now 38 and a father of two, he talks of "regret" too, while asserting that he was an unwitting participant in the attack. "A mob came and started attacking the vehicles."



At Manoharpur village, where Graham Staines and his two minor sons were killed in 1999

and introspection..."

Asked about allegations of forcible conversion, including by Staines, Chetan Murmu, the pastor at a newly built church-cum-prayer house in the village who knew the missionary well, suggests the numbers say it all. Only seven of the over 250 households in the village were Christian when Staines and his sons were killed. "Now 41 families follow Christianity."

Talking about how Staines, who ran a centre for leprosy afflicted, helped his daughter, Murmu, 60, says releasing Dara would set a wrong precedent. "Staines was a victim of hate crime and his killers should not be allowed to walk free... And why did they kill his two innocent children?"

While he was in the Opposition, Chief Minister Mohan

Charan Majhi, who represents the Keonjhar Assembly constituency, had supported the demand for Dara's release.

Keonjhar BJP MP Aananta Nayak also supports it, saying Dara has already received his punishment.

Hembram, who was given life for Staines's killing and was released in April last year on grounds of "good behaviour", says he himself has "no regrets". "Staines was a missionary, who was invading our culture and forcing people to convert. The attack happened in a fit of rage by an angry mob."

Then just 21 and a final-year student doing his graduation, Hembram says he once dreamed of becoming an official "to serve the community". "It's all over now," he says, adding that no one in the village

wants to associate with him since his release. He lives at his late elder brother's home and gets by on the Rs 10,000-Rs 15,000 monthly given by the 'Dara Sena', a little-known self-constituted fighter for Hinduism and for Dara Singh.

Hembram, 48, says he too is fighting for the release of Dara, "my elder brother", and visits him regularly in jail.

Staines arrived in Mayurbhanj in 1965. In 1999, he drove down with sons, 10 and 6, for the annual jungle camp in Manoharpur. On January 22, Staines and his sons went to sleep in their station wagon. Around midnight, the camp was attacked.

Hembram says he has one regret. "We were not aware his (Staines's) kids were inside the station wagon."

The Big Picture

SATURDAY, JULY 25, 2026

9

They sang, took selfies, shouted till their voices went hoarse, and flooded social media with memes. As Delhi witnesses an unprecedented youth-led protest, THE INDIAN EXPRESS hears from the new protester

BY DRISHTI JAIN, VIDHEESHA KUNTAMALLA, TRISHA MUKHERJEE & DEVANSH MITTAL

MEET THE PROTESTER AT JANTAR MANTAR YOUNG, ANGRY & VERY GENZ



Unlike in past protests, there is a different kind of solidarity. Many of the youngsters came with their parents — a mother from Ballabgarh, a young father

"But my privilege gives me the ability to show up. It would be easier to sit at home and say this isn't my fight. All that people endured... it is reduced to nothing if we don't come back," she says.

Sanjay Srivastava, anthropologist and sociologist at Distinguished Research Professor at SOAS University of London, says the current protest changes how Delhi's spaces are experienced. "Delhi is historically a very exclusionary city. It was designed by the British to be deeply segregated. An ironic consequence of the traditional political gathering is that it reinforces the segregated nature of the city, one that mimics Indian society itself: Dalit causes are mainly championed by Dalits, Sikh ones by Sikhs and religious ones by followers of those religions. In the current protests, what makes people show up is the fact that each can invent their own reasons for being there as, beyond the idea of an economic future, there are no other defining ideologies."

'I am not scared anymore'

This time, unlike in past protests, there is a different kind of solidarity. Many of the youngsters came with their parents — a mother from Ballabgarh in Haryana who had accompanied her daughter and friends who were volunteering at the site, a young father who stood with his son perched on his shoulders, a single parent with her 22-year-old daughter.

But Samreen, 24, from a Northeast Delhi neighbourhood, had to be at Jantar Mantar on her own. Her parents wouldn't have approved, so she told them that she was going to the library and headed to the protest site instead. The second of five siblings, Samreen graduated from Jamia Millia Islamia with a Master's degree in History six months ago. It's a milestone that has come after several arguments over marriage with her parents — her father is an electrician and mother, a homemaker. "I have held off for so long. I keep telling my parents, let me first secure a future, then I'll think of marriage," she says.

But it's getting difficult to hold on to that position, says Samreen. She took the UGC-NET examination for the second time this year. Like her first attempt, this one too was marred by allegations of paper leaks. "Even with a degree from a good university, I'm still struggling to achieve my dreams," she says.

Like Samreen, many of the women who had turned up for the protest carried with them a natural resilience, honed by their daily struggles.

Pratishtha, 40, from Thane, Maharashtra, is in Delhi on work — "at least that's what my family thinks," she laughs. Her medicine supply business often brings her to Delhi, but this time, she has spent more time at the protest. "I have been here for 22 days," she says outside Kutty's, the popular dosa joint near Jantar Mantar, during a break from the protest. Her husband and two children, one in Class 10, the other in Class 8, are back in Thane.

"My parents allowed me to study, but once marriage and kids happened, I had to give up a lot. But hopefully, my sacrifices will amount to something," she says.

Pointing to the many women at the protest site, she says, "How times have changed. Look at all these girls. After all these years, I am not scared anymore. As a mother, I am here to protect my children's future, what they grow up to be in my hands."

'Never attended a protest'

On July 20, hours after protesters clashed with police in Delhi, at Jantar Mantar, 16-year-old Raj Kumar, from Saidabad in Prayagraj, stood on a ledge holding a placard. It's a wobbly platform, so Sajid, 34, stands at the other end to balance it.

Raj says he "ran away from home" to participate in the protest and informed his parents only after he arrived at Jantar Mantar. The call was made from Sajid's phone. Since then, Sajid has taken the teenager under his wings, looking out for him in the crowd, ensuring he has eaten and has a space to sleep at night. "He is like my child. I have two boys back home in Ajmer (Rajasthan) — a four-year-old and a 15-month-old. I miss my children, but Raj inspires me to keep going," says Sajid, stopping to ask a woman not to lean on the ledge, worried Raj might fall.

On the pavement to the right of the stage, Harsh Swamy, 26, and Ujjwal Yadav, 20, huddle under the tarpaulin to shelter their backpacks from the rain. "Neither of us had attended a protest before, and I was just telling *bhai* what an experience it has been," says Ujjwal.

Harsh had arrived from Jaipur the previous night and Ujjwal that morning from Etah in UP. "We started talking because both of us are UPSC aspirants, and we soon connected over how distressing this NEET paper leak has been. What if it happens with UPSC as well?" says Harsh.

Elsewhere at the protest site, Pushpa Kumari, a former corporate employee, sits with Anjali Saini, a homemaker, and Neetu Singh, who sells hair oil. They have been there essentials for a living. They met each other on the mat below the stage, where they now rest and sleep, at different points during the course of the past 20 days.

Neetu was the first to arrive with her 14-year-old daughter and nine-year-old son Vaibhav from Agra. Then, came Anjali, who has been at the site for nearly a week, from Delhi. Pushpa has been there four days ago. Nearly 96 hours and a *lathi* charge later, the three women now finish each other's sentences. "It is because of her that my son didn't get hurt," says Neetu, pointing towards Pushpa. "The police were charging at him with a *lathi* and she pulled him back," says Anjali.

AS THEY made their way through the heaving crowd at Delhi's Jantar Mantar, Shivam, 21, held his mother's hand, his arm in a tight grip around her shoulder.

For the last two days, the mother and son from an East Delhi neighbourhood have been parking their two-wheeler at Shivam's father's office nearby, and walking down to Jantar Mantar, the site of one of the biggest youth-led protests in Delhi in recent times.

A student of Electronics and Communication Engineering at a university in Noida, Shivam says he turned up for the protest because he has been anxious about job prospects. "Honestly, I'm very scared. Many of my seniors have not been able to find jobs. Some of them work as Blinkit delivery partners or drive for Rapido," he says. "My parents keep hoping I'll get a good job. But if I end up as a Rapido driver, it will break their hearts."

Holding on to Shivam in the crowd, his mother says, "Every parent dreams that their child will study hard, earn a good living, and live with dignity. But now I am scared when I read about children committing suicides when they don't get into colleges or don't get jobs. Look at all these children... It breaks my heart to see them sleeping on stone slabs, and in tents without fans."

After nearly three weeks of protests by the Cockerroach Janata Party (CJP) seeking the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over the recent NEET paper leak, on July 20, as protesters stormed the heart of Delhi, police pushed back with force, using *lathis* and tear gas.

With that, what started as an exam controversy has turned into an agitation against stacked up grievances of the country's youth — from shrinking employment opportunities to stagnant real incomes.

Initially, the response was lukewarm and it looked like the CJP protest would go the way many others at Jantar Mantar have in the past, too insular for an indifferent city. But that changed when socialist activist Sonam Wangchuk, who was on hunger strike at the site, was moved to hospital. Suddenly, the tide changed. A generation often accused of being too apathetic, too entitled, looked up from their screens. This was no longer about one exam, one paper leak.

Yogendra Yadav, member of Swaraj India and national convener of Bharat Jodo Abhiyan, says the crowd at Jantar Mantar are forcing older generations to confront their own misconceptions about young Indians. "Those of us with grey hair, we tend to somehow believe that people younger to us are no good, especially about politics. Our general impression has been that they are given to comfort... they are non-political, which is a lot of misunderstanding of the new generation, and also a lot of rose-tinted picture of our own generation. The problem is not that the younger generation does not have its own understanding of politics... it is that we have not made an effort to tune into their grammar of politics," Yadav says.

Cautioning against reading the protest simply as middle-class mobilisation, he says what stands out to him is the visible participation of Dalits and Scheduled Caste organisations — "not merely as representatives of Scheduled Castes or reservation politics, but as people claiming the right to shape the country's larger conversation on education and the future."

'Feels like doors are closing'

Twenty-year-old Ayush, who recently graduated with a Bachelors in Engineering from a private university in Kanpur, starts his first job in Gurgaon in a week. But far from being excited, he says, he is gripped by a sense of anxiety.

"About 30 seniors from my college were let go within a year of being hired. The average salary has stayed around Rs. 30,000 for years, with more roles turning out to be internships. AI is automating entry-level jobs, government exams are either leaked or delayed for years. It feels like all doors are closed to us," says Ayush.

So on May 16, when he saw CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke's first tweet — "What if all cockroaches come together?" — Ayush immediately followed him on social media and has, since then, been watching his every reel.

"Coincidentally, the time in June when I came to Gurgaon from Kanpur for a job interview was when CJP was also organising their first protest at Jantar Mantar. That was the first time I was attending a protest, because our college doesn't allow protests," he says.

Since then, Ayush has kept coming back; he has visited the protest site around four times so far.

Anil Raj is not a NEET aspirant, he clarifies. Yet, for five days now, he has been coming to Delhi's Jantar Mantar to protest against the "country's education system". At 30, the graduate from Malpuri, Uttar Pradesh, senses a ticking clock — he is still without a job.

"I wanted to be in the police. I worked hard for the UP Police recruitment exam and appeared for the exam in 2024, but the paper was leaked. Then, I appeared for the Home Guard exam in Agra in 2025, but then too, there were allegations that the paper was sold for Rs 48 lakh before we reached the exam hall," says Raj. He is now studying B.Pharm "as a backup".

On July 19, he took a train to Delhi to join the protests at Jantar Mantar. "I have rented a room for Rs 7,000 a month in Gurgaon and have been staying here for the past five days. I will stay here until Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan resigns," he says. "My parents gave up their dreams to give me an education. I can't let that go to waste by not speaking up," he says, wiping his face with a sweat-soaked *gamcha*.

The frustrations voiced by Shivam, Ayush and Anil are reflected in India's labour market. According to data from the Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy (CMIE), the share of working-age Indians (15 years and above) with a job has fallen from 42.7% in 2016-17 to 38.7% by March 2026.

While the number of people employed increased from 406 million to 438 million over the period, the additional employment has failed to keep pace with a much faster growth in the country's working-age population.

'Not just about exams now'

Even for Delhi, a city that has witnessed some of the most defining political protests, including the more recent India Against Corruption agitation in 2011 and the 2020-

21 farmer protests, the current one brought out a new side of the city and its people.

In the days since July 18, protesters have been pouring into the road adjacent to the 18th century observatory to express their solidarity. Many of the youngsters, even among those from Delhi, were there for the first time. They came armed with posters — some acerbic in the way youngsters can be, others peppered with witty one-liners — and, of course, their precious phones on which they shot selfies and recorded their friends, the slogans, the speeches. Once the protests wound down, they would sit hunched over their phones to create memes, that baffling combination of video, irony and word play that has become the movement's unofficial language.

There were also those who came in solidarity.

For over a week, Nundrisga Wakhloo, a 34-year-old documentary filmmaker, has been visiting the protest site, mostly during the nights with her friends. "Here, I feel

safer than ever, even at night. It is beautiful to see so many people come together," she says. "This is not just about exams anymore. It's about not being heard for so many years. Young people are beginning to vote, beginning to ask questions. If this generation feels unheard, what have we really got?"

Listing the slow buildup of anxieties among youngsters, from unemployment to shrinking space for dissent in educational institutions, she says, "Education is the first place where narratives are shaped. When you change education, when truth itself begins to feel negotiable, this protest becomes about much more than one incident. I don't think most people at the protest site have anything to do with the NEET exam. People have been coming to stand with the students because they recognised something of themselves in what was happening."

The daughter of architect parents, who graduated from Delhi University's Gargi College, identifies herself as "somewhat privileged" in many ways.



SEVA SANKALP SAMARPAN

DAYS
of

BUILDING TOMORROW'S BIHAR

FASTER GROWTH, BETTER GOVERNANCE,
BRIGHTER FUTURE

TRANSFORMING EDUCATION FOR A FUTURE-READY BIHAR

- 211 new degree colleges inaugurated, ensuring higher education reaches every block of Bihar and expanding access to quality education statewide.
- Announcement of an Artificial Intelligence & Computer Science University (Bhagalpur), an Architecture & Civil Engineering University (Muzaffarpur), and approval for 4 new private universities to strengthen higher education and innovation.
- Under Saat Nischaay-3 (2025-30), Saraswati Vidya Niketan model schools to be established across all 534 blocks, with 155 government and aided schools upgraded in line with NEP 2020.
- Model schools will offer smart classrooms, science & ICT labs, libraries, digital learning, weekly assessments, remedial classes, and NET/JEE coaching, bringing quality education closer to students.
- Focus on academic excellence, digital integration, skill development, and equitable access, creating a modern, inclusive, and future-ready education ecosystem for Bihar.



SAHAYOG SHIVIR TRANSPARENT & CITIZEN-CENTRIC GOVERNANCE

- State-Level Sahayog Shivir launched to ensure transparent, impartial, and time-bound grievance redressal, with citizen satisfaction as the key measure of success.
- Application Receipt Centre and Sahayog Path inaugurated to strengthen public access to grievance redressal services.
- During the inaugural camp, 129 applications were received, with 100 grievances resolved on the spot, demonstrating responsive governance.
- Critically directed to ensure quality disposal of complaints within 30 days, with strict action against delays or negligence.



BIHAR'S HELI-TOURISM

INITIATIVE GIVES NEW WINGS TO TRAVEL
AND ECONOMIC GROWTH



DRIVING INDUSTRIAL GROWTH & BUILDING AN AI-ENABLED BIHAR

- The government is creating an investment-friendly ecosystem by accelerating industrial approvals, expanding industrial land availability, strengthening MSMEs, and promoting employment-intensive sectors.
- Priority sectors include Manufacturing, Food Processing, Textiles & Leather, Electronics, Renewable Energy, and Biotech industries to drive industrialisation and job creation.
- A new Unified Industrial Policy is being developed to integrate multiple sectoral policies into a single, simplified investment framework for investors.
- Within three months, the government announced 11 Mega Industrial Parks and a 50,000-acre industrial land bank to meet future investment and industrial infrastructure requirements.
- Alongside industrial expansion, Bihar is pursuing an AI-driven IT agenda focused on AI adoption, digital governance, IT modernisation, and positioning Bihar as an emerging AI-enabled technology hub.



STRENGTHENING BIHAR'S PUBLIC HEALTHCARE SYSTEM

- to bring advanced care closer to people.
- BHARVIA Portal integrated with ABHA to digitally manage patient registration, prescriptions, referrals, treatment history, and Electronic Health Records (EHR), ensuring seamless and technology-enabled healthcare delivery.
- All district hospitals to provide 24x7 ICU, emergency, ambulance, and X-ray services, with mandatory digital registration of doctors, paramedics, duty rosters, and patient records; referrals to require medical justification and AI/ML ambulance support.
- District-Level Monitoring Committees and state-level weekly reviews introduced to monitor referrals, prevent unnecessary patient transfers, and ensure an accountable, patient-centric, public healthcare system.



CITIZEN-CENTRIC GOVERNANCE IN BIHAR-DOORSTEP PROPERTY REGISTRATION

- Under Saat Nischaay-3, "Sabka Samman, Jeevan Aasani", Bihar has introduced doorstep property registration for citizens aged 80 years and above, ensuring dignity, convenience, and ease of living.
- Eligible senior citizens can register land, flats, and other immovable properties from the comfort of their homes, eliminating the need to visit registration offices.
- Appointments can be booked through the e-Registration Portal, after which a Mobile Registration Unit visits the applicant's residence with biometric authentication, Aadhaar verification, webcam, and internet-enabled digital systems.
- The entire registration process is completed securely at home, with digitally signed documents delivered instantly via SMS in PDF format.
- A paperless property registration system featuring automatic fee calculation, e-Challan, e-Stamp, Aadhaar-based e-signatures, and GIS-enabled property verification has made property transactions faster, transparent, and more secure.



BIHAR ACCELERATES DIGITAL TRANSFORMATION WITH LANDMARK AI PARTNERSHIPS



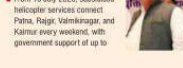
making services faster, more transparent, efficient, and accessible. It will also promote AI research in Indian languages and regional dialects to address local needs.

A strong focus has been placed on AI skill development, with training programmes for government employees and youth to build future-ready talent. The collaborations will further support AI startups through mentoring and institutional partnerships, positioning Bihar as a leader in innovation, digital inclusion, and technology-driven governance while setting a benchmark for other states.

Bihar has taken a major step towards becoming an AI-powered state by signing landmark MoUs with indigenous AI firms Sarvam AI and Bhavasth. Signed in the presence of Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary, the partnerships aim to build a citizen-centric AI ecosystem that enhances governance, strengthens digital infrastructure, and improves public service delivery. The initiative will enable government departments to use India-developed AI models.

URBAN DEVELOPMENT

- 11 new satellite townships planned across Patna, Sonpur, Gaya, Darbhanga, Saharsa, Patna, Muzaffarpur, Chapra, Bhagalpur & Siwan, featuring modern roads, parks, affordable housing, commercial & institutional zones, and EVS infrastructure to drive planned urbanization.
- Patna Metro construction has been accelerated, with the initial metro network already expanded, integrating housing, transport, and public utilities while reducing traffic congestion and improving urban mobility.
- Plans to extend Metro connectivity to Gaya, Muzaffarpur, Darbhanga, and Bhagalpur, supporting the next phase of Bihar's rapidly growing urban centers.



POWERING BIHAR WITH CLEAN & RENEWABLE ENERGY

- PM Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana is being rapidly implemented to make rooftop solar power affordable and accessible, reducing electricity bills and promoting clean energy across Bihar.
- Launched on 14 June 2025, the programme is being executed through the Utility-Led Aggregation (ULA) Model across NBPDCL and SBPDCL service areas for hassle-free rooftop solar installation.
- 450 rooftop solar systems installed so far, including 317 under NBPDCL and 175 under SBPDCL, enabling households to generate clean electricity at home.
- The mission is expanding renewable energy infrastructure, reducing carbon emissions, and promoting energy self-reliance through technology-driven, citizen-centric implementation.
- Bihar's Rooftop Solar Mission is laying the foundation for a greener, sustainable, and energy-secure future, positioning renewable energy as a key driver of long-term development.



BIHAR REVIVES SUGAR SECTOR, BOOSTING FARMERS' INCOME AND EMPLOYMENT



- Planting sugarcane during the monsoon to revive the Sarsamta Sugar Mill (Gopalganj), benefiting thousands of farmers and creating new livelihood opportunities.
- 268 acres of the closed Muzaffarpur Sugar Mills (Muzaffarpur) reclaimed for a modern sugar mill, sugarcane research centre, and other industrial projects.
- State-wide programmes for seed development, mechanisation, and sugarcane nurseries to provide disease-free high-yielding seeds, modern farm equipment, free sugarcane seeds, technical support, and improved cultivation practices.
- MoUs signed with the Sugarcane Breeding Institute, Varanasi and Sugarcane Research Institute, Patna to promote advanced sugarcane varieties, modern technologies, and AI-based crop management, strengthening Bihar's long-term sugar economy.





The Bihar Government has established four degree colleges in my region—Laxmi, Aizawl, Agartala, and Jamsh.

degree colleges across 711 blocks is transformative, especially for women and underprivileged students. Smart online classes are a modern initiative benefiting future generations."

-ARIYAN



Under the Samrat Choudhary-led Bihar Government, law and order has improved significantly. The healthcare system is witnessing steady progress, reducing the need for patients to travel outside their districts for referrals. The government is also modernising education by developing an advanced and future-ready learning model.

-PUNIL KUMAR



Under the Samrat Choudhary Government, investment-friendly policies are being introduced. Free medicines are strengthening healthcare, and pending projects are being completed, roads are being widened, and development is visible across sectors. The AI Summit at Uga Auditorium showcased Bihar's growing focus on technology and innovation.

-SARITA SINGH



Samrat Choudhary is a dynamic Chief Minister. Under his leadership, healthcare services have expanded, law and order has improved, and industrial reforms, such as the Single Window System have replaced cumbersome licensing, accelerating investments and giving fresh momentum to Bihar's economic development.

-NEELAM SHAHI





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● WHAT THE OTHERS SAY

It cannot be left to younger generations to pick up the pieces of a broken social model which should have been renewed and redesigned. — *The Guardian*

I was asked to sing with an AI band. Here's why I said no



SONU MOHAPATRA

LAST EVENING, I found myself facing a decision I had not anticipated. I had been approached to sing an Odia bhajan — 'Asha Nila Shaili' — for a band called Trilok. I have always believed that artists who have acquired visibility, like me, should occasionally lend that visibility to younger musicians. An Odia bhajan, new talent, a cultural collaboration in the month of the Rath Yatra, it seemed like something I would naturally want to support.

Then I did a little research. I discovered that Trilok was not a band in the sense in which most of us understand the word. Its members were virtual identities. It now has some men with painted faces to play live stages. The project had been developed as an AI-led "spiritual rock band" by a talent-management and media company, not by four musicians who had met, rehearsed, disagreed, failed and finally decided to come together.

I would have appreciated being told this at the very beginning. The fact that this was an AI-generated band with fictional identities was not a minor production detail. It was central to the nature of the invitation and materially changed my decision about whether I wished to associate my voice with it. I gave my answer the same night. It did not come easily, because I am opposed to technology. In fact, I had to examine my own recent choices before arriving at it.

Every generation of musicians has feared some new machine. When synthesizers entered studios, many instrumentalists believed their livelihoods would disappear. The anxiety was understandable: Why hire an orchestra if a keyboard could imitate one? Why call a drummer when a machine could keep perfect time?

But the synthesiser did not bring music to an end. It became another instrument. Drum machines did not eliminate rhythm; they altered its vocabulary. Sampling, digital recording, Auto-Tune and home-produc-

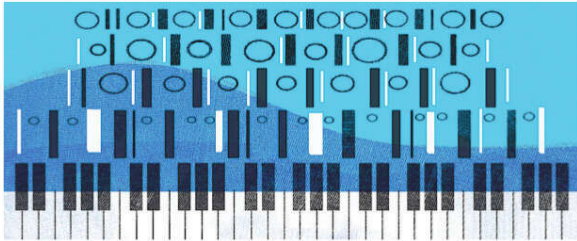


ILLUSTRATION: C. S. KASUKAR

tion software all provoked similar alarm. Each was eventually absorbed into music. So it would be simplistic to declare that any use of AI is automatically an attack on art. I recently released 'Ghane Bhadra', an original song whose video combines a live green-screen shoot of me performing with AI-assisted imagery. I am bodily present in the video. I sang the song. Human musicians played on it. AI helped us enlarge the visual canvas. It did not invent the artist, replace the performance or conceal the people who made the music. That distinction matters to me.

Independent musicians in India work within an increasingly punishing economy. We write and produce original songs, pay for recordings, musicians, mixing, mastering, styling, shoots, editing, publicity and distribution without the machinery of a major film studio or record label. We then place that work on social-media platforms that depend on our content to hold audiences but do not pay most of us meaningfully for it. A new technology that allows us to tell a more ambitious visual story without waiting for a label's permission or budget can feel liberating.

This is why I had to ask myself an uncomfortable question: Was I being inconsistent? How could I use AI in my own video and then refuse to sing for an AI band?

The answer became clearer when I stopped treating all uses of AI as though they were the same.

There is a meaningful difference between an artist using a ma-

chine and a corporation using one to manufacture the appearance of artists. One begins with human authorship and uses technology to extend its reach. The other can create an entire synthetic identity around which a catalogue and business may be built. One helps a financially constrained artist complete a labour of love. The other can produce material at a velocity no human musician can possibly match. One acknowledges the people at the centre. The other risks making them invisible.

When I examined the Trilok project, what troubled me was not simply that the members were digital avatars. It was the larger proposition. Devotional music is among the most enduring and commercially powerful musical traditions in India. The songs come with faith, familiarity and an audience already attached to them. A synthetic act built around beloved bhajans can rapidly create a catalogue without undergoing the slow, uncertain process through which musicians develop a voice.

Except for the guest collaborator, a known name used presumably to expand reach and gain credibility, all Trilok uploads just credit "Trilok" as the performer. That makes the question of authorship even more important. The point is not that no human work exists behind an AI output. Of course it does. But if human beings perform the labour while fictional identities receive the fame, where will value eventually accumulate?

And what happens when a re-

There is a meaningful difference between an artist using a machine and a corporation using one to manufacture the appearance of artists. One acknowledges the people at the centre. The other risks making them invisible



MANOJ KUMAR JHA

YOUTH MOVEMENTS across the world are concerned with matters well beyond their immediate aims. The immediate concern of the young people protesting in Delhi is fair examinations. They have shown ample understanding that irregularities deepen inequalities of class and identities. The protest expresses a sense of betrayal among students, aspirants, and parents. The moral language of protesting youth has helped add urgency to long grievances about the quality and experience of democracy itself.

Movements do not appear in a political vacuum but are a product of the political environment in which collective action develops. Whether some people like it or not, opposition parties are an important part of this process. Where a regime restricts protest or raises the costs of dissent, opposition parties can play an important role in expanding the space available to a movement.

Rahul Gandhi, Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, Mallikarjun Kharge, Akhilesh Yadav and other parliamentarians pressed for both a parliamentary debate and ministerial accountability. They carried the students' demands from Jantar Mantar to the vicinity of the PM's residence, and were detained. Opposition MPs, MPs and ex-PMs met with protesters and condemned the police action. Opposition representatives also provided food and other practical sup-

A march towards the PM's residence expresses the shared conviction that responsibility for institutional breakdown ultimately resides with the highest executive office

Opposition amplifies, not captures, citizens' voice

port, and offered legal assistance.

These actions are significant because repression isolates protesters by raising the personal costs of participation. The physical presence of recognised political leaders makes violence more visible, gives detained participants access to institutional assistance and ensures that demands enter legislative debate. The youth have not rejected party politics; they want parties to perform their representative function. The intervention of opposition MPs and regional leaders also enlarges the meaning of the mobilisation.

Against this, the BJP's response has combined coercion with politically hollow and morally reprehensible rhetoric. The use of barricades, prohibitory orders, detention, tear gas, pellet guns and baton charges treated a crisis of public confidence as a problem of crowd control. The subsequent attempt by Dharmendra Pradhan to portray Rahul Gandhi as "exploiting" students or staging a political spectacle evaded the elementary democratic point that opposition parties are expected to politicise failures of government and demand accountability. By attacking the legitimacy of Opposition involvement, the ruling party seeks to leave citizens facing the state as isolated individuals. The Opposition's task is to protect the movement's autonomy while giving its demands institutional en-

forced human singer is brought in?

My voice could give such a project something an avatar cannot manufacture: History, credibility, cultural location and emotional trust. My participation could tell listeners that this synthetic band had been accepted by a working artist. Even unintentionally, I might help normalise a model that could ultimately reduce the space available to the world I come from. That was the ethical and moral line. Would I cross it?

There is another unresolved question. Generative music systems learn from large bodies of existing material. Around the world, creators are asking whether copyrighted work has been used for training with consent, transparency or compensation. The legal position is still contested. Technology has always learned from human knowledge. Artists, too, learn from other artists. But artists do not ingest a million recordings at machine scale and then produce a competing catalogue within days. Scale changes the ethical character of the act.

I do not believe the answer is panic, prohibition or romantic speeches about returning to some pre-technological past. But artists need to ask harder questions before lending their names and voices to synthetic acts. Who owns the resulting work? Who is credited? Was the training material licensed? Can a voice be cloned? Is the human guest artist helping build their own replacement? Is technology reducing the cost of expression or reducing the need to compensate creators? Is the audience being told clearly what it is hearing? And the final question: Where is the human being in this, and are we being invited to see them?

After thinking through, I knew I could not participate.

My use of AI in 'Ghane Bhadra' may still be questioned. That is fair. Artists should not demand exemption from scrutiny simply because our intentions are good. I am also learning where my boundaries lie. But this experience clarified one of them. I will use technology to help human expressions travel further. I cannot knowingly lend my voice to make the human artist disappear.

That is not fear of the future. It is a choice about the kind of future I am willing to help create.

The writer is a singer, producer and live performer

Young have spoken. They must now engage with government



RAM RAJYA
BY RAM MADHAV

IN NON-DEMOCRATIC systems, people resort to clandestine protests in the form of sabotage or violence to express their dissent. But dissent in a democracy must be disciplined. Because, unlike other systems, democracy recognises dissent as a constitutional right. Article 19(1)(a) of the Indian Constitution guarantees freedom of speech and expression, which also includes the right to peacefully disagree and critique the government. It is this fundamental right that the agitating students in Delhi are entitled to enjoy. However, they must also keep in mind that this right comes with reasonable restrictions in the interest of the sovereignty and integrity of India, public order, decency and morality, etc. They are expected to uphold the discipline of democratic dissent.

The core issue raised by the agitating students concerns the conduct of examinations by the National Testing Agency (NTA). The NETA-UG paper leak led to the cancellation of the exam a couple of months ago, causing enormous agony to a large number of students, was a genuine issue. There were widespread protests over the leak, and the government promptly acted and handed over the case to the CBI. Thirteen accused have been arrested and legal proceedings are ongoing against them. Subsequently, the exam was reconducted without any glitch, and over 20 lakh candidates participated. The results were declared on schedule, with over 11 lakh students qualifying. Ideally, the matter should have ended with that. But it didn't. It is understandable if the agitators demanded reform and overhaul in the conduct of the competitive examinations. But their demand is limited to the removal of the education minister. Accountability is an important argument, but it should be about reforming the system and punishing those involved in malpractices. Both have been effectively addressed by the government.

Over the course of a month of the agitation, the assembly at the designated protest site near Jantar Mantar has acquired critical mass and momentum with the joining of several other sections of people. When a movement acquires that momentum, vested interests, professional



"andolan jeevi" and political parties also jump in. We are witnessing that now. Several objectionable slogans began to be raised at the venue. Violence and attacks on security personnel, too, were reported.

The plunge taken by the opposition parties, led by Congress, cannot per se be objected to, but their refusal to use the constitutional platform of Parliament to discuss the matter points to an anarchist streak. This was evident when a group of MPs led by Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi indulged in a sudden sit-in protest outside the Prime Minister's residence, knowing well that it was against the rules and public order. On the one hand, Rahul Gandhi demanded accountability for paper leaks from the government, but on the other, he himself publicly refused to be accountable to the law, claiming it to be his "prerogative". The government expressed its willingness to debate the issue in Parliament. But the Opposition is running away from it because it knows the consequences of such a debate. Paper leaks are not happening for the first time in the country. Not a single year passed during the UPA regime without accusations of that nature confronting the government. Yet, not a single minister ever resigned, nor was anyone held accountable and punished. This exposes the Opposition's duplicity and their reticence to debate the matter in Parliament.

The government is sympathetic to the agitating students' legitimate concerns. The Modi government enacted the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act 2024, the first ever law to tackle paper leaks and other unfair means, prescribing strict punishments including fines up to ₹5 crore. Respecting the sentiments of the students, the Prime Minister has announced fast-track courts and stringent punishments to tackle these cases.

The government is also sincere in engaging with the leaders of the agitation to address their concerns. Two central ministers were deployed to speak with them. The ball clearly is in the court of those young leaders. It is good that Sonam Wangchuk, the social activist supporting the agitation, decided to end his fast. He understood that with the entry of various interests into the movement, there is the danger of it losing its way. Wangchuk and the agitating students succeeded in making their views heard across the country. It is time now to work towards a resolution through active engagement with the government. The movement for a genuine cause should not be allowed to turn into the "grammar of anarchy", to quote B.R. Ambedkar, when a sincere government and secure constitutional methods are available.

The writer, president, India Foundation, is with the BJP

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Read the room

WHILE THE media across the nation was showing visuals of police brutality against thousands of largely peaceful protesters, the unemphatic remarks of the country's chief justice in response to a plea for an urgent hearing were ill-timed, in bad taste, and contrary to people's expectation of the top court as their ultimate protector against state excesses ("Due process is not a waste of anyone's time," *IE*, July 24). They only give the impression that C.J. Surya Kant is still guided by his earlier remarks about "cockroaches and parasites". There are multiple instances in which he agreed to urgent listings of less significant matters, such as his assurance of an urgent intervention regarding the closure of the Supreme Court metro station. Such selective treatment only shakes people's faith in the judiciary.

Kamal Laddha, Bengaluru

Before the water rises

EVERY MONSOON, Assam braces for overflowing rivers, mass displacement, damaged crops and loss of life. Despite decades of embankment construction, river management projects and disaster preparedness, the cycle continues ("Flood shifts course, State response is static," *IE*, July 24). Turning floods from recurring disasters into manageable natural events remains the state's biggest challenge.

S.S. Paul, Nadia

ASSAM'S FLOODS are no longer unpredictable acts of nature but failures of foresight. ("Floods shift course, State response is static," *IE*, July 24) The Brahmaputra's shifting course and rising riverbed are well known, yet authorities still rely on outdated embankments and reactive relief instead of scientific planning and interstate coordination. The tragedy demands a unified river management system that treats rivers as shared ecosystems. Early warnings, sediment control and joint action across states must replace complacency.

Veda Chidnand, Bengaluru



RAJAN KUMAR

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump is trapped in a strategic deadlock with Iran with no clear options. His strategy is unlikely to deliver a decisive military victory or a negotiated peace. And political and strategic constraints will not allow the US to withdraw either. Therefore, the US is likely to remain engaged in a prolonged proxy confrontation.

Negotiations remain the most viable option, but Trump's negotiating strategy suffers from inconsistency, inexperience and ineptitude. That bombing and negotiations can run in parallel is an inherently flawed and futile logic. In his negotiating team, there are three states and two individuals: Oman,

Qatar and Pakistan; and Jared Kushner and Steve Witkoff. They were chosen for their loyalty to Trump rather than for real experience in strategic affairs.

A negotiation requires trust-building and neutrality. However, in the ongoing negotiations, negotiators are running with the hare and hunting with the hounds. Oman and Qatar are US allies, while Pakistan carries little political weight. They are not neutral, and their legitimacy is highly suspect. On the other side, Witkoff and Kushner are unable to restrain Trump from making provocative statements. Thus, the ongoing negotiations have achieved nothing substantial, besides an episodic ceasefire.

If Trump's negotiating strategies are flawed, his war strategy is no better. A victory requires full political and military commitment, entailing high economic cost. Trump

lacks the political or economic capital to risk a full escalation. His ratings are declining, his loyalists are jumping ship, and his party fears losses in the November midterm elections, in which 435 seats in the House of Representatives, 35 seats in the Senate, and 36 state governor seats are at stake. The Democrats have a modest edge in the election for the House of Representatives.

Further, the US's ability to project

Trump wanted regime change in Iran, but he cannot even keep the Strait of Hormuz open. He wanted a decimation of the Iranian military, but is incapable of protecting US allies

power beyond the region faces serious constraints. The cases of Afghanistan, Iraq and Syria clearly illustrate this limitation. But Trump seems to have little regard for strategic constraints.

Essentially, Trump has drawn the US again into a Middle Eastern quagmire. He began with the goal of regime change, but is unable to keep the Strait of Hormuz open. He desired a decimation of the Iranian military, but he is unable to protect the US's allies in the region. He sought to restore American hegemony in the region, instead, he has driven the Gulf states to deepen their ties with China.

At the global level, the Iran war has damaged the reputation of the US as a rational and capable superpower. Allies no longer view Washington as a reliable partner in winning a war, striking a deal or securing peace.

NATO refused to endorse Trump on Iran, the Gulf countries are cautious, and the Global South views the US as imperialist, hegemonic and erratic. The US is a pariah in 36 countries found that China is viewed more favourably than the US in 25 countries. The trend is likely to accelerate.

Trump's Iran strategy has reached a cul-de-sac where every option — war, withdrawal or deal — entails high strategic costs. In the short term, a further escalation involving other regional states is the most likely outcome. The leading countries of the Global South must step forward to broker a ceasefire and advance a de-escalation process. Strategic silence today may result in high strategic costs tomorrow.

The writer is professor, School of International Studies, Jawaharlal Nehru University, Delhi

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LEGAL

Puri temple the only 'Jagannath Dham': Odisha's trademark move

Sujit Bisoyi
Bhubaneswar, July 24

FIVE TRADEMARK applications submitted by the Shree Jagannath Temple Administration (SJTA), the statutory body that administers the 12th century temple in Puri, have cleared the second round of examination by the Trade Marks Registry and been approved for publication in the upcoming Trademark Journal.

SJTA chief administrator Arvind Padhee said Thursday that the Registry had approved names such as "Jagannath Dham", "Shree Kshetra", "Mahaprasad", "Nila-chakra" and "Koili Vaikuntha" — associated with Jagannath culture and the shrine. SJTA has filed a total of 29 such applications so far.

Political confrontation

SJTA's decision to secure trademark registration of words and logos associated with the temple came last year after it locked horns with West Bengal's then Trinamool Congress government, which built a Jagannath temple in Digha and named it Sri Sri Jagannath Dham Cultural Centre in April 2025, triggering a confrontation.

Odisha Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi, in a letter last May to then Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee, said that using "dham" for the Digha temple "dilutes the distinct heritage of Puri", and added that it hurt the sentiments and emotions of millions of pilgrims and devotees. He said that the Puri shrine holds unparalleled religious, spiritual and cultural significance not just for the people of Odisha but for devotees worldwide, and that the name "Jagannath Dham" holds a unique identity linked to Puri.

Puri's erstwhile royal and chairperson of Shree Jagannath Temple Managing Committee, Dityasingha Deb, said that

using the word "dham" for the Digha shrine amounted to violation of the "scriptural injunctions and long-established tradition" of Lord Jagannath. The controversy ended last month after Suvendu Adhikari, the new Chief Minister of Bengal's BJP-led government, said that using "dham" for the Digha temple was not in accordance with "Sanatan culture" and removed it from the name.

Trademark registration
Trademark registration is the legal process of protecting a unique brand — like a name, logo, symbol or slogan — associated with any organisation. Established in 1940, India's Trade Marks Registry administers the provisions of the Trade Marks Act, 1999, and the Trade Marks Rules, 2017. The Registry is a resource and information centre and facilitates matters relating to trademarks in India.

The Act aims to provide for the registration of trademarks relating to goods and services, ensure better protection and prevent their fraudulent use.

Publication of these words in trademarks journals amounts to preliminary approval, as final certificates are issued if no objections are received within three months.

SACRED NAMES
● Jagannath Dham and 'Shree Kshetra' are sacred words associated with Puri. 'Mahaprasad' refers to the food offered to the deities and 'Nila-chakra' is the eight-spoked metal wheel atop the temple.
● 'Koili Vaikuntha' refers to the sacred garden inside the shrine where the deities are made from the sacred wooden logs and old deities are buried after consecration of new idols.

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ECONOMY

Alongside Centre, states' education expenditure too declined over past 12 years

GRAPH, DATA, PERSPECTIVES
BY UDIT MISRA
WEEKLY ECONOMIC AND POLICY INSIGHTS USING DATA

THE ONGOING work by NGOs at Jantar Mantar in Delhi and in several other cities, demanding the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan and seeking education reforms, have brought attention to the state of education in India.

The Indian Express had recently explained how the Education Ministry's share of the Union Budget had sharply declined over the past 12 years — from 4.6% in 2013-14 (the last year that the Congress-led UPA government was in power) to 2.5% in 2025-26. The fall suggests that the BJP-led NDA government reduced emphasis on education.

As a subject of policymaking, however,

education is not the sole preserve of the Union government.

Common subject

Education falls under the Concurrent list in the Seventh Schedule of the Indian Constitution.

The schedule essentially divides powers and responsibilities between the Union and state governments through three lists — Union, State and Concurrent. Both the Centre and state governments can legislate on subjects under the Concurrent list.

So, how do states act on the subject of education and what policy significance do they attach to it? A broad marker of priority is to examine the share of a state's total expenditure on education. The table and chart alongside provide a glimpse of where things stand.

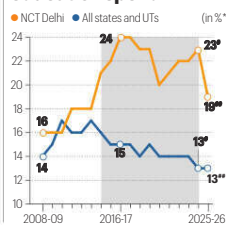
Apart from providing an average for all states and Union Territories, the table also looks at a selection of states to provide a geographically and politically diverse sample for the country.

State of education expenditure

State/Union Territory	Expenditure on education (2025-26)*	State-wise gross enrolment ratio (2024-25)**
Bihar	20	45
Gujarat	13	61
Kerala	12	94
Tamil Nadu	12	89
West Bengal	14	75
NCT Delhi	19	92
All states and UTs	13	69

*AS PERCENTAGE OF AGGREGATE EXPENDITURE **FOR SECONDARY EDUCATION *2024-25 (RE) **2025-26 (BE) SOURCE: RIES NOTE: INCLUDES EXPENDITURE ON SPORTS, ART AND CULTURE UNDER REVENUE EXPENDITURE AND CAPITAL OUTLAY

AAP effect on education spend



For some context about the status of education, while many variables could be chosen, the table shows data on gross enrolment ratio (GER) at the secondary edu-

cation level (Classes 9 to 12). The GER is the total number of students enrolled in a specific level of education — regardless of their age — divided by the total population of the official age group for that level, multiplied by 100. A look at the GER in the second column confirms the long-held notions of which states are better educated and which are lagging.

For instance, Bihar's GER is 45% while that of Kerala is 94. A low GER also reveals the distance any state has to cover to achieve a better level of education. This is especially relevant given the population difference in states such as Bihar and Kerala. In essence, it gives a sense of the need for the state government to spend on education.

The first column in the table shows states' expenditure on education as a percentage of total expenditure. Bihar and Delhi stand out.

To be sure, both states were spending even higher than this in the years preceding 2025-26. In the same period, states such as Kerala and Tamil Nadu have shared

below the national average. Longer-term data — going back to 2008-09 — shows that Tamil Nadu has largely tracked and then fallen just behind the national level. Kerala used to allocate a higher share than the national average until the Covid-19 year of 2020, and has lagged since then. Gujarat, too, has lagged behind the national average more often than not.

What is concerning is that the national average of all states and UTs itself has been trending down, as the chart alongside shows. After staying at around 17% in 2013-14, the average share of expenditure on education has gradually fallen. This fall is crucial, since it mirrors the fall in the share of money spent by the Union government as well.

There are exceptions to this trend, though. Take the Union Territory of Delhi under the Aam Aadmi Party government, which initially made health and education the key pillars of its pitch to voters. Between 2014-15 and 2024-25, education's share went up sharply, in contrast to the falling trend of the national average.

GLOBAL

New US tariffs leave India better off than competitors



RAVI DUTTA MISHRA

THE Donald Trump administration has begun its efforts to reconstruct its international Emergency Economic Powers Act (IEEPA) tariffs that were declared illegal by the US Supreme Court in February.

Starting Friday, the administration began imposing new tariffs under Section 301 of the US Trade Act of 1974 on the grounds that the 60 countries it targets — all major exporters to the US — have failed to take measures to stop imports of goods manufactured through forced labour.

According to the US Trade Representative (USTR), countries that import goods made by forced labour get an artificial cost advantage while exporting goods, forcing American workers to compete on an uneven field. The main target, however, is clear: China. These tariffs are largely meant to force countries to cut their dependence on China, which the US is in a trade war with. The US State department says the country uses forced prison labour to make goods and injects these into international supply chains.

The new US architecture is yet to fully take shape. Only the first set of tariffs has been imposed, and multiple other Section 301 tariff investigations are still ongoing. India, as of now, faces 10% tariffs, down from the 12.5% when the USTR first proposed the tariffs in March. The Trump administration is expected to announce the results of another Section 301 investigation, this one focusing on excess manufacturing capacity. The lower rates for Indian goods come with New Delhi engaging in negotiations with the US for over a year, stepping up energy imports from Washington and lowering duty for some US goods.

On June 14, India also amended its foreign trade policy to explicitly ban the import of goods produced using forced labour. The USTR considered this an improvement, placing India in the lower-tariff category alongside 16 other economies.

India's grouping
The USTR's stated reason for imposing the new Section 301 tariffs is the import of

The four-tier US tariff structure

Brackets countries based on measures they have taken to prevent imports of products made through forced labour

	Section 301 tariffs	Number of countries
Most favourable group	10% net of MFN tariff rate	EU, Taiwan
Second-most favourable group	Flat 10% (on top of MFN tariff rate)	17 (including India, Pakistan, Sri Lanka, Canada, Mexico)
Third-most favourable group	12.5% net of MFN tariff rate	3 (Japan, South Korea, Switzerland)
Least favourable	Flat 12.5% (on top of MFN tariff rate)	38 (including China, Vietnam, Russia, Brazil)

SOURCE: GLOBAL TRADE ALERT, USTR; NOTE: MFN REFERS TO MOST-FAVOURABLE NATION

- USTR took action against 60 countries in a forced-labour Section 301 investigation
- Exemption given to Scotch whisky, medical devices, semiconductors

goods made by forced labour.

But the four-tier tariff structure — ostensibly bracketing countries based on measures they have taken to prevent imports of forced-labour goods — suggests that they were imposed along geopolitical lines. All 60 countries under investigation were found guilty — the most favoured countries or groupings remain the European Union (EU) and Taiwan, and the most unfavourable Vietnam and China.

The USTR explained that for a product of the EU or Taiwan, where the product's most-favoured nation (MFN) tariff is less than 10%, the US shall impose a Section 301 tariff in a way that the sum of the MFN tariff and the Section 301 tariff shall be 10%. In cases where a product's MFN tariff is greater than or equal to 10%, the Section 301 tariff would not be imposed.

In trade parlance, MFN rates are duties that countries use across the board for all countries. As per World Trade Organisation (WTO) norms, MFN rates are the standard, non-discriminatory tariff or tax levels that a WTO member country promises to apply to imports from other WTO members.

The second-most favourable rate has been offered to India and 16 other countries, where a flat addition of 10% has been imposed. This would mean that the Section 301 rate of 10% would be added to the current MFN rate. Countries in this bracket in-

Rebuilding the tariff regime

The new US tariff architecture — meant to reconstruct the IEEPA tariffs struck down by the Supreme Court — is yet to fully take shape.

Only the first set of tariffs has been imposed, and multiple Section 301 investigations are still ongoing.



US President Donald Trump at the White House on Thursday. AP

clude Argentina, Bangladesh, Cambodia, Canada, Ecuador, El Salvador, Guatemala, Honduras, India, Indonesia, Jordan, Malaysia, Mexico, Pakistan, Sri Lanka, the UK, and Trinidad and Tobago. Notably, when the investigation began in March, Pakistan had lower tariffs than India.

Higher rates on competitors

The third-most favourable grouping includes Japan, Korea and Switzerland. These countries had, in earlier tariff structures, received better rates than India. The USTR said these three countries will now face a 12.5% rate. However, just like countries in the first category, the overall tariffs will be capped at 12.5% itself if the MFN tariff is less than that level.

"...where such product's MFN tariff is greater than or equal to 12.5%, the Trade Representative shall impose a Section 301 tariff of zero," the USTR said in its finding. The least favourable group had 38 countries, including top Indian competitors such as Vietnam and China. The USTR said these countries, like the second category, face a flat 12.5% rate, which means 12.5% over and above the MFN rates. These two countries have not only been hit with higher tariffs under the "forced labour" category but are also facing more Section 301 tariffs than India. Exporters said that with Vietnam and China facing steeper rates than India, source-

ing requirements could shift to India.

'No credible alternative'

In the wake of the tariff measures imposed by the US since early 2025, a significant decline in India's merchandise exports was widely anticipated. But trade data from the Ministry of Commerce reveals that India's exports to the US actually grew 0.9% (or \$801.7 million) from \$86.5 billion to \$87.3 billion, an Indian Council for Research on International Economic Research (ICRIER) report released in July said.

This, however, was driven by exports of products in the exclusion list, which primarily included pharmaceutical and electronic goods. "In 2025-26, exports of products covered under the exclusion list rose sharply by 24.5%, climbing from \$29.4 billion to \$36.6 billion. Exports of non-excluded products, by contrast, fell by 11.2% over the same period, declining from \$57.1 billion to \$50.7 billion — a contraction that reflects the true effect of the tariff measures imposed by the United States," the ICRIER report said.

Even as India aggressively scouts for newer markets through free trade agreements, the report pointed out that the capacity of alternative markets to absorb India's US export losses is "highly uneven... for some product categories, partial for others, and altogether absent for several".

Global trends

Aviation and competition regulators worldwide have largely preferred keeping airports and airlines operationally independent. Even in the few cases of common ownership, like in the major hub airports in West Asia, the government ultimately owns both airlines and the airports. Dubai airport and Emirates are government-owned but are separate corporate entities. So are Etihad and the Abu Dhabi airport, and Qatar Airways and Doha airport.

Similarly, Singapore's Changi Airport and Singapore Airlines are linked through the Singapore government investment ecosystem, but have distinct management structures and regulatory oversight.

Moreover, all these examples involve large hub airports in territories that have virtually non-existent domestic air traffic, and primarily operate as pure-play international airports serving as hubs for airlines owned by the respective governments. Domestic airline competition is also absent.

But in India, all airlines — except regional carrier Alliance Air — are in the private sector, and a growing number of major airports are being operated by private firms. That makes India's aviation market more like Europe than West Asian states or Singapore.

Shubhra Gupta

A FILM made four years back, releasing only now, suddenly feels current. Mention of protests and placards woven into the plot around an unraveling couple makes you feel that it's reflecting the times we are passing through. But then, who is to say that thorny relationships and problem-ridden times aren't the story of us, decade upon decade?

Max (Siddharth Menon) and Min (Medha Shankar), a pair whose relationship is heading south, find themselves connecting over their cat. Or is it just the handsome creature that draws Min back to Max, especially when things aren't quite as smooth with the new man in her life? The feelings are relatable: if you've been together for a while, parting is never easy, and could perhaps encompass residual warmth alongside resentment and sadness.

The Max-Min conflict initially feels a little too talky, not enough feely. But the film rescues itself by building upon the connections and gives the characters a few ticks

The elements surrounding them feel refreshingly life-like as well. Bad dates we are desperate to get out of. Parents with whom we are in constant, guilt-ridden conflict. How we deal with those things defines who we are, and by the end of this film, we do get to know the contours of his characters, and that's the best part of the film, which begins a little clunkily, and then settles down into its groove, as we go along.

The most interesting character here is Mahesh aka Max's near-estranged father, Ramesh (Adil Hussain), a well-to-do businessman. The latter's brusqueness comes from a broken childhood that is acknowl-

The Shape of Us



edged when he begins loosening up under the patient ministrations of his therapist, Dhaara (Mandira Bedi, appearing in a series of distractingly gorgeous linen saris). Mahesh's own father (Nassar), now living in an old age home, was always a distant figure, busy with his career as a successful Carnatic classical singer; reconciliation and healing become a key aspect of the thing between the trio, representing three generations.

A cat called Meowzaki just because the two interfaith (Hindu-Muslim) lovers love

MAX MIN & MEOWZAKI

★★★

DIRECTOR:

Padmakumar
Narsimhamurthy
CAST: Siddharth Menon, Medha Shankar, Adil Hussain, Vidhatri Bandi, Mandira Bedi, Nassar, Nafisa Ali

Miyazaki, is too cutesy for words, but is handsome enough to be forgiven his name. The Max-Min conflict initially feels a little too talky, not enough feely. But the film rescues itself by building upon the connections and gives the characters a few ticks: Max finds it hard to sleep; his sleeplessness finds an echo in a cat-sitter (Vidhatri Bandi), whose grandmother (Nafisa Ali) is in an advanced stage of Alzheimer's. And as we see them begin leaning on, and into each other, we begin to lean into the easy warmth the film is

trying to build.

There are also the unexpected touches which lift the film, especially in the way a lesbian relationship is slipped in quietly, adding to the texture. Menon is a constant presence, and does well as the coming-of-age young man. It is Hussain, as the man who takes the longest, most difficult steps towards self-awareness, who holds this film: despite a few places where the emphasis on the Tamilian vowels is evident — Dhaara becomes Daira — his Ramesh Mahadevan is pitch perfect.



When Every Lesson Is a Lecture

Shubhra Gupta

THIS SEVEN-PART series reminds me a little of *Maamla Legal Hai*, the show set in a lower Delhi court in a part of the national Capital far away from the swag and smoothness of Central Delhi. *Adarsh Baal Vidyalaya* functions in the same mould: this is a sarkari school in the fictional mohalla of Tinki Toli, whose students come from a certain section of society, with parents working low-rung jobs, whose only way out of the rut is education.

It's quite ironic that the show is out at a time when student protests are raging out in Delhi and in other parts of the country, demanding accountability and the reset of an education system which has been systematically devalued over time. And it's even more ironic that for a show which wants to do the right thing — picking up topics which are relevant and timely — it goes about it in such an overstated manner. Everything is underlined; very little is left to the imagination.

Gyanshwar Tripathi (Kay Kay Menon) is the principal of ABV, where he spends much of his time playing cricket with his students, when not dashing his head against the intractable wall of the money no resources' which stops his wards from doing well in exams. And that's a factor which prevents him from taking off to a foreign jaunt which he has set his heart upon, not just for himself, but for his loyal wife (Prachee Shah), who has stood by him all these years.

Over seven episodes, around 25-35 minutes each, such issues as corruption, honesty, respect for an older generation, as well as jobs that are considered beneath your dignity, sex education by a shrinking female teacher (Annapurna Soni), and others, are brought up for an airing, and kept aside after being neatly resolved. Not much is left hanging, because that would

make things complex, and that wouldn't do, would it?

The able Naveen Kasturia plays a counsellor raising his teenage daughter — who attends the same school — and learning on the job. Abhimanyu Singh, breaking from his usual grey roles, pitches in as the burly teacher who learns better than using force to get the students to fall in line: the fact that he has a second job to augment his meagre salary — moonlighting as a mendhi artist to make ends meet — makes for an interesting layer.

Archana Puran Singh, shilling for a local MP (Deven Bhojani), keeps coming in the way of the principal and his undeniable affection for his students. Prasanna Bisht is a newbie who adjusts to the ways of an ill-funded government-run school without losing sight of why she wanted to be a teacher in the first place: she speaks up against the labelling of kids as *malai* vs *khurchan*, telling us every child has the right to an education.

The premise is solid, and in between all the preachiness, there's an attempt to showcase the difficulties faced by overburdened and underfunded *sarkari* institutions. But that keeps disappearing in the pile of clichés: how a *sanskari* teacher is reluctant to use the word penis in a sex ed class is such an old one. I also wasn't

very sure about a North Eastern actor playing the stereotypical role of a canteen cook rustling up spicy chowmein, even though he is held up as a role model in passing. Kay Kay does his best, staying consistently watchable, but that's nothing new. That a teacher can be dyslexic is a good touch, but the clear intention of inserting low-hanging laughs at every step dilutes the impact. One line cracked me up, though. An act of eating-and-spitting paan is called peek detailing, hehe. Now why wasn't there more from where that came?

No Kick to the Blend

Shubhra Gupta

A THREE-WAY modern romance set in a small town. That's the pitchline of *Musafir Cafe*, based on a novel of the same name by Divya Prakash Dubey and created by Sharanya Rajagopal and directed by Ruchir Arun. The eight-part show takes the memo very seriously indeed. Chander and Sudha — someone here is evidently a fan of Dharamveer Bharati's classic novel of the same name — meet and ignite in Bhopal.

Having quit his software job in the US, he works in a dull government office, nursing a dream of opening his own cafe in the hills, while meeting suitable girls with a view to marriage.

She is your ambitious girl who never hides anything she's thinking, outspoken in the way Bollywood *chubutulis* are: Sudha, like that other girl in the train, is her own favourite, and doesn't care who knows it.

There's passion. There's a bit of sex — yes, really — too. Small town people aren't squeamish like that, okay? All is well until ambition rears its ugly head. So, a rift in the late. Time elapses. And then, bingo, there comes that picturesque cafe, blue skies, misty hills, and a generous-hearted girl called Preeti.

But, but, is that that? Will Chander and Preeti live happily ever after? Even though good-looking guests make puppy eyes at Preeti, knowing full well that her heart beats for another? And even though she knows, yes, she does, that Chander hasn't forgotten his first love?

Musafir Cafe is that rom com that is aiming for sweet and winsome, which should have left you with the warm fuzzies. But it doesn't quite get there. Not because the actors aren't up for it. Not because they don't try. Not because the plot doesn't have room for all of them. But because it ends up being more performative than felt.

Vikrant Massey as Chander tries his best to be believable and he really does come close to it. Mahima Makwana as the steady



MUSAFIR CAFE

★★★

DIRECTOR: Ruchir Arun

CAST: Vikrant Massey, Vedika Pinto, Mahima Makwana, Rajeev Siddhartha, Anubha Fatehpuria, Loveleen Mishra, Sadiya Siddiqui

STREAMING ON: Netflix

third wheel is commendable too, even though she gets short shrift when it comes to a backstory. It is the spritely Vedika Pinto, who acts out her part, for no fault of hers: the writers keep putting her in front of a man whose law keeps dropping at her carefree airs: *kyu hain tum*, he says in amazement, not once, but twice, and maybe thrice. And by then, our Sudha believes in it too: that she's too cool for school, and certainly for the sedate Chander.

There are also a bunch of excellent actors with very little to do but play out ropes: Anubha Fatehpuria as Chander's mother, Loveleen Mishra as Sudha's mother, and Adil Hussain and Sadiya Siddiqui as the still madly in love silver-haired couple as Chander and Preeti's mentors and well-wishers.

Why does it take eight stretched episodes to tell a tale that would have been better told in half the time? Why is the serene city of Bhopal such a fleeting presence — the famed lake glimpsed from a terrace cafe — even though it is named frequently throughout the show? Those are also questions which this could have been a *pyari-prem kahani* doesn't answer well enough.



JANA NAYAGAN ★★

DIRECTOR: H Vinoh

CAST: Joseph Vijay, Poja Hegde, Bobby Deol, Mamitha Baiju, Prakash Raj, Gautham Vasudev Menon

The story follows Vetri Kondan, a former police officer played by Vijay, who is drawn into conflict when a young girl

close to him, played by Mamitha Baiju, faces a threat that traces back to a powerful international arms dealer named Phoenix, played by Bobby Deol.

Vinoh constructs an elaborate backstory involving civil wars in Africa, terrorist attacks from Pakistan, drone warfare, robots fighting humans, and a confrontation between the villain and his own alter ego. The VFX in these sequences is poor given

STREAMING WATCHLIST



Protector

LIONSGATE PLAY

IN A new town, Nikki has built a quiet life with her teenage daughter, determined to keep her safe from everything she once was. But when Nikki wakes up in an abandoned factory with no memory of how she got there, her daughter has vanished. What follows is a race through the criminal underworld that Nikki navigates the only way she knows how: with the full force of a military career she never fully walked away from. Directed by Adrian Grünberg, the cast includes Milla Jovovich, Matthew Modine and Isabel Myers.



Watson

JOHOTSTAR

SIX MONTHS after the apparent death of Sherlock Holmes at the hands of Moriarty, Dr John Watson (Morris Chestnut) returns to medicine, taking charge of a clinic dedicated to treating rare and unusual disorders. But his past refuses to stay buried as Moriarty resurfaces, pulling Watson into a new battle of wits. Blending medical drama with investigative suspense, the series created by Craig Sweeny reimagines one of literature's most iconic characters, shifting his focus from solving crimes to unraveling complex medical mysteries.



Aga Aai

Aaho Aai

ZEE5

AGA AAI Aaho Aai is a heart-warming Marathi family drama that celebrates the unique bond between a daughter, her mother, and her mother-in-law, showing how love deepens when families come together. Directed by Varun Navarekar and written by Kalyani Pandit, the series stars Hruta Durgule, Renuka Shahane, and Nirmitti Sawant.



72 Hours

NETFLIX

THE MOVIE 72 Hours follows a 40-year-old executive (Kevin Hart) who hopes to revive his faltering career by tagging along on a chaotic three-day bachelor party after he's mistakenly added to a group chat of 20-somethings. Directed by Tim Story, the comedy also stars Mason Gooding, Marcello Hernández, Ben Marshall, Zach Cherry, Kam Patterson, and Teyana Taylor.

Masters of the Universe

PRIME VIDEO

AFTER BEING away for 15 years, Prince Adam (Nicholas Galitzine)

returns to find Eternia under the tyrannical rule of the villainous Skeletor (Jared Leto). To save his homeland, Adam must join forces with the fearless Teela (Camila Mendes) and the ingenious Man-at-Arms (Idris Elba). Directed by Travis Knight, the fantasy adventure combines large-scale action with nostalgic appeal. It is the second live-action adaptation of the franchise.

ALAKA SAHANI

this is a big production that had three years to get it right. The AI-generated visuals look unfinished; the action sequences that are supposed to establish Phoenix as a global threat end up making him look like a character from a video game.

Where the film works, and it does work in stretches, is where Vijay is allowed to be himself. Mamitha Baiju brings real weight to her scenes and delivers one of the more affecting performances in the film. Poja Hegde as Kayal does what the script allows, which is not much. Prakash Raj and Gautham Vasudev Menon add texture in their supporting roles, though neither is given enough screen time to fully register.

The deeper problem with *Jana Nayagan* is not any single bad decision. It is the weight of trying to do everything at once. This is a film that wants to be a women empowerment drama, a political thriller, a modern warfare spectacle, a family sentiment piece, a mass action entertainer, a campaign video, a farewell tribute, and a statement about Indian democracy. Vijay deserved better. His fans, who waited six months through a censor battle, a court case, a nationwide leak and an A-certification, deserved better.



while officials shared that over 1.65 lakh ASHA workers have already been certified across the country. Delivering the keynote address, Dr. Neelima Mishra, Director, National Institute of Biologicals, described ASHA workers as the frontline of India's public healthcare system.



MP Dr. Jitendra Singh, Union Minister of State for Personnel, Public Grievances & Pensions, called for a comprehensive review of pension regulations to ensure that evolving social realities are adequately reflected in government policies, stating that many pension disputes arise because existing rules have failed to keep pace with changing societal needs. During the event, Dr. Jitendra Singh launched the Compendium of Case Laws on Pension Litigation, a Flyer on Pension Litigation, & the Special Campaign 3.0 of the Department of Pension & Pensioners' Welfare aimed at strengthening litigation management, improving service delivery and promoting citizen-centric pension administration. He said such reforms demonstrate the Government's commitment to making pension policies more humane, inclusive and responsive to contemporary societal requirements.



UCO BANK reported a strong performance for the quarter ended recently, posting a net profit of Rs 656 crore, up 8.05% year-on-year. Total business rose 15.53% to Rs 6.05 lakh crore, with advances growing 21.18% & deposits 11.26%. Asset quality improved, with Gross NPA at 2.06% & Net NPA at 0.25%. The bank's capital adequacy ratio stood at 19.03%, reflecting robust financial stability. UCO Bank's network spans 3421 Domestic Branches, as well as overseas in Hong Kong, Singapore & a representative office in Iran.

PNB reported a robust Q1 FY'27 performance with net profit surging 214% year-on-year to Rs 5,253 crore. Global business rose 10.2% to Rs 29.98 lakh crore, while advances grew 12.7% and deposits 8.5%. Asset quality strengthened with GNPA improving to 2.78% and NNPA to 0.28%, alongside higher RoA, NIM and capital adequacy, reflecting strong financial resilience.

DWCD In collaboration with Sangath, successfully organised an orientation & felicitation programme under the NAMASTE Programme, reaffirming its commitment to strengthening ECD services across the National Capital Territory. The programme focused on promoting early identification & timely intervention for children with developmental delays & disabilities through a community-based screening approach. The orientation session signified Anganwadi functionaries & supervisory staff on the objectives, implementation framework, & significance of the NAMASTE Programme. The event was graced by Rashmi Singh, Hon. Secretary, Department of Women & Child Development, Government of NCT of Delhi.

CORPORATE BRIEFS



BHARAT TAXI Bharat Taxi & Department of Information Technology & Electronics, Govt. of West Bengal entered into an MoU to strengthen the Yatri Sathi Partnership to focus on operational support, driver welfare, technology interoperability, platform growth, and service expansion across West Bengal, Kolkata on 19th July. Yatri Sathi is a state-developed digital taxi aggregation platform owned by DITE, providing cab & taxi services to passengers across West Bengal. Through this partnership, STCL will act as DITE's strategic and preferred Growth & Welfare Partner for Yatri Sathi.



GDA Uttar Pradesh CM Yogi Adityanath inaugurated and laid the foundation stone for Ghaziabad Development Authority projects worth approximately Rs 596.40 crore during his Ghaziabad visit on July 17. The projects included the inauguration of four completed works worth Rs 91.29 crore and the foundation laying of 19 new infrastructure and public welfare projects worth Rs 505.11 crore, providing a significant boost to the district's development.



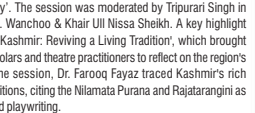
GMC Ghaziabad Municipal Commissioner Vikramaditya Singh Malik presented the city's integrated solid waste management initiatives to Uttar Pradesh CM Yogi Adityanath, highlighting waste segregation, recycling, composting, real-time waste collection monitoring and public participation. The CM also unveiled the Ghaziabad Municipal Corporation's coffee table book showcasing its cleanliness and environmental initiatives over the past two-and-a-half years and commended the Corporation's efforts to build a cleaner, greener city.

BOB AGRA Bank of Baroda's Regional Office, Agra celebrated the bank's 119th Foundation Day with a series of events, including a walkathon, tree plantation drive, free health check-up camp and a cultural-cum-felicitation programme. The evening programme, held at Rao Krishna Pal Auditorium, featured cultural performances by employees and children. Paisalo Digital Limited Executive Director and CFO Harish Singh attended as the chief guest, while Regional Head Dhananjay Kumar, Deputy Regional Manager Anuj Chitransh, RRB Agra AGM Avinash Palod and former Bank of Baroda General Manager S.P. Bhandari were among the distinguished guests. Retired officers and employees were felicitated during the event.



NBT The third Chinara Book Festival at SKICC continued to draw enthusiastic participation with engaging literary and cultural sessions. The day began at the Authors' Corner with an engaging session titled 'From Soil to

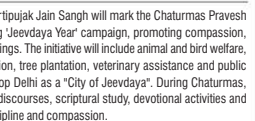
Soul: Culinary Traditions and Sustainability'. The session was moderated by Tripurari Singh in the presence of Chef Yaseen Reshi, Rajni. Wanchoo & Khair Ull Nissa Sheikh. A key highlight was the landmark discussion, 'Theatre in Kashmir: Reviving a Living Tradition', which brought together playwrights, actors, directors, scholars and theatre practitioners to reflect on the region's theatrical heritage and future. Opening the session, Dr. Farooq Fayaz traced Kashmir's rich theatrical legacy to its ancient Sanskrit traditions, citing the Nilmata Purana and Rajatarangini as evidence of its vibrant history of drama and playwrighting.



CTD Reaffirming the Government of India's commitment to Swasth Bharat, Viksit Bharat, & a TB-Mukt Bharat, the CTD, Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, organised an Ayushman Arogya Shivar at Kartavya Bhawan - I in collaboration with the Delhi State TB Cell, the NTEP & the SNA Division. Aradhana Patnaik, Additional Secretary & Mission Director, National Health Mission inaugurated the Shivar. The camp witnessed enthusiastic participation with services including blood pressure, blood sugar, haemoglobin and BMI assessments. The initiative reflects the government's continued focus on strengthening preventive healthcare and a TB-Mukt Bharat.



CPM The Delhi Gujarati Shwetambar Murtipuj Jain Sangh will mark the Chaturmas Pravesh Mahotsav with the launch of the year-long 'Jeevdaya Yatra' campaign, promoting compassion, non-violence and the welfare of all living beings. The initiative will include animal and bird welfare, cow protection, environmental conservation, tree plantation, veterinary assistance and public awareness programmes, aiming to develop Delhi as a "City of Jeevdaya". During Chaturmas, devotees will also participate in religious discourses, scriptural study, devotional activities and spiritual programmes centred on self-discipline and compassion.



ALLEN NEET ALLEN Career Institute delivered an outstanding performance in NEET-UG 2026, with five students securing places in the top 10 and 46 featuring in the top 100. Aryan Gupta secured AIR 1 and Panshal Bansal AIR 2 with 715 marks each, followed by Ayush Bhalotra (AIR 4), Aryan Dubey (AIR 7) and Gaurav Singh (AIR 9).

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

See Section 82 Cr.P.C. / 84 BNSS
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person Sanjay Dayal S/o Ganesh Dayal R/o H. No. B-317, Jawahar Mohalla, Patparganj, Delhi also at Ward No. 7, Gausahala Road Mokama, P.S. Mokama, Distt. Patna, Bihar has Committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. 213/2021 U/s 279/338 IPC, P.S. Jaitpur, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused Sanjay Dayal cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Sanjay Dayal has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant),
Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused Sanjay Dayal of case FIR No. 213/2021 U/s 279/338 IPC, P.S. Jaitpur, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 16.11.2026.
By Order
Dr. Raj Kumar Singh
Judicial Magistrate First Class -11
South East, Court Room No. 09, Main Building
Saket Court Complex, New Delhi

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Theinang Shimrah, S/o: Late Ashok Shimrah, R/o: H.No. 106, Humayunpur Village, Safdarjung Enclave, New Delhi; also at: Village View Land Zone-I, Ukhra, Manipur has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. 176/2021, U/s 33 Delhi Excise Act, P.S. Safdarjung Enclave, New Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused Theinang Shimrah cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Theinang Shimrah has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant),
Proclamation is hereby made that the said Theinang Shimrah accused of offence in case FIR No. 176/2021, U/s 33 Delhi Excise Act, P.S. Safdarjung Enclave, New Delhi and is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 02.09.2026.
By Order
Ms. Devanshi Janmeja
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03 (South)
Room No. 212, Saket Court, New Delhi

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C./84 BNSS
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Dhruv S/o Anil R/o B-3, 4/5, Bhatta Shah Road, Vishnu Garden, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case registered vide FIR No. 155/2024 U/s 279/338 IPC, PS Vijay Vihar, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused Dhruv cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said Dhruv has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant),
Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused Dhruv of FIR No. 155/2024 U/s 279/338 IPC, PS Vijay Vihar, Delhi is required to appear before this Court (or before me) to answer the complaint on or before the date of 30.01.2027 at 10:00 am.
By Order
Ms. Shagun
Judicial Magistrate First Class-06
North West District, Room No. 109, 1st Floor
Rohini Courts, Delhi

PUNJAB STATE POWER CORPORATION LTD.

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Website: www.psbpl.in
Tender Enquiry No. MOP-267/2026-27(P/O/M) Dated 23.07.2026
Chief Engineer/Metering, C-3, Shakti Vihar, PSPCL, Patiala invites e-tender for Supply, Installation, Testing, Commissioning, Reading, Analysis, integration with billing system and 1 year O&M of Power Quality Meters complying to IEC 61000-4-30 class A.
For detailed NIT and tender specification please refer to https://eproc.punjab.gov.in dated 23.07.2026, 11:00 AM onwards.
Note:- Corrigendum & addendum, if any, will be published online at https://eproc.punjab.gov.in
No.13644/PB C 74426

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O/c: Dr. CE/TS (Design), Telefax: 9175-2297774, E-mail:ce@pstcl.org
Notice Inviting E-Tender
Tender Enquiry No. STQ-7100 (SHORT TERM OPEN TENDER)
For manufacture, testing, supply & delivery of 780 nos. SCADA compatible IUK VCB Panels.
1. Last date & time for submission of tender: 07.08.2026 upto 11:00AM
2. Last date & time for submission of tender: 07.08.2026 upto 11:00AM
3. Date & time for opening tender: 08.08.2026 at 11:00 AM
Detailed NIT/specification may be downloaded from Punjab Govt. e-tendering website https://eproc.punjab.gov.in/nicgp/app. Corrigendum, if any, will not be published in newspapers. As such the website may be visited regularly for updates.
No. 13623/PSCTL Dr. CE/TS (Dr. PSCTL, Patiala).

HARYANA REAL ESTATE REGULATORY AUTHORITY

New Mini Secretariat, 2nd Floor, Sector-1, Panchkula.
E-mail: herapkl-hrv@gov.in, officer.rera.hrv@gmail.com
Website: www.haryanareg.gov.in
PUBLIC NOTICE
For kind attention of allottees of the Real Estate Project namely "Devrachna Lok" an Affordable Residential Plotted Town Planning Scheme under DDJAY-2016 being developed by M/s Tika Cotton Industries over an area measuring 6.864 acres situated in Sector-10, Residential, Fatehabad.
1. The above-mentioned project was registered with HREERA Panchkula vide Registration No: HREERA-PKL-FTB-540-2024 Dated: 16.01.2024 valid upto 30/06/2026.
2. The promoter has requested the Authority that instead of revoking the registration on its expiry, the Authority may permit it to remain in force for one more year subject to such further terms and conditions as it thinks fit to impose in the interest of the allottees and any such terms and conditions so imposed shall be binding upon the promoter.
3. The Authority is considering the application of the promoter to permit continuation of registration for one more year under section 7(3) of the Act for this project. However, the first right of refusal for carrying out of the remaining development works is that of the association of allottees. Therefore, the Authority hereby invites objections from the association of allottees in particular and any other concerned persons in general.
4. The objections shall be filed in the registry of the Authority by 07.08.2026 which will be considered by the Authority under section 7(3) of the Act.
Secretary (Acting)
HREERA Panchkula
No. 47490/HR

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C. / 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person Taj Khan S/o Md. Rafiq R/o 332, Gali No.-3, Bhagya Vihar, Delhi, Also: 125A, Vidyapati Nagar, Inder Enclave, Ph.-2", Delhi, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in FIR No. 451/2020, U/s 33/58 Delhi Excise Act, PS Prem Nagar, Rohini Distt., Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused Taj Khan cannot be found, and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Taj Khan has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant);
Proclamation is hereby made that Taj Khan the said accused of FIR No. 451/2020, U/s 33/58 Delhi Excise Act, PS Prem Nagar, Rohini Distt., Delhi, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 29.08.2026.
By Order
Ms. Shagun
Judicial Magistrate First Class,
North West, Court No. 109, 1st Floor,
Rohini Courts, Delhi

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82(2) (ii) Cr.P.C./84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita
Whereas a complaint has been made before me that accused persons namely Mihir Das @ Pukal S/o Gopal Das R/o H.No. C-367/8, Gali No. 11, 2nd Floor, Soniya Vihar, Delhi have committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence under FIR No.1526/2025 U/s 316(4) Bhartiya Nagarik Sanhita, has been registered at PS: Karol Bagh, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said, Mihir Das @ Pukal cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said, Mihir Das @ Pukal has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).
Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused, Mihir Das @ Pukal of under FIR No.1526/2025 U/s 316(4) Bhartiya Nagarik Sanhita, Registered at PS: Karol Bagh, Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before 30.09.2026.
By Order
Sh. Nishant Bangarh
JMFC-01 (Central), Room No. 180
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Monu @ Shankar Shikander, S/o Santosh Shikander, R/o WZ-65/55, Indra Camp No. 03, Vikas Puri, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. 27/2020, U/s 33/38 Delhi Excise Act, P.S. Vikas Puri, New Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said Monu @ Shankar Shikander cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said Monu @ Shankar Shikander has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).
Proclamation is hereby made that the said Monu @ Shankar Shikander accused of FIR No. 27/2020, U/s 33/38 Delhi Excise Act, P.S. Vikas Puri, New Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 07.09.2026.
By Order - Sh. Sh. Vinod Kumar
Judicial Magistrate First Class-05, South-West District
DP/10130/WD/2026 Room No. 09, Dwarka Courts, New Delhi

MAHARASHTRA METRO RAIL CORPORATION LTD.

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PUNE METRO RAIL PROJECT- PHASE 2
Metro Bhavan, 04th Floor, D. I. Metro Station, Wanyamurti
Ranade Path, Shivaji Nagar, Pune-411005. Tel.: 020-26951072/4
E-mail: ptdender.pmr@mahametro.org | www.punemetrorail.org
Tender Notice No: P1PD-60/2026 Date: 25/07/2026
Name of Work: Licensing Internal Advertisement Rights of Corridor-01 Metro Stations of the Pune Metro Rail Project for a Period of 15 Years.
Interested bidders may visit the Pune Metro Rail website www.punemetrorail.org to view this Tender Notice (NIT) and can download the tender documents and obtain further details regarding the tender from e-tender portal of Govt. of Maharashtra: https://mahatenders.gov.in from 17:00 Hrs. on 27/07/2026 to 16:00 Hrs. of 27/08/2026.
General Manager (TP & Procurement - PD)
Maha-Metro Rail Corporation Limited
Pune Metro - City's Transport Solution

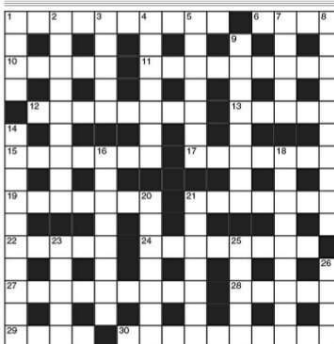
PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(SEE SECTION 82(2) (ii) Cr.P.C.)
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) Ashutosh S/o Sh. Abhay Kumar R/o M-98, Meer Vihar, Madanpur Dabas, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case CR. No. 533019/2016, U/s 394/34 IPC, PS Kanjhawala, Delhi and it has been returned to a Warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) Ashutosh can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) Ashutosh has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant),
Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) Ashutosh of case CR. No. 533019/2016, U/s 394/34 IPC, PS Kanjhawala, Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before dated 27.08.2026.
By Order
Apoorv Bhardwaj
Judicial Magistrate First Class-02
Room No. 113, First Floor
Rohini Courts, Delhi

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82/84 BNSS
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person namely Amir Khan S/o Nabijan, R/o: H. No. Idgaah Colony, Gali No. 10, Sonipat, Haryana (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in FIR No. 0278/2020, U/s 129/55 G. Act, Date : 29.09.2020, registered at P.S.: New Friends Colony, Delhi and the warrant has been returned writing upon that the said accused Amir Khan cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Amir Khan has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).
Proclamation is hereby made that the said Amir Khan accused FIR No. 0278/2020, U/s 129/55 G. Act, registered at P.S.: New Friends Colony, Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before 25.08.2026.
By Order
Vinod Joshi
Addl. Chief Judicial Magistrate
South East District, Room No. 515
Saket Courts, New Delhi

CROSSWORD



ACROSS

- 1 Island with many debts is unpendable (10)
- 6 List of food (4)
- 10 The best one to make business arrangements (5)
- 11 Lavish with everything but mercy (9)
- 12 A lioness is strangely classified as cereal (8)
- 13 Free trip to give medical attention (5)
- 15 Drug possibly oceanic in origin (7)
- 18 Rent rowdies cause a storm (7)
- 19 It comes last locked in reverse (7)
- 21 See sign is incorrect for a start (7)
- 22 Just a maxim (5)
- 24 Honoured with high rank in the finish (8)
- 27 Not having had any hot drinks? (4,5)
- 28 Outliving a vine is simple (5)
- 29 Rough deal for Helen's mother (4)
- 30 It's said to be praise for good sportsmen (4,6)

DOWN

- 2 Slight damage to essential part of computer (4)
- 2 Allegations that may be false (9)
- 3 pick up key to lock round someone's house (5)
- 4 Until that is put in order this is useless (7)
- 5 Pushy type seen to jump out of bed first (7)
- 7 A green girl (5)
- 8 Edifice with strong beams (10)
- 9 Car is not damaged being strong (4-4)
- 14 Bill gets a medical qualification of college (10)
- 16 The Utopian has his own collection of notions (8)
- 18 It stay true to the principle of self-denial (9)
- 20 Three times surrounded a number show fear (7)
- 21 Non-specialist officer (7)
- 23 Directed — in a straight line (5)
- 25 Commonplace restriction on almost everything (5)
- 26 Metal van (4,6)

OVER THE HEDGE



CALVIN & HOBBS



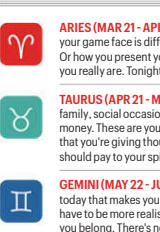
MARVIN



ROYAL STARS



ROYAL STARS



ROYAL STARS



SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6049 ACROSS: 1 Lament; 5 Dicks; 8 The creeps; 9 Oar, 10 Rife, 12 Strolled, 14 Rude, 15 Stress, 17 Research, 18 Asia, 21 Era, 22 Hold still, 24 Trowel, 25 Doublet **DOWN:** 1 Later, 2 Nee, 3 Earl, 4 Treary, 5 Distors, 6 Shoulders, 7 Strides, 11 Firm stand, 13 Breather, 14 Earnest, 16 Scattered, 19 Allot, 20 Easou, 23 Ill

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given clue.

Believe those who are seeking... Doubt those who find it

Andre Chénier (3,5)

THREE

ABRUTU

TRUST

CNOOH

ANSWERS: Andre Chénier, ABRUTU, CNOOH, THREE

DIFFICULTY LEVEL 45 INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL:
1 = Very easy; 2 = Easy;
3 = Medium; 4 = Hard;
5 = Very Hard;
6 = Genius

SUDOKU 6390

4	3	7	8
7	5	2	9
1	6	8	5
9	1	6	8
1	2	8	3
6	4	2	1

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6390

4	3	7	8
7	5	2	9
1	6	8	5
9	1	6	8
1	2	8	3
6	4	2	1

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SR. NO.	NAME OF BOYER CORP./AUTH	OLD REFERENCE/NET NO.	NATURE OF CONSEQUENCE	WEBSITE OF THE BOARD CORP./AUTH	MOBILE OFFICE/CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	THE SIRISA COOPERATIVE MILK PROCESSORS UNION LIMITED	TENDER NO. 2020, MCH, SUDOL, 1 REF NO. HUSG-TENDER/2020/272	TENDER DATE EXTENDED 04.08.2020	https://mutter.in/nc.in	98123-02368 mnutd@gmail.com
2	THE SIRISA COOPERATIVE MILK PROCESSORS UNION LIMITED	TENDER NO. 2020, MCH, SUDOL, 1 REF NO. HUSG-TENDER/2020/272	TENDER DATE EXTENDED 04.08.2020	https://mutter.in/nc.in	98123-02368 mnutd@gmail.com

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT : www.haryanaeprocurement.gov.in or www.etenders.hry.nc.in

MUTHOOT FINCORP LTD. GOLD AUCTION NOTICE

Notice is hereby given for the information of all concerned that gold ornaments pledged with under mentioned branches of the company, which were overdue for redemption and which have not been redeemed so far in spite of repeated notices sent on 12th June 2020.

Auction Date: 26.08.2020 - BHOPAL DISTRICT - ASHOKA GARH: 433400148, 433400340, 433400344, 433400352, 433400356, 433400360, 433400364, 433400368, 433400372, 433400376, 433400380, 433400384, 433400388, 433400392, 433400396, 433400400, 433400404, 433400408, 433400412, 433400416, 433400420, 433400424, 433400428, 433400432, 433400436, 433400440, 433400444, 433400448, 433400452, 433400456, 433400460, 433400464, 433400468, 433400472, 433400476, 433400480, 433400484, 433400488, 433400492, 433400496, 433400500, 433400504, 433400508, 433400512, 433400516, 433400520, 433400524, 433400528, 433400532, 433400536, 433400540, 433400544, 433400548, 433400552, 433400556, 433400560, 433400564, 433400568, 433400572, 433400576, 433400580, 433400584, 433400588, 433400592, 433400596, 433400600, 433400604, 433400608, 433400612, 433400616, 433400620, 433400624, 433400628, 433400632, 433400636, 433400640, 433400644, 433400648, 433400652, 433400656, 433400660, 433400664, 433400668, 433400672, 433400676, 433400680, 433400684, 433400688, 433400692, 433400696, 433400700, 433400704, 433400708, 433400712, 433400716, 433400720, 433400724, 433400728, 433400732, 433400736, 433400740, 433400744, 433400748, 433400752, 433400756, 433400760, 433400764, 433400768, 433400772, 433400776, 433400780, 433400784, 433400788, 433400792, 433400796, 433400800, 433400804, 433400808, 433400812, 433400816, 433400820, 433400824, 433400828, 433400832, 433400836, 433400840, 433400844, 433400848, 433400852, 433400856, 433400860, 433400864, 433400868, 433400872, 433400876, 433400880, 433400884, 433400888, 433400892, 433400896, 433400900, 433400904, 433400908, 433400912, 433400916, 433400920, 433400924, 433400928, 433400932, 433400936, 433400940, 433400944, 433400948, 433400952, 433400956, 433400960, 433400964, 433400968, 433400972, 433400976, 433400980, 433400984, 433400988, 433400992, 433400996, 433401000, 433401004, 433401008, 433401012, 433401016, 433401020, 433401024, 433401028, 433401032, 433401036, 433401040, 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Judoka Tulika banned by NADA for whereabouts failures; removed from CWG

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 24

JUDOKA TULIKA Maan, who had won silver at the 2022 Commonwealth Games, has been withdrawn from the ongoing edition in Glasgow after being provisionally suspended by the National Anti-Doping Agency (NADA) for three whereabouts failures in the last 12 months. It is a second blow for the Indian judo team for the Games, with Arun Kumar earlier being suspended by the NADA.

According to PTI, Tulika had made three whereabouts failures in a 12-month period. Under the World Athletics Anti-Doping (WADA) rules, any combination of three whereabouts failures — filing failure and/or missed test — within a period of 12 months constitute an anti-doping rule violation.

One of the most decorated judokas in the country, Tulika had made an exit in the round of 32 at the 2024 Paris Olympics. She had won silver in the -73kg category at the 2022 Commonwealth Games.

This is third case of doping that has hit the Indian contingent since the Games have started. Earlier, Arun Kumar, a judoka participating in the -73kg category, was removed from the judo squad after he was provisionally suspended by the National Anti-Doping Agency (NADA).

Hours after Kumar's suspension, it was revealed that another Indian athlete, weightlifter Dilbag Singh, would return from Glasgow — although for no fault of his own.

Indian weightlifting has reported five positive cases during the period of June 1, 2025, to July 22, 2026. Consequently, India's athlete quota was slashed from 16 to 11.

The sports ministry had approved a 191-member contingent, including 126 athletes.



India checks in

Weightlifter Mirabai Chanu (L) and boxer Lovlina Borgohain carry the flag as they lead the Indian contingent during the opening ceremony of the Commonwealth Games. **PI**

BEYOND DIPRA'S PRODUNOVA

India's gymnasts bet on getting the basics right

Shivani Naik
Mumbai, July 24

GYMNASTS SPEAK about the bubble of fearlessness that coaches conjure around them, before they go leaping into unknowns. The assured faces hide storms within.

"The 2014 Glasgow bronze medal was memorable because it was the first time I stuck a landing on the Produnova. My coach told me I would," Dipa Karmakar recalls of a sunny late Glaswegian afternoon when magic began weaving for Indian women's gymnasts.

"I'm sure the new girls are going to change the colour of the Indian medal on vault," she says, passing on the baton, wrapping in the same glaze of confidence that is necessary for a gymnast to hear, before take-off, when it defies reality even.

Balance is linked to ears, and Dipa has confidently whispered the message that she believes in their abilities, into ears of Pranati Nayak, Eshita Rewale, Nishka Agarwal and Protistha Samanta who were all picked based on their vault strength as India mounts a medal challenge at 2026 Glasgow.

Unlike Dipa, the four Indians now are not attempting terrifying vaults. But finding brilliance in basics, when judges are not blown by the nerveless execution of bravado, is difficult by itself. It's the evolution Dipa is getting behind, as the totem of the sport.

Pranati, big hope

Tokyo Olympian Pranati has thrice medalled at Asian Cham-

Vaulters go to Glasgow chasing not daring but precision, as Dipa Karmakar passes the baton to a generation built on Tsukaharas and Yurchenkos rather than high-risk tumbles



Pranati Nayak is set to go with Tsukahara 360 and a Handspring Forward Pike 360 at the CWG. **PI**

pionships, so consistency is her currency, even as she manages ankle troubles. She has lived like a monk at Odisha's high performance centre, leaning on sports science.

She picks vaults working within her fitness confines, so she is slated to go with a Tsukahara 360 and a Handspring Forward Pike 360, a 360 being a single rotation.

Though she will be assured of a 4.4 Difficulty score on the Tsukahara, the block on the table remains the crucial element to pull it off.

Scoring high and clean on execution is her plan to get into the finals. The Tsukahara vault demands maturity and strength that Pranati has, and

minimising deductions is the trick to get into the Top 8.

Yurchenko choice

The gymnast attempting a tougher one is Nishka Agarwal, who has shadowed Pranati for years. If coach Manoj Rana can inject enough confidence, she will go for a Yurchenko with a D-score of 5.0.

Her movement alignment and technique are sturdy, and she tends to cop fewer angular deductions. If she can land the double twist, she can go up to 13.8, while the Tsukahara for a 4.4 D-score can take her to 13.1, averaging out in ideal circumstances.

Yurchenko is an entry-level vault, attempted by half the

Finding brilliance in basics, when judges are not blown by the nerveless execution of bravado, is difficult by itself.

field. A round-off onto the springboard is step one. A back handspring onto the vault table is step two. India's only other CWG medalist, Ashish Kumar, explains: "The back lift-off from floor is biomechanically easier to lead to saltos or twists from the vault thereafter - 360, 540, 720. Three-four Indians have now logged a long journey on the vault," says the 2010 daredevil from Delhi Games.

The Tsukahara is tougher than Yurchenko because you need strength for the round-off on the springboard. "The English are landing them perfectly even if it's half a twist less," he says of the recent Yurchenkos. But someone like Protistha, who shadowed Dipa in her early years, has that necessary strength for a 2014 encore. "Everything is about perfect landing," Rana reminds.

Why vault

Dipa's fourth place at the Olympics spawned a dozen dreams. Anura Reddy became the first Indian gymnast to win a World Cup medal, on vault.

Pranati has since added Asian Championship medals of her own.

The history has science behind it. India, never a gymnastics nation, has chosen vault and maxed it out for a simple reason. Despite the risk, the acrobatic aerials and the speed, a vault is judged on only two execution skills, one for each vault, while the rest of the apparatus get marked on seven skills each, over lines, passes, elements, dismounts and more.

Nationals gold medalist Eshita Rewale from Mumbai has stuck to two basics, a Tsukahara 360 and a Yurchenko stretch. A lightweight, springy athlete, Eshita will look to nail the rudimentary routines.

Competition check

The biggest name on vault that Pranati and co will be up against is Canadian Lia Monica Fontaine, a 2025 World Championships silver medalist on vault, debuting here.

The debutant joins power-speed bullet Ellie Black at her fourth Games.

Defending champion Georgia Godwin returns from a full rupture of her Achilles tendon sustained before the Paris Olympics.

An all-rounder who has an eponymous skill on uneven bars named after her, the Australian has said she still struggles with phantom pain. She has since earned a degree in medical imaging, and is writing a gymnastics storybook.

England's Abigail Martin is a fiery contender, while Welsh sisters Abigail and Emily Ropers are vault specialists.



King Charles (C) and Queen Camilla step out of the Doctor Who Tardis police box as cyclist Chris Hoy looks on. **AP**

The king makes an entry, but not quite James Bond style

THERE WAS no parachute jump from a helicopter by the Queen and Mr. Bond. The 2026 CWG spin off of the dramatic royal entry at the 2012 London Olympics was restrained. In place of the most famous fictional secret agent was six-time Olympic medal winning cyclist Chris Hoy, who is battling cancer, and Scottish actor and writer Greg McHugh.

The centrepiece of the entry film, the now less common but once ubiquitous police box, which entered pop culture as the Tardis, Doctor Who's time machine. Small on the outside but large on the inside, the reel version of the police box is a bit of a starship. The Glasgow link to the original police box, which actually had a phone to get in touch with the station and a mini office space inside for quick paperwork, is Gilbert Mackenzie Trench, an architect from Scotland. He came up with its design and also served as the chief architect of the police force in London. The Tardis, which has a mind of its own, or a sixth sense as to where the Doctor should be, played its part in the opening ceremony film, which set the mood for

the actual entry at the stadium. A couple of off-target stops later Hoy and McHugh reach Balmoral where the royal couple join them. Of course, they are magically transported to The Hydro.

From the yellow-light-lit cabin emerged Hoy, then McHugh and finally King Charles and Queen Camilla. Credit to Charles for being game by shading his eyes to look into the distance to figure out where he had been transported to. He waved and wore a slight smile too, a way better performance than the Queen who looked like she had a bad hair day when he walked into the Olympic Stadium in London. Can't blame her though. The air from the helicopter rotor blades might have messed with her mood.

Yet, nothing beats the classy Daniel Craig, in a sharp suit, chaperoning the queen in a chopper over the London skies with the Bond soundtrack playing. 'Good evening Mr Bond' delivered nonchalantly by the queen was a smooth dialogue delivery with more recall value than any of the 'I declare the Games open' lines over the years. **ENS**



Actor Sam Heughan raises his hand to touch a life-size model of the mythical Loch Ness Monster during the opening ceremony. **PI**

Loch Ness Monster spotted

ONE OF Scotland's most enduring legends made an appearance in Glasgow as the Loch Ness Monster — affectionately known as Nessie — emerged from a CGI recreation of Loch Ness, the vast freshwater lake in the Scottish Highlands that has been linked to mysterious monster sightings for nearly a century.

The mythical creature, which has featured in Scottish folklore for generations and become one of the country's most recognisable cultural icons, made contact with Outlander star Sam Heughan inside the Hydro. Dressed in a grey kilt, the Scottish actor walked across the Celtic knot stage with his arms outstretched before gently touching Nessie's nose as she rose from the digital loch to the delight of the crowd. **ENS**

Scotland and the pipers entry

THE HOME team received the loudest welcome of the night, with a thunderous roar echoing around the Hydro as the athletes made their way around the stage. Scottish flags rippled through the stands as thousands of fans rose to their feet. The only sound capable of cutting through the cheers was the unmistakable skirl of the Great Highland bagpipes. Dozens of pipers flooded the stage and lined the aisles, creating a wall of sound that has accompanied Scottish celebrations, military ceremonies and sporting occasions for centuries.

Few instruments are more closely associated with Scotland, and as the massed pipers and drums filled the arena, the home nation's entrance felt every bit ceremonial. **ENS**

• RISING STAR

World Cup final: Silver in a field of Olympic champs makes Sainyam's best day

Nitin Sharma
Chandigarh, July 24

SAINYAM VIJ was tenth after qualification. The final she walked into afterward had an Olympic champion, a reigning world number one, and two Chinese shooters on home soil. By the time it ended, the 22-year-old from Chandigarh had beaten all but one of them.

Shooting a final score of 243.4 at the Fuyang Yin Sports Centre in Hangzhou on Friday, Sainyam finished 0.2 points behind China's Yao Qianxun, the world number one, to win silver, her second senior international

medal after a silver at last year's ISSF World Cup Final in Doha.

"Whenever I shoot, I don't shoot with the idea of whom I am competing against or whether she is an Olympic champion," she told *The Indian Express* from Hangzhou. "Whether it's China or Korea, my competition is only with myself." She started the final poorly, a first series of 497 that left her fifth.

The second series turned it: a 51.9, the best of the eight shooters in the field, put her level at the top with Qianxun. She stayed inside the top two through the eliminations that

followed, trailing Qianxun by 0.6 points heading into the final series before closing with a 10.6 and a 10.7, better than Qianxun's own 10.3 and 10.4, but not enough to close the gap. Reigning Olympic champion Oh Yejin, of Korea, finished last.

"I understood that my first series did not go well and I should not focus on what has happened," Sainyam said. "There was some difference in lighting in qualification as compared to the final range, and I knew I had to adjust. The key for me was to believe in what I have been doing in training. Post the silver medal in Doha, I had some



"Whenever I shoot, I don't shoot with the idea of whom I am competing against or whether she is an Olympic champion. ...my competition is only with myself."
SAINYAM VIJ

Sainyam Vij after clinching a silver medal in the women's 10m air pistol. **NEAU**

low scores, but I knew I had to keep having belief in my process, and that worked for me today. Coach Samresh Jung has always told me to believe in the process, and that's the winning mantra for me."

Sainyam started shooting after watching her brother Akarshan train, and gave up on a career in medicine to follow him into it.

She is a former junior Asian and junior world champion. She missed out on next month's Asian Games squad after NRA's trials, with the federation's 30-shooter quota already filled by Esha Singh and

Manu Bhaker across the 10m and 25m pistol events. Asked how it feels to compete against Bhaker and Singh, and against Phogat, for a place in the Indian team, Sainyam returned to the same idea that had carried her through the final.

"I have never thought about competing for my spot in the Indian team. I have only thought about shooting and how I can improve," she said. "Yes, I wanted to compete in the Asian Games, but that's shooting. My aim is to win the Olympic quota for India at the World Championships in Doha later this year."

NO ROLE CLARITY

Ton that solved nothing: India's Rohit dilemma, by the numbers

A 34th ODI hundred at Lord's kept the debate alive. What comes next, an anchor, an aggressor, or a clean break, is a choice India can no longer defer

Lalith Kalidas
New Delhi, July 24

INDIA HAVE lost six of the nine away ODIs they have played under head coach Gautam Gambhir. Rohit Sharma, India's highest run-scorer and the only centurion in overseas ODIs outside Asia in this period, remains the batter closest to losing his spot. Nudging 40, age appears to have become the defining metric of Rohit's readiness. Not the runs or range of his batting, Rohit is the only opener to aggregate over 1000 runs since last year and is India's highest run-scorer in ODIs since the 2023 World Cup.

A run of five innings without a fifty was enough for conversations around retirement and succession to gather pace mid-way through this year. A cold snub when the selectors meet again for the next selection in September cannot be ruled out.

Rohit has not thrown in the towel yet. His blockbuster 34th century in the series decider against England at Lord's last Sunday confirmed as much.

But lost beneath India's eventual 27-run defeat in a colossal 388 chase was the true purpose of Rohit's century itself. The conflicting nature of it, the quality of having to play for one's spot and the collective outcome, a situation thrust upon him by the management just a year out from the next World Cup.

Between losing his cap-

taincy within two series of a Champions Trophy win under coach Gambhir and settling back to life solely as an opener, India are presented with three choices regarding Rohit.

The first: persist with the anchor. The century at Lord's was a throwback to the Rohit of the previous decade, the devastating accumulator who could bat deep and bat big. A premium on big knocks has prompted his fallback to cautious starts. Not by design, but his place increasingly depends on it.

The second: restore the aggressor. The shift toward anchoring has almost obscured the version from 15 months ago, a brutal aggressor who nearly batted India to a World Cup win and spearheaded a tricky chase in the Champions Trophy final.

The third: involves the idea of Rohit altogether, asking whether India should instead hand over the reins to Yashasvi Jaiswal alongside captain Shubman Gill.

Should the selectors move on, India will miss Rohit's sixes and aggression, the only proven shape-shifter in a lineup of elite anchors in the top-middle order.

If they lock in Rohit as a certainty, the tempo of his and Gill's forthcoming partnerships will require recalibration. India's 147-run opening stand in the Lord's chase looked imposing, yet the required rates never truly came down. It rose above nine just before the partnership reached



Rohit Sharma scored 138 runs off 118 balls in the third ODI at the Lords. CREMAS/BCCL

three figures, stayed there through Gill's dismissal on 74 and Rohit's 84-ball century, and climbed beyond 11 by the time he departed for 138. India eventually needed 126 off 11 overs, a bridge too far for a middle-order that lacked the explosiveness Rohit could summon to upend attacks.

Uncertain future

The uncertainty isn't merely over Rohit's future. It extends to what batting philosophy India's core group still believes in. What India have is an accumulation-heavy quartet in Gill, Kohli, Iyer and KL Rahul. With his 110-ball 138, Rohit has shown he can still expand that bracket, and also remain the outlier for his innate attacking strengths in the Powerplay, should India choose to unshackle him.

Between the start of 2023 and the Champions Trophy final in March 2025 that

marked Rohit's last innings as captain, Gill and Rohit combined for 214 runs at the best of a 69.2 run rate, the best combination for all opening partnerships. Over 73 percent of those runs (1533) came in the first Powerplay (overs 1-10). Rohit contributed 60 percent of the runs (921) at a manic 122 strike rate. Gill collected 558 at 94.

Post the captaincy switch, the scoring rate has plummeted to 5.71, a conspicuous drop-off that cannot be ignored for a batting group that inherently bore no weakness, save the absence of a left-hander in the top six. Gill's outputs have remained identical in both periods, his Powerplay share continuing at 97.

The slowdown has come almost entirely from Rohit, whose strike rate in the first ten overs has fallen by 42 points, from 122 to 80. It hasn't meant the pair have lasted longer either. They have batted past

the 10th over thrice in the last 10 innings, with Powerplay averages dropping by 20 runs (from 86.3 to 67.9) from the two preceding years.

Rohit nevertheless remains the premier six-hitter in the side. At Lord's, he surpassed Chris Gayle for most sixes (94) struck past the age of 36 in the format. He has hit 38 maximums since last year, level with the next two players in the Indian line-up.

With months between assignments, the lingering absence of role clarity does not temper the load on Rohit, nor the top-order players around him. India must make their choice now. Persist with an anchoring Rohit at the expense of variety. Restore the aggressor who transformed India's ODI batting through the last World Cup cycle. Or move on from nearly 12,000 runs of experience in pursuit of a newer, untested approach.

The reluctant president: Anand to run FIDE for two months

Amit Kamath
Mumbai, July 24

IN A strange turn of events for Viswanathan Anand, the five-time world champion finds himself as the man running FIDE, the global governing body of chess. Strange, because just five days ago, Anand was explaining why he was voluntarily stepping back from active administration. Anand said he had opted not to run as the Deputy President in Arkady Dvorkovich's re-election campaign. Anand's current term as the second-in-command of Dvorkovich would end when the elections are held during the Olympiad in Samarkand in two months' time.

Anand's reasoning for not wanting to continue in a role he has held since 2022 was simple: "I simply wanted to have more time at home. My son will probably go to university in three years, I thought these are the years I should be here. That was a big motivation to get a different role. But I am still very much part of the team."

But now, in a quirk of fate, for the next two months at least, Anand finds himself more front and centre of the global governing body than ever. On Thursday, sanctions from the European Union became public which made Dvorkovich's position as FIDE president untenable. The Russian has consequently stepped aside as president, meaning Anand is now the interim president of the global governing body of chess.

The sanctions against Dvorkovich mean he is out of running for a third term as FIDE president. In a statement to The Indian Express, Dvorkovich said: "The sanctions are completely unjustified, unfair and based on political characterisations rather than a proper assessment of my personal and professional conduct. The only reason for sanctions is to prevent me from running and



Five-time World Champ Viswanathan Anand.

serving for FIDE. I reject political allegations being presented as an established fact and will challenge them through every available legal process."

Timur Turloy, the CEO of Freedom Holding, had been named on Dvorkovich's ticket as a Deputy President contender. Anand, meanwhile, had said that he would be part of Team Dvorkovich, but without running for Deputy President role. Now, with Dvorkovich out of the running, it remains to be seen if Anand will get convinced to run for another term.

The deadline to name the president and deputy contenders is on Sunday, July 26. Ukraine-born German Wadim Rosenstien (with Gordon Tang as his running mate) and Jan Henric Buettner (Malcolm Pein as Deputy) have announced their intention to run for FIDE President. In his role as the Interim President, Anand is likely to preside over the decision to award hosting rights for the FIDE World Championship at the end of this year where Gu- kesh will defend his title against Uzbekistan's Javokhir Sindarov.

"Following the decision by President Arkady Dvorkovich to suspend the exercise of his duties, and in accordance with

the FIDE Charter, I have assumed the responsibilities of Interim President," Anand posted on X.

"I want to thank Arkady for his leadership and for putting the interests and stability of FIDE first. Together with the FIDE Council, the administration and our member federations, my focus will be on ensuring continuity and serving the global chess family. FIDE's work continues. Arkady has built a strong team and vision and I today take it as our collective responsibility to carry the work forward."

Dvorkovich hit back

Hit with the sanctions, Dvorkovich, who had been Russia's deputy prime minister before he took over the FIDE presidency, opted to step aside.

In written comments shared with The Indian Express, Dvorkovich slammed the sanctions and questioned their timing. "The sanctions are completely unjustified, unfair and based on political characterisations rather than a proper assessment of my personal and professional conduct," Dvorkovich said. "The only reason for sanctions is to prevent me from running and serving for FIDE."

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